

The Half Apple

Finding a Father in God When Mine Walked Away

Bill Ray Majors

*The eternal God is your refuge,
and underneath are the everlasting arms.*
— Deuteronomy 33:27

Dedication

To my mother,
who stayed.

You gave your life to raise your four children—
quietly, faithfully, without asking for anything in return.
Your love was not loud, but it was constant;
not often spoken but lived every day.

You were forty-two when I left Oklahoma for Korea.
Three times you made the long journey across the world—
for our wedding, for the birth of our daughter Anna,
and once more, when we gathered for Resurrection Sunday in
2008.

You were nearly seventy then,
and you said the distance was too far to travel again.

So now we come to you.

And still, you walk on
with the quiet strength
that has always carried you.

More than anything,
thank you for showing us how to love—
not by words alone,
but by the life you lived before us.

You stayed.

And through you,
we learned that Father God stays too.

Preface

This is not a story I set out to write.

For most of my life, I was simply living it—one step at a time, often without understanding where those steps were leading. Looking back, I can see a pattern. At the time, I could not.

What I remember most are not the plans, but the moments.

A half apple in a lunch box.

A door that did not open again.

A calling I could not explain.

A country I did not understand.

A fall I cannot remember.

And a presence that never left.

This book is not an attempt to make sense of everything.

It is an attempt to tell the truth about what happened—and what remained.

There are parts of this story that are clear, and parts that are not. There are moments I remember in detail, and others I know only through what came after. But underneath all of it, there is something that has not changed.

God was there.

Not always in ways I recognized at the time.

Not always in ways I would have chosen.

But always present.

I did not plan this life.

I followed.

Sometimes with confidence.

Sometimes with questions.

Sometimes simply because I did not know what else to do.

If there is a thread that holds this story together, it is not my understanding. It is God's faithfulness.

This is a story about loss, but it is not defined by loss.

It is a story about calling, but not one I controlled.

It is a story about a father who left—and the Father who did not.

If you find yourself somewhere in these pages—
in the questions, in the uncertainty, in the waiting—
I hope you will also see what I have come to see.

That underneath it all,
there are everlasting arms.

And they do not let go.

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The Half Apple

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Chapter One

The Half Apple

The first thing I remember about my father is an apple.

Not a whole one. Half. He would come through the door after work, lunch box in hand, and inside that box there was always something left — half an apple, the last bite of a sandwich, a square of chocolate broken off and saved. He did it on purpose. We knew he did it on purpose. And we would wait for it the way children wait for Christmas morning, except this came on any ordinary day, or the days he came home at all.

My mother would take whatever he had saved and cut it into three pieces. One for my sister Cheryl. One for my brother Bobby. One for me. We ate like we had not seen food in a week, though we had. That was not the point. The point was that Daddy had thought of us. Somewhere between the morning he left and the evening he returned, he had held something back from himself and carried it home.

I was three years old. Maybe four. I did not have words for what that felt like.

I still don't, really.

What I know now, looking back across more than sixty years, is that my father had something real in him. Something that loved us. But love without commitment is just a feeling passing through. He was a boy who never grew into a man — never learned that the people who need you are not optional,

not something you return to when it is convenient, not something you leave behind when something else catches your eye or the law catches up with you. He could save half an apple. He could not stay.

He was not home much. And then one day he was not home at all.

But before he was gone entirely, there are two things I remember.

The first is a horse.

My father had gotten hold of a horse — not a pony, a real horse — and was keeping it somewhere with a yard large enough to ride within a fence. I was three, almost four. He put me up on the horse's back and walked in front, hands on the reins, letting me feel the movement and the height and the terror and thrill of being that far off the ground. I was doing well. The horse was doing well. I felt safe because he was right there, leading.

Then he decided to make it more interesting. He began to jog.

The horse, going around the house, got faster than my father's jog. For whatever reason — maybe he stumbled, maybe he misjudged — he let go of the bridle. And the horse kept going. Around the corner of the house, faster now, just the horse and me, no hands on the reins, no father in front. I was alone up there and terrified and not watching and the horse was going too fast and I came off.

I hit the ground and started crying. My father heard it and came running around the house and found me — scared but not seriously hurt. He looked at me. And then he decided this was the moment to teach me something.

He lifted me back up and put me back on the horse.

I did not want back on the horse. I was crying and I refused. But he was stubborn and he was stronger than me and he insisted — because he believed if I did not get back on immediately, I would never get on a horse again. He was trying to build something in me. Courage. The refusal to let fear be the last word.

I don't remember the outcome. I'll never forget the experience.

What I know now that I did not know then is that he was not wrong about the principle. Get back on. Don't let the fall be the end of the story. He was teaching me something real, the way fathers teach real things, with his hands and his stubbornness and his certainty that the lesson mattered more than the fear.

He just did not stay long enough to see if it worked.

* * *

The second story I did not experience — I was told it, more than once, by the people who lived it.

By this time Bud was gone for days at a stretch. My mother was already managing alone — four children, no income beyond what came in from outside, no husband reliably present. That was the household Bobby, and I slipped away from one afternoon without permission.

Bobby was five. I was four. A neighborhood boy — older than both of us — appeared and told us he was going to the store. He would buy us something if we came with him.

We followed him out of the yard. Farther from the house than we had ever been. I do not remember if we made it to the store or if he bought us anything, because what I remember — what was told to me — is what came next.

The boy left us somewhere. Too far from home. Walking back, Bobby and I found ourselves under an overpass. There

was a concrete slope — steep, the kind you could climb up and feel the cars thundering above your head and see the road below. We climbed it. We sat there. And we noticed there were stones around us.

If you let a stone roll on a steep concrete slope, it accelerates. If you throw a stone from up there, it arrives at the road below with remarkable force and remarkable speed. We discovered this. We applied this discovery enthusiastically to the passing cars below.

We hit a police car.

The car slowed. It stopped. It began to back up. We were suddenly aware that we had made an error in judgment.

The officer got out. He told us to come down. We came down. He asked us where we lived. We did not know how to tell him — we were four and five years old and too far from home to have an address available. He put us in the back seat. He radioed something in. We did not understand the radio. He drove.

We were sweating. He told us not to be afraid. We were afraid anyway.

He pulled up to our house. Our mother was outside. She had been looking for us for some time — checking the yard, checking the neighbors, sending Cheryl to look, going around the house repeatedly finding nothing. She was alone with four children, one of them a baby, and two of them had simply disappeared. She had called the police. She had reported two small boys missing. And the police had found them, as it turned out, because those two small boys had thrown a rock at a police car.

She scolded us. She hugged us. She was so glad to see us that the scolding and the hugging happened almost

simultaneously, which is a particular kind of love that only mothers produce.

The difficulties of being essentially alone with four children include the specific difficulty of two boys who follow strangers out of the yard and throw rocks at police cars from underpasses. She managed that difficulty the way she managed everything. She held it together. She found us. She brought us home.

We did not do it again. At least not that thing.

I was four years old when my father stopped coming through that door. And with him went the lunch box, and the apple, and the waiting.

My mother never stopped cutting things into pieces for us. She just had to find different things to cut.

* * *

Her name was Ellen Mary Jane Maxwell, though everyone who loved her called her Mary. She had grown up in the country — Oklahoma red dirt, oil fields, small churches, the kind of life where you learned early that nothing comes easy and everything worth having requires your hands. She was not a complicated woman. She did not want complicated things. She wanted a family. She wanted to be a good wife and a good mother, and she wanted her life to matter to God. That was the whole of her dream, and it was such a simple dream, and life made it so terribly hard to hold.

She married young — too young, most would say, though she would not say it herself. She married a boy from Wichita named Bud who drove down to Stillwater on weekends to see her, who wanted her completely, who could not wait. She said yes because she loved him and because the life she wanted seemed to be standing right there in front of her asking to begin. They were married at a small church on August 17, 1957. She was eighteen years old.  [view photo](#)

The dream started coming apart almost immediately.

I will not dwell long on what Bud was and was not, because this is not his story and he does not deserve more pages than he earned. What I will say is this — he was in and out of her life the way weather is in and out of Oklahoma. Unpredictable. Sometimes warm, sometimes dishonest and deceptive, always temporary. There were other women. There was gambling. There was theft, then prison, then more theft, then more prison. There were months of silence and sudden appearances and promises that dissolved before they were finished being spoken.

And through all of it, my mother kept making a home.

She cleaned houses to feed her children when there was no other income. She stood in welfare lines with her head up. She borrowed seven dollars a week from her mother-in-law for groceries and paid it back when she could. She moved from apartment to apartment — eight different homes in the first five years of marriage — carrying her children and her few belongings each time, setting up a new kitchen, making it work.

The government sent a welfare check once a month. It was not enough. She made it enough.

She learned to sew in high school and used that skill throughout her life. But the Easter in that photograph was different. Bud had left an uncashed check — money he had never collected for himself — and Mary felt it was right to spend it on her children. That one Easter, she bought them all new clothes. The boys in matching suits with ties. Cheryl in a dress with ruffles and a white hat. Mitchell, the baby, carried in arms that had learned to carry everything. It was one of the few times she could give them something new, bought rather than made, and she enjoyed every moment of getting things for each of them.

The boys are in matching suits. I am on the left, grinning. I was always grinning. Bobby is on the right, serious, already carrying something heavier than a seven-year-old should carry. Cheryl is proud in her hat. Mitchell is bewildered and beautiful in the middle.

There is no father in the frame.  [view photo](#)

But everything in that picture — every button, every pressed lapel, every carefully made ruffle — was put there by the woman standing in the back with her hands on her baby and her eyes still counting, still making sure.

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I said she was not a complicated woman, but I want to be careful with that. Simple is not the same as shallow. The roots of a tree are simple in their purpose — they go down, they hold, they feed — but try pulling one up and you will understand that simple things can run very deep.

Mary's faith was like that. She had loved God since she was a girl in the country, attending small churches in the Oklahoma oil fields. She had not been taught much theology. Nobody sat her down and explained the Holy Spirit or the deeper workings of grace. She just knew that Jesus was real, that the Bible was true, and that her life belonged to Him whether it was going well or falling apart.

She showed her faith the way she showed her love — with her hands, not her words. She was not a woman who made speeches about God. She was a woman who tithed on a welfare check. Who loaded four children onto a church bus every Sunday without fail. Who knocked on strangers' doors on Saturday afternoons with candy and an invitation. Who showed up every time the church doors opened because the church was not just a building to her — it was the community that kept her family alive.

And she sang.

Not on a stage. Not for an audience. She sang the way breathing happens — because she could not help it, because something inside her needed to come out. She sang in church with the congregation. She sang doing laundry. She sang loading children onto the bus. Her voice was not extraordinary. What was extraordinary was what was behind it. There was joy in her singing that had no business being there — no earthly explanation for it, no logical source given everything she was living through. We children teased her for it sometimes, the way children tease their parents for things they do not yet understand.

We did not understand it then. We did not know that you cannot manufacture that kind of joy. It does not come from circumstances. It comes from a source that circumstances cannot touch.

She had a name for that source. She called it Jesus.

What she did not know — what nobody had taught her yet — was that the Holy Spirit was living inside her all along. She found that out later, when her children were grown, and she said that she wished someone had told her sooner. Wished someone had explained the presence she had been carrying for decades without knowing its name.

But here is what I have come to believe: she did not need the name to have the thing. The Holy Spirit was working in Mary long before Mary had the theology for it. That joy in her singing was not manufactured. That strength in her hands was not her own. That refusal to be destroyed — that was not stubbornness, though it looked like stubbornness from the outside.

That was grace, doing what grace does. Holding a person up when they have every reason to fall.

* * *

The hardest season came after Bud left for the last time.

I was four years old. My sister Cheryl was six, my brother Bobby was five, and my baby brother Mitchell had just been born. Four children. No father. No income beyond what the government provided. My mother was twenty-four years old.

She lost a pregnancy somewhere in those years — another baby that never came home. She has spoken of coming back from the hospital to an empty house, or a house full of small children who needed feeding and had no idea what their mother had just lost. She has spoken of how her arms felt when she walked through that door. Empty in a way that had nothing to do with what her hands were or were not holding.

She had wanted to love that baby. She had been ready to love that baby with the same fierce, quiet, relentless love she poured into everything she did. And the baby was gone, and her arms did not know yet what to do with that absence.

A woman from the church came to her door. She brought a dish of meatloaf. There were shredded carrots in it — my mother had never seen carrots in meatloaf before. She has remembered that meatloaf for sixty years. Not because of the carrots. Because of the knock on the door. Because someone came.

That is what the church was to Mary Majors. Not a building. Not a doctrine. A knock on the door when your arms are empty and you do not know what to do with yourself.

* * *

I want to tell you something about empty arms, because it runs through this whole story like a river runs through a landscape — not always visible, but always shaping everything around it.

My mother's arms were empty in more ways than one. There was the miscarriage. There was the absence of a husband who should have been there to receive her love and was not. There was the end of each day when the children were finally in bed, and the house went quiet and she was alone with herself and tired in a way that sleep could not entirely fix. She was built to love with her hands — to feed and wash and sew and hold — and life kept removing the people she was made to hold.

She married again after Bud — a neighbor named Raymond, a quiet man who came into her life when her older children were nearly grown. He had never raised teenagers, and she had never had a man in the house telling anyone what to do, and the early years were not without friction. But Raymond stayed. He earned his place. They were married thirty-two years before he passed away, and in those thirty-two years he gave Mary something she had not had since she was eighteen years old and full of dreams — a husband who came home.

When Raymond died, Mary did not go looking for someone else. She was not interested. As far as she was concerned, she was still married. Raymond had earned that place in her life and nobody else was going to stand in it. She is his wife still, in the only way that matters to her.

That is not ordinary. That is not something a person does on their own.

I grew up watching that. A woman who kept pouring love into the world with no guaranteed return. Who sang with joy she had not earned and could not explain. Who turned a deadbeat husband's uncashed check into Easter clothes for four children and called it a good day. Who made meatloaf visits into a kind of theology, though she would never have used that word.

I grew up watching that, and somewhere along the way — I cannot tell you exactly when, exactly where, exactly how old I was — I decided. A quiet decision. The kind of decision that does not feel like a decision at the time but turns out to have been the hinge on which everything else swung.

I decided that I had a perfect Father.

Not the man with the lunch box. Not the man whose name appeared in newspapers under the headline * Coyle Bank Bandit Suspect Arraigned. * Not the man who put his hands up in a field in Oklahoma and dropped to his knees while the FBI stood over him. That man had loved me in his way; I believe that I still believe that — but he had also left. He had proved that human love, even real human love, could walk out a door and not come back.

God would not do that. I was certain of it in the way that children can be certain of things that take adults a lifetime to work out. God had made promises and God would keep them. God would provide. God would not abandon. Whatever hole my father had left in the shape of a father, God would stand in it.

That decision did not make everything easy. But it made everything possible.

And underneath it all — underneath the empty arms and the welfare checks and the Easter suits and the singing that had no business being joyful — underneath everything in this story, I have come to understand that something was already holding us.

There is a verse in Deuteronomy, the thirty-third chapter, the twenty-seventh verse. I did not know it as a boy. I would not encounter it until years later, on a graduation day in Chattanooga, Tennessee, when a stranger's organization gave a young missionary student a book with a sticker inside the cover,

and on that sticker, beneath a signature and a date, were these words:

The eternal God is your refuge, and underneath are the everlasting arms.

Underneath. Not beside. Not in front. Underneath.

When you have no floor left to stand on, you find out what is underneath.

My mother found out. Four children, no husband, a sewing machine and a welfare check and a song she could not stop singing. She found out what was underneath.

And so, in time, would I.

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Chapter Two continues...

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Chapter Two

I Am Going to Be a Missionary

There is a question that adults love to ask children and children hate to answer.

What are you going to be when you grow up?

They mean well. They are trying to show interest, trying to draw a child out, trying to imagine a future for the small person standing in front of them. But the child usually has no idea. The child is thinking about lunch, or the scab on his knee, or whether the dog is going to be in the yard when he gets home. The future is too far away to be interesting.

After that summer at Lake Texoma, I had an answer.

I am going to be a missionary.

I said it to every adult who asked, from the time I was thirteen years old until the day I left for Korea. I said it so many times that it became the expected answer, the thing Billy always said, the furniture of our family life. My mother heard it so often that I wonder sometimes if it stopped landing, the way a clock on the wall stops being heard after a while — you know it is ticking, you just stop noticing.

She noticed. She was always noticing. She was just waiting to see if I meant it.

That is the thing about my mother. She did not make a lot of noise about what she believed or what she hoped or what she feared. She watched. She listened. She kept her own counsel, and she waited to see what a person would do when the words ran out and the moment came to move.

I did not know she was watching. I was just answering the question.

* * *

But I am getting ahead of myself. Before Lake Texoma there was Oklahoma, and before Oklahoma can be left behind it has to be properly inhabited — because a boy is not only what he decides, he is also where he grew up, and where I grew up was loud and red-dirt poor and more alive than I knew at the time.

After my father disappeared for the last time, my mother moved us back to her parents in Stillwater, Oklahoma. Her father found a farmhouse on eight acres outside of town — close enough to reach in an emergency, far enough to build something that felt like a life. It was not much of a house. The roof leaked. There was no indoor bathroom at first, just an outhouse you had to reach in the dark with a flashlight, which meant that on many nights the flashlight stayed inside and other arrangements were made. The wind came through the walls in winter. A rat lived somewhere in the structure and had opinions about being disturbed.

But there were eight acres. And to four children with no father and limited options, eight acres was the whole world.

There was a pond — red water, because Oklahoma dirt is red and it stains everything it touches. You could swim in it if you did not mind your clothes coming out looking like you had been wrestling in clay. We did not mind. The pond was ours. There was a garden — potatoes, corn, okra — and a henhouse that gave us eggs, and a pig we raised from small and fed every

night with the dinner scraps, a pig that wagged when it saw us coming because it thought we were its friends. We knew what the pig did not know. That irony never entirely left me.

There were three Shetland ponies. Rowdy, who was white and unpredictable, who would let you ride him on good days and launch you skyward on bad ones. Trigger, who was young and fast — faster than anything I had been on before once he finally let you stay on him. And Midnight, who was black and half blind in one eye, which made him jumpy in ways that were educational if you survived them.

There was a dog named Tippy who ate the neighbor's chickens and had to be driven far away and abandoned, and who then walked all the way home on his own and was so wild with joy when he found us again that we had to get out of the car slowly for fear of being knocked over. Tippy never ate another chicken. I have always thought that experience taught him something about what he stood to lose. Some lessons only arrive through loss.

There were snakes. Once I was running through the pasture and jumped over what I thought was a stick lying across the path. I was in the air before I understood that it was not a stick. The rattlesnake coiled beneath me as I cleared it, and I landed on the other side and screamed, and my brother Bobby appeared from somewhere with a shovel and the problem was resolved. I was never certain afterward whether Bobby had been nearby already or whether the screaming had conjured him. Either way he came.

There was a cave, several miles from the farmhouse, on someone else's land, that we discovered on one of our wandering expeditions and told no one about for years. We called it the fort. We hid things there. We went there when we needed somewhere that belonged only to us.

I did not know then that I was poor. Not in the way that registers as a fact. I knew that we used food stamps at the grocery store and that I hated pulling them out at the register while people waited behind us, hated the way it marked us, hated the feeling of being seen as someone who needed the government's help to eat. I knew that our clothes were not new unless my mother made them. I knew that the farmhouse had smells and sounds that Jeff Rhoads' house did not have — and Jeff Rhoads' house had a father who came outside to throw the football, which was the most astonishing thing I had ever witnessed up close.

I remember standing in Jeff's yard watching his father throw a spiral and feeling something, I could not name. Not quite envy. Not quite grief. Something in between — a recognition of an absence so complete that seeing it filled in someone else's life was almost physical. That is what a father does. He comes outside. He throws the ball. He is simply there, in the yard, on a Tuesday afternoon, available.

I went home and did not say anything to anyone.

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The center of our life was not the farm. It was the church.

My mother made sure of that. She loaded us into whatever vehicle was available and got us to church every time the doors opened, and when she could not get us there herself, she found someone who could. The Robinsons came with their station wagon. The Toney's came. The bus ministry came. Someone always came. My mother had a way of making sure that the distance between us and the church was never long enough to be an excuse.

When Rev. Sam Stricklin started the bus ministry at Bible Baptist Church in Stillwater, my mother became the first bus captain. That meant she had her own route. On Saturday

mornings she would drive her circuit, stopping at houses, knocking on doors, reminding people that Sunday was coming and that there was a seat on the bus for them. She took us with her. We sat in the back while she knocked on strangers' doors and invited them to church with the same matter-of-fact warmth she used for everything — not pushy, not theatrical, just certain. Come on. There is a place for you. Come on.

I was embarrassed by it sometimes. The knocking on doors, the cheerful persistence. I did not understand yet that what she was doing required more courage than most adults could summon, and that she was doing it for love of people she had never met. I just wanted to go home.

The first pastor I remember knowing personally was Rev. Larry Stevenson — a man with quick eyes and an enormous voice who preached like the building might not be able to contain what he was saying. He loved the people in that small church with the kind of love that shows up and stays and gets involved in the details. His family and ours were tangled together in the way that families in small churches get tangled — dinners after Sunday services, children running through each other's yards, the slow comfortable knowledge that these people will be there when you need them. He had two sons who were a little older than me.

He had two sons close to our ages. I remember chasing them through the church yard, playing tag in the dark while the adults talked inside. I remember the feeling of being known by people who were not my family and did not have to show up and did anyway.

Then one Sunday he stood in front of the congregation and said that God had called him and his family to Mexico. They were leaving. They were going to be missionaries.

The church grieved. These were people who had built something together and now the builder was going. I sat in the pew at eight years old and listened and felt the sadness of the room settle over me, and then I had a thought that I could not shake.

Why would anyone leave? Why would anyone take everything they had built — their home, their people, their church family — and carry it to another country to start over? What in the world did it mean to be a missionary?

I did not have an answer. I filed the question somewhere and went back to being eight years old.

He went to Mexico. He spent ten years there. He built a church and then a Bible college. He learned Spanish and preached in it and led people to Jesus in it. He had not planned to do any of that. He had just said yes when God asked.

I did not know then that I was watching a preview of my own life. I just thought he was brave in a way I did not understand.

* * *

A new pastor came. Younger, athletic, full of plans, the kind of man who could coach a basketball team and preach a sermon and fix a broken bus engine and never seem to run out of either energy or ideas. He grew the church. He started a Christian school. He organized bus routes and door-to-door visiting and Saturday morning visitation and more activities than our small congregation had ever attempted. The church hummed with purpose under his leadership.

Rev. Sam Stricklin was with us for six years. Then God called him to Rhode Island, and he loaded his family into a car, and I stood at the edge of the road and watched him drive away, and for the second time in my young life I watched a man leave for a mission field and wondered what kind of person does that.

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The summer I was thirteen, a church member paid my way to a youth camp at Lake Texoma, on the Texas-Oklahoma border. I did not have the money to go. He did not make a production of paying for me. He just made sure I could go, the way people in churches sometimes do things quietly and completely, without needing to be thanked.

The camp was everything a thirteen-year-old boy could want. A roller rink. A swimming pool. Sports fields. And a concession stand that opened in the evenings where you could stand in line for a Dr Pepper and accidentally-on-purpose position yourself near girls from other churches. The evenings smelled like popcorn and possibility.

There were also required gatherings. Morning and evening, everyone assembled on a concrete slab under an open roof — hundreds of chairs in rows, a platform at the front, a piano and a podium. A music director who could play the trumpet like he was announcing something from heaven. By the second day we all knew the song he had been teaching us, knew it well enough to sing it in the shower, knew it well enough that when he lifted his trumpet and played the melody back to us, every person on that concrete slab felt something move in their chest.

The speaker that year was an American missionary. He had spent years overseas. He was a storyteller — the kind who makes you lean forward without knowing you are doing it. He told us about eating things he did not recognize and learning to pronounce sounds that had no equivalent in English and walking into villages where nobody had ever heard the name of Jesus and telling them anyway. He made it sound terrifying and thrilling and necessary.

On the last night he set down his notes and looked at us.

He said: I want to ask you something. I want you to think carefully before you answer. Do you believe God is calling you to be a missionary?

I was not going to raise my hand. I was sitting in the dark in a crowd of hundreds of teenagers, and I was not going to raise my hand and draw attention to myself and be the boy who raised his hand and nobody was going to see me, and I was not going to raise my hand.

My hand went up.

I did not decide to raise it. It went up the way something rises when it has been held underwater too long and finally breaks the surface. The question had reached something in me that was already there, already decided, already waiting for someone to ask directly enough to bring it out into the open.

I pulled my hand back down immediately. But it had been up. I knew it had been up. And whatever had sent it up was not going back where it came from.

The speaker said: if you raised your hand, I want you to come forward. I want to pray for you.

Standing up was the hardest thing I had done in thirteen years of living.

I do not know how I got to the front. I remember the light feeling different up there. I remember there were about ten of us standing together, which helped, though not as much as you might think. The speaker prayed over us with the kind of fervency that makes you feel the weight of what you have just agreed to. Then he said amen and I turned to go back to my seat and he stopped me.

Come back up here. Tell everyone what you have decided.

The microphone appeared in front of my face.

My eyes filled with tears. My face did what faces do when something too large is trying to come out of them — it twisted

and crumpled and stopped cooperating. I could not give a speech. I could not explain what had just happened to me because I did not fully understand it myself. All I could do was open my mouth and let the truest thing come out.

God wants me to be a missionary.

Then I walked quickly back to my seat. The worship finished. Everyone else headed for the concession stand, for the Dr Pepper and the popcorn and the girls from other churches.

I went to the cabin.

I threw myself face down on my bunk and pushed my face into the pillow and the tears came and would not stop. I was not sad. I was not frightened, not exactly. I was not regretting what I had done. I was crying because something had become real that had previously only been possible. I had just said yes to the rest of my life. I had agreed to go to a foreign country and learn a foreign language and find people who had never heard of Jesus and tell them. I had agreed to that at thirteen years old, lying face down on a bunk bed at a summer camp in Texas, with everyone else standing in line for Dr Pepper.

When the tears finally slowed, I lay still for a while in the dark.

I did not think about what my mother would say. I did not think about the details of how any of this would work. I did not even think about where I would go.

I just lay there with the certainty of it, which was heavy and clean at the same time, the way a decision feel when it is finally the right one.

* * *

In the years that followed, adults would ask me the question they always ask children.

Billy, what are you going to be when you grow up?

And I would answer.

I am going to be a missionary.

I said it at thirteen. I said it at fourteen and fifteen and sixteen. I said it when we moved to the city and I started at a new school and made new friends who did not know my history. I said it at college in Chattanooga when professors asked about my goals. I said it the same way every time — not dramatically, not as a testimony, just as a fact. The way you tell someone your name or where you are from.

I am going to be a missionary.

My mother heard me say it so many times that I wonder if it stopped sounding extraordinary to her. If it became just the thing Billy says — real in the way that familiar things are real, present in the way that furniture is present, noticed less the longer it sits in the same spot.

But she was listening. She was always listening. She was watching to see whether it would stick, whether this one would last, whether this decision would prove different from the ones that dissolved after three days and a return to ordinary life.

It stuck. I kept saying it. I graduated from college saying it. I was ordained saying it. I bought a one-way ticket to Seoul, South Korea saying it.

And then I was standing at the door with a suitcase.

And the words became a suitcase. And the suitcase became a door. And on the other side of that door was a country my mother could not follow me into, a distance her arms could not cross, a calling she had heard for eight years and now could not hold back.

She did not try to stop me. That is not who she was. She had raised me to know that God's call is not negotiable, and she was not going to spend her breath arguing with God at forty-two years old.

But she told me later what she did in that moment. What she did when her hands reached the end of what they could hold and she had to let go.

She gave me to Jesus.

The same Jesus she had been singing about since she was a girl in Oklahoma. The same Jesus who had been living in her without her knowing His name. The same Jesus who had reached down into a dark cabin at Lake Texoma eight years earlier and pulled the hand of a thirteen-year-old boy upward before the boy had finished deciding.

She gave me to that Jesus.

And what she did not know — what I perhaps did not fully understand myself until years later — was that she was not giving Him something new. She was returning something that had never entirely been hers to keep.

At thirteen, I had given myself.

At forty-two, she gave me back.

Eight years apart. The same person. The same open hands. The same Jesus.

Underneath are the everlasting arms.

* * *

Chapter Three continues...

* * *

Chapter Three

Bill

The summer I turned fifteen, I decided that nobody asked about, and nobody particularly noticed.

I stopped being Billy.

Not officially. Not with any announcement. I simply began introducing myself differently. New city, new church, new school — when someone extended a hand and asked my name, I said Bill. Bill Majors. It felt like something a person with a future would say. Billy was the boy on the farm catching grasshoppers for fishing bait and getting his arm caught in the wringer and throwing stones at passing cars from under a highway overpass. Bill was someone who knew where he was going.

I was going to be a missionary. I had known that for two years. The knowing had not faded the way other camp decisions faded — it had settled, the way something settles when it finds the place it was always meant to occupy. Every time an adult asked what I planned to do with my life I told them plainly and without drama. I am going to be a missionary. They smiled and nodded and moved on, the way adults do when a teenager says something that sounds like a phase.

It was not a phase. But I could not prove that yet. All I could do was keep saying it and keep meaning it and wait for my life to catch up to my answer.

Bethany, Oklahoma was where the catching up began.

* * *

Bethany sat right against the edge of Oklahoma City, divided from it by the middle of a street. The city had been founded by the Church of the Nazarene in 1909 and named after a town in the Bible, and even decades later the conservative influence of its founders still ran through the place like a current under water. There were no bars. There were no movie theaters. On Sundays the shops closed. The neighbors were friendly and private in equal measure, the kind of people who waved from their driveways and did not ask too many questions.

Our house was at 5917. To the east, an older man who spent his days in a workshop behind his house, building something or fixing something, always occupied, always quiet, always willing to offer a word if you approached him first. To the west, something more interesting — a grandmother who still drove her own car, a small red thing that she reversed out of the driveway with a confidence that the evidence did not support. Her son lived with her. He worked at a factory and came home to weld things in his garage and shoot arrows in his yard. He fixed neighborhood children's bicycles when they broke. He took my brother and me to shoot arrows along the banks of the Cimarron River.

He was getting friendly with us in a way that made my mother thoughtful. She did not say anything dramatic. She simply mentioned it to the pastor at our new church — Western Oaks Baptist Church — and asked if someone might visit the man next door.

Two men from the church knocked on his door. They sat with him and talked about ordinary things and then opened the Bible and walked him through what it said. He listened. He understood. He gave his life to Jesus that evening. From that day forward he grew in his faith and started attending church.

My mother had been doing this her whole life. Finding the person at the edge of things and quietly making sure someone came to them. She did not consider it extraordinary. It was just what you did when you belonged to something worth belonging to.

* * *

A teacher at the new school handed me an address and said she thought I should go visit a family that had just moved to Bethany from Chicago. The father was a pastor. They had a son my age. She thought we would get along.

I rode my bicycle to the address.

His name was Steve White. The teacher had been exactly right — we got along immediately, the way certain people get along when they recognize something in each other that they have not yet been able to name. He was from a pastor's family. I was headed to the mission field. We were both serious about our faith in the way that teenagers can be serious before the world has had enough time to complicate things. We became best friends that afternoon and we have been best friends ever since.  [view photo](#)

I did not know then that Steve would one day serve on the board of my ministry in Korea. I did not know that our friendship would outlast geography and decades and the ordinary attrition that takes most friendships apart. I just knew that I had found someone who understood what I was talking about when I talked about God, and that was not as common as you might think.

* * *

There was an older boy at church — seventeen or eighteen to my fifteen — who wore blue jeans and a white T-shirt and drove a yellow Jeep with a removable soft top. He was cool in the specific way that older boys are cool to younger ones, which is to say he did things without appearing to think about them and he was generous with his money and his time, and he treated me like a person worth knowing despite the age difference.

He had come to faith after a hard beginning — a stern father, a difficult home, the kind of childhood that leaves marks. But he had given his life to Jesus, and he was fully committed and he brought that same wholehearted energy to everything he did. We rode ten-speed bicycles to the 7-Eleven to play pinball. We drove down to Lawton to climb the Wichita Mountains and camp overnight. He paid for most of it without making it feel like charity.

He was a few years ahead of me in everything — in age, in experience, in the knowledge that comes from having been through things. I watched how he moved through the world, and I learned things I could not have articulated at the time but have never forgotten.

* * *

Oklahoma law allowed a fourteen-year-old to get a motorcycle license, limited to bikes of 125cc or smaller. I turned fourteen two months after arriving in Bethany and I had been watching the clock.

Down the street, someone had parked a 1950 Cushman Eagle with a For Sale sign on it. Fifty dollars. It was older than almost everything I owned, and it showed. It had a high gear and a low gear operated by a handle on the side of the gas tank. It rarely started. When it did start it rarely ran well. But my

brother and I stood in front of it and felt the motorcycle fever come over us and that was the end of our good judgment on the subject.

My brother got a 125cc Yamaha. I got a 125cc Honda. His was faster off the line. Mine went further on a tank of gas. We both needed money for payments and fuel, which meant we both needed jobs. I poured concrete in the summers — sidewalks, driveways, patios, the kind of work that requires your back and your legs and your arms and gives back soreness and calluses and the slow satisfaction of seeing something solid where there was nothing before. The baby fat I had been carrying since the watermelon-eating incident gradually departed. I grew taller. I grew harder. I started to look like someone who could carry what he had agreed to carry.

* * *

My mother remarried when I was in high school.

The man she married was Raymond, the neighbor to the west — the one who fixed bicycles and shot arrows and had come to faith through the visit my mother arranged. He was a simple man. That word is not a criticism. Simple men are often the best kind — they know what they value, they go to work, they come home, they do not require drama and do not create it unnecessarily. Raymond went to work and came home and provided for my mother and wanted to do right by her children.

We made it complicated.

Not on purpose. But four teenagers who had never had a man in the house telling them what to do, combined with a man who had never raised teenagers, was a combination that required patience from everyone involved and received it from almost no one. Raymond had been taught that a firm hand was part of good parenting. We had been raised by a woman whose

discipline came through patience and quiet expectation. These were not compatible systems, and the friction was real.

I was the most difficult. I will not pretend otherwise. I kept a wall between Raymond and me that I built so early and maintained so thoroughly that eventually I stopped seeing it as a choice and started seeing it as just the way things were. There was a space in me shaped like a father. My father had left when I was four years old and left that space empty. Raymond came and stood near it and I would not let him in.

It was not his fault. He was not the man who had made the wound. He was just the man standing closest to it, and I could not tell the difference.

One night it came to a head. Words were said that should not have been said — not by Raymond, not by me, probably not by anyone. My mother stood between us and kept us from being physical, which was the kind of thing she had been doing her whole life, placing her body between the people she loved and the damage they were capable of doing to each other. I was done. I was leaving. I got on my motorcycle, and I rode out into the dark.

I had nowhere to go. That was the truth of it, though I was not ready to admit it yet. I rode toward my uncle and aunt's apartment because it was the nearest place that would let me in without requiring explanations, and they did let me in, and they listened to what I had to say, and then without telling me they called my mother and told her I was there and I was safe.

What I did not know that night was what my mother was planning for the next day.

She came to the basketball game.

I was on the starting team. Homecoming game. I had not planned to miss it regardless of what happened with Raymond — I was fifteen years old and I had my priorities, and whatever

was happening at home, there was a basketball game tomorrow and I was going to be in it. My mother knew this. She came to the gymnasium, and she sat in the stands and when the game started, she cheered louder than anyone in the building.

Not loud because she was performing. Loud because she meant it. Loud in the way that people are loud when they are trying to reach someone across a distance that words cannot cross — when the only thing left is volume and presence and showing up and refusing to let the distance be the last thing said.

I heard her. Everybody heard her. We won the game. And when it was over I went home.

That was her answer to the fight. Not a lecture. Not conditions. Not a careful conversation about what I owed Raymond or what Raymond owed me. Just a woman in the stands cheering her son's name, louder than anyone, saying the only thing that mattered.

I am here. I see you. Come home.

* * *

I want to say something about Raymond that I did not say when I had the chance to say it to him directly, and that I carry as one of the genuine regrets of my life.

He was good to my mother. Faithful. Present. He came home every day. He provided. He stayed. For thirty-two years he was exactly what he promised to be and more than she had been given before. My siblings came to love him. My children called him Grandpa. He became, in every meaningful way, the father of our family.

I kept the wall up. I called him Raymond. I gave my daughters full freedom to love him as they chose, and I watched them build something with him that I could have built and did not. He was on the other side of the wall the whole time — close enough to touch, if I had reached.

I know what I would say to him now if I could.

Raymond, you have proven that you love our family. You deserve to be called the leader and father of this home. I want to call you Dad, if you will let me.

He would have let me. I know he would have let me. He was that kind of man.

The words were always available. I just never got around to saying them before he was gone. That is not Raymond's failure. That is mine. And I put it here not as punishment to myself but as truth — because a book about “being led by Jesus” ought to include the places where I dug in my heels and refused to be led, and this is one of them.

* * *

One more thing happened in the Bethany years that I have not told yet.

My father was still alive somewhere. I knew that. He had been in and out of prison since before I was born and I had not seen him since I was four years old, but he existed in the world and occasionally his name surfaced in newspaper headlines and family conversations. I wanted to find him. Not because I expected anything from him. I think I just needed to look at the man whose face I apparently wore and ask him one question.

My mother drove with me to Wichita. She stayed at my grandmother's house while I went to my aunt's. My aunt called my father. He was in Kansas City — a few hours away. He said to wait right there, he was coming. He needed to shower first. He would be right there.

We waited through the afternoon. We waited through the evening. Night came and my father did not. My aunt and I stayed up talking, and I finally fell asleep on the living room floor sometime in the early hours of the morning.

The doorbell woke me. I jumped up, disoriented, and ran to the bathroom — I do not know why, instinct perhaps, the need to collect myself before being seen. I left the door open. And in the mirror over the sink, I watched a man walk through the front door of my aunt's house.

He looked like me. Or I looked like him. The same face, rearranged by decades.  [view photo](#)

We spent six hours together. We ate. We played pool in my aunt's basement. We went out to look for pheasants. Mostly we talked — the first real conversation I had ever had with my father, which is a strange thing to say about a man whose blood I carry. I told him the few memories I had of him. The lunch box. The half apple. Waiting at the fence for him to come home from work.

He listened. He seemed moved, or something that looked like moved from the outside.

Then I asked him the question I had been carrying since I was four years old. We were walking through a field, looking for birds, and I stopped and looked at him and I asked it.

Why did you leave us?

He was quiet for a moment. Then he said: you may think badly of me. But I believe the things I have been through have made me a better person.

I did not know what to do with that answer. I stood there in the field with my father for the first time in more than a decade and I listened to him tell me that his experiences had improved him, and I thought about my mother cutting welfare cheese into equal portions and sewing Easter suits on a secondhand sewing machine and loading four children onto a church bus at seven in the morning, and I could not find a way to make those two things fit together in the same world.

I have thought about his answer many times since. I have become less satisfied with it each time.

He was not a monster. I want to be clear about that. He was a boy who never grew into a man — capable of tenderness, capable of love in small doses, fundamentally unable to stay. The half apple was real. The love in it was real. It just was not enough, and he did not know how to make it more, and he left.

I went back to Oklahoma. I finished high school. I went to college in Chattanooga. I kept saying what I had been saying since I was thirteen years old.

I am going to be a missionary.

* * *

At Western Oaks Baptist Church, the pastor ran a program for teenage boys who felt called to ministry. He gathered us and taught us to prepare a five-minute sermon and then stand up in front of the congregation and deliver it before the real sermon began.

I was fifteen years old and I was terrified.

Not the manageable kind of terrified that loosens once you start. The deep kind. The kind that makes your mouth go dry and your mind go blank and your legs feel like they belong to someone else entirely. I stood at that podium and wanted to be finished before I began. The only moment I enjoyed was sitting back down.

My sister Cheryl and my brother Bobby gave me a nickname: Billy Bible. I had been coming home from those preacher boy sessions with enough conviction to comment on their behavior, and they found this irritating, which was fair.

But the pastor was doing something I could not see at the time. He was teaching me that a calling is not only a feeling — it is a practice. That you show up even when you are afraid. That you open your mouth even when your voice is wrong and

your mind is blank and you would give anything to be somewhere else. That the discipline of doing the hard thing anyway is not separate from the calling — it is part of it.

I did not appreciate that lesson at fifteen. I have appreciated it every year since.

* * *

College came. Chattanooga, Tennessee. Tennessee Temple University.

I drove there in my Volkswagen Super Beetle with seventy-five dollars in my pocket, arriving a week before the dormitories opened, willing to sleep in my car if necessary. On Wednesday night I went to a church service and ended up sitting on the same pew as a missionary professor and his family. They found out I had nowhere to stay. They took me home. They fed me for a week while I looked for work.

I found a newspaper route — the Chattanooga Times, delivered before sunrise. But the job required two hundred and fifty dollars in advance to pay for the first month of papers. I would deliver all month, collect house to house at the end of the month, and keep what I earned. But I needed the two hundred and fifty dollars first, and I did not have it.

I called my paternal grandmother. Sarah Majors — my father's mother, the woman whose house I had visited in Wichita when I went looking for Bud. She worked at a laundry. She had been saving her money carefully the way people save when they do not have much. I explained what I needed and why.

She sent me two hundred and fifty dollars.

That money started the newspaper route. The newspaper route paid my tuition. It bought two cars — both tax deductible. It funded three years of college and left me with only a twenty-

five-hundred-dollar loan at graduation. It made possible everything that followed.

My father's mother — the mother of the man who had left — sent the money that allowed his son to go to Korea.

God threads things together in ways that take years to see clearly. This is one of them.

I delivered newspapers before sunrise for three years to stay enrolled.

One morning I had company.

Don Corley was one of twin brothers — Don and Ron Corley — who were missionaries from New Mexico. They had come to speak at our church in Stillwater when I was a little boy, and again when we moved to Bethany, and later at Tennessee Temple's chapel service and at Highland Park Baptist Church in Chattanooga. Don Corley had heard me say, as a boy, that I was going to be a missionary. He remembered that. When he came to speak at Tennessee Temple and saw me there as a college student, he sought me out. We had coffee. We talked. I told him about the newspaper route — up before sunrise every morning, delivering the Chattanooga Times, throwing papers from the window of a moving car.

He said — let me go with you.

I told him it was dark and early, and he would have to sit in the back seat of the Volkswagen and fold the papers and wrap them with rubber bands so I could throw them from the window while I drove. He would get no sleep. It was not glamorous work.

He said he would do it.

So, Don Corley, missionary speaker, got in the back seat of my Volkswagen Super Beetle before sunrise and folded newspapers and placed them in the front seat so I could grab and throw while I drove my route in the dark. He could have

been sleeping. He chose this instead — not because it was useful to him, but because it was useful to me, and he wanted to spend time with someone who was working.

I have never forgotten that. There is a kind of mentorship that happens on stages and in coffee shops, and there is a kind of mentorship that happens in the back seat of a Volkswagen before sunrise with rubber bands and newsprint on your hands. Don Corley gave me both.

He also came to Korea. He visited me at the orphanage and spent time with me and the children there. The man who had first heard me say I was going to be a missionary — as a boy in Oklahoma — came and stood in the orphanage in Korea where the missionary was living.

I know that nobody is perfect. But it seems that at times you meet somebody, and heaven seems to be shining through them — at least during the time you spend with them, in what they say and what they do and how they choose to spend their hours. That was Don Corley. And what I saw and heard and experienced with him has stayed with me.

There was another man who did the same thing — got in the back of the Volkswagen before sunrise and folded papers.

Rev. Sam Stricklin. The second pastor from Stillwater — the one who had taken his family to Rhode Island to plant a church in New England, the one I had watched drive away as a boy and wondered what kind of person does that. He had come to Tennessee Temple looking for Christian school teachers for his Rhode Island ministry. He found his former parishioner delivering newspapers before sunrise.

He met me at my car. He got in the back. We drove to the Chattanooga Times print shop together, picked up the papers, and he started folding and wrapping with rubber bands, placing them in the front seat as I drove my routes and threw from the

window. Five routes. Before sunrise. Sam Stricklin in the back seat.

He was always a good example of how to be a man of God. Not just in the pulpit — in the back of a Volkswagen at four in the morning, doing whatever needed doing, being present with a person who was working.

Two men. Different churches, different states, different mission fields. Both got in the car. Both folded the papers. Both showed me something about what it means to love someone by showing up where they are.

But first I had to get enrolled. And that required one more obstacle I had not seen coming.

After two or three days on the newspaper route, it was time to register for classes and get a dormitory key. I went through every station in the line set up for new students. The last stop was the business office. They informed me that twenty-five percent of my semester tuition and housing was required in advance.

I did not have it. I had borrowed two hundred and fifty dollars from my grandmother to start the newspaper route. There was nothing left. I had been in Chattanooga less than two weeks, and I was about to be sent home before I had attended a single class.

I got back in line. I told the students working the counter my situation. They told me to wait — I would need to speak to the person in charge.

I waited four hours.

When my name was called, I went in to speak with the business office manager. She was elderly. I told her everything — Oklahoma, the week sleeping near my car, the missionary professor who had taken me in, the grandmother who had sent two hundred and fifty dollars, the three days already delivering

newspapers, the fact that I had a job and would pay my bill month by month if she would only let me start.

She listened. She explained that she could not say yes to every student in my situation — if she did it for one, she would have to do it for all. She suggested I ask my grandparents on my mother's side to help. I explained that was not possible — they could not help one grandchild without helping all of them, and they could not help all of them. She suggested my parents co-sign a loan. I explained my situation.

She was quiet for a moment.

Then she said yes. She would let me start. But I could not take my midterm exams if I had not paid fifty percent of my tuition and housing fees by that point. I agreed to that condition without hesitation. I did not know exactly how I would meet it. I agreed anyway.

I started my first semester at Tennessee Temple University.

Four hours of waiting and sweating and stuttering. Four hours of a young man from Oklahoma explaining himself to a woman who had every procedural reason to send him home and chose not to. That is what grace looks like when it is wearing a cardigan and sitting behind a business office desk.

When I graduated one year early, I went back to the business office. I brought twelve red roses. I found her and I thanked her for what she had done for me three years earlier.

She had shown me grace at the beginning. I wanted her to know I had not forgotten.

I slept through classes and borrowed notes from friends who left spiral-spring imprints on my face when they woke me up. And I learned sign language — which requires a longer explanation than the sentence suggests.

My freshman year I was walking across campus and saw a very attractive young woman. I asked someone nearby who she

was. They told me her name and then mentioned — did I know she was deaf? Tennessee Temple had a school for the deaf, and I had noticed students signing to each other on campus. But I had not thought much about it until that moment.

I thought about it now.

I took four sign language classes. I became proficient enough to join a rotation of student translators for the chapel services — signing for the deaf students while the hearing students listened. That was a privilege. I took it seriously.

I also had a theory. If I learned American Sign Language, I told myself, I could go anywhere in the world and communicate with deaf people. Sign language was universal. One skill, global application.

That theory lasted until I got to Korea.

I was walking down a shopping street in Seoul one day and saw two people signing to each other. I stopped. I stepped toward them and began signing in the American Sign Language I had learned at Tennessee Temple — fluently, confidently, completely certain this would work.

It did not work at all. Korean Sign Language and American Sign Language are as different as Korean and English. The hand shapes, the grammar, the entire visual vocabulary — different. I stood there signing things that meant nothing to the people in front of me, and they signed things back that meant nothing to me.

One of the two people was a hearing woman who had learned Korean Sign Language. She understood what had just happened — this foreigner had tried to communicate in a sign language from another country and had failed completely. We laughed about it. We talked. We became friends.

She was a couple of years younger than me, a freshman majoring in Chinese. Over the following years we met from

time to time, two young people in Seoul navigating their different callings. She eventually married a Chinese man who had been born and raised in Korea — a green card holder with a Chinese passport — and the two of them were sent by a Korean church as missionaries to Chinese-speaking people.

Years later, back in Seoul, her daughters attended the English-speaking church where I was pastoring. Another few years after that, her oldest daughter contacted me and asked if I would perform her wedding.

From a beautiful girl on a campus in Chattanooga — through sign language and shopping streets and missionaries and daughters who came back around — to a wedding. That is the kind of story that only becomes visible when you look backward across enough years to see the whole shape of it.

I still think about that theory. Sign language is universal. Korea said — not quite.

My first year, during the summer session, the house dormitories closed and all summer students were moved into the large building dormitory. A Korean student named Joey Kim (김요셉) had been living in one of those house dormitories. My roommate was leaving for the summer. I told Joey that if he needed a place, he could room with me.

He moved in. We were roommates for that summer.  [view photo](#)

His father visited campus once that summer and took Joey and some of his friends to a Korean restaurant in Chattanooga. I was one of those friends. We ate Korean food — my first real experience of it — and his father paid for the meal, and we talked and laughed and it was a good evening.

I did not know who Joey's father was. I knew he was Joey's dad.

I learned later — much later, in Korea — who I had had dinner with that evening in Chattanooga. Dr. Billy Kim. The man who had left Korea as a boy, gone through seminary in America, returned as a missionary, become the senior pastor of Central Baptist Church in Suwon, led Korea Youth For Christ, headed Far East Broadcasting Company in Korea, stood beside Billy Graham to translate for hundreds of thousands of people in Seoul, and served as President of the Baptist World Alliance from 2000 to 2005. That was the man who had treated me to Korean food in Chattanooga.

And that same man would one day take an ensemble of Korean high school girls on a tour of North America — raising money through revivals and special meetings — and I would later marry one of those girls.

None of that was visible at the dinner table. I just ate the food and enjoyed the evening and went back to the dormitory.

Several months later, in Korea, Dr. Billy Kim attended a nationwide Youth for Christ conference where leaders from across the country gathered. Elder John Song (송준용 장로님) was there — the director of YFC Gwangju, the English professor, the man I had not yet met. Elder Song asked Dr. Kim a question. He wanted to bring an American college student to Gwangju for the summer as an intern with Youth for Christ. Did Dr. Kim know of anyone who might be a candidate?

Dr. Kim thought back to Chattanooga. The dinner. The young man from Oklahoma studying missions who had told everyone at the table that he was going to be a missionary.

He gave Elder Song a name. He gave Elder Song an address.

One day I opened my post office box at Tennessee Temple University and there was an envelope from Korea.

Elder John Song was writing to invite me to come to Gwangju for the summer as an intern with Youth for Christ Gwangju.

I wrote back. I explained that I delivered newspapers full time — I could not take even a single day off, not one. But I accepted the invitation. Could he delay it? I was graduating one year early, in 1982. If he could wait until then, I would come.

He could wait.

For the last year and a half of college, I knew where I was going. Not because I had applied for a position or sent out letters or worked a system. Because a man had dinner in Chattanooga and remembered a young man from Oklahoma and mentioned his name to someone who needed exactly that person, and a letter arrived in a post office box.

Before I graduated, Joey took me back to that same Korean restaurant — just the two of us at a table. We talked about what Korea would be like. He would be home for the summer, and we might meet again there. He told me things I might experience, things to expect, the texture of a country I had only heard about through his voice in the dormitory hallway. It was a good conversation. We were not paying attention to who else was in the restaurant.

A young couple walked up to our table.

They apologized for interrupting. They said they had overheard us talking — about Korea, about me leaving to go there as a missionary. The man said he felt like God was calling him to give me a donation. But they had already left. They had gotten up, walked out, gotten in the car, started the engine, and driven away.

God did not give them peace.

They turned around. They came back. They walked across the restaurant to our table. And he handed me a check for twenty-five dollars.

Their names were Gary and Judy Lange.

In 1982, twenty-five dollars was not a small thing to a college student delivering newspapers before sunrise to pay his tuition. But the amount was not the point. The point was that they had driven away and come back. That they had felt something pulling them back to a table where two young men were talking about Korea, and they had not been able to ignore it.

I went to Korea. I have been here ever since.

Forty years later I reconnected with that couple. They began giving twenty-five dollars a month. Three years ago, during sixty-eight days of deputation travel in the States raising missionary support, I was in Chattanooga and we met again face to face.

They drove away in 1982. They turned around. They have been turning back toward that decision ever since — first with a check at a restaurant table, then with monthly support four decades later, then with a reunion in the city where it all began. Gary and Judy Lange are in their mid-eighties now. They are still giving.

That is what it looks like when ordinary people listen to the thing that will not let them keep driving.

Another friend from college helped in a quieter way. Rod Casey — a preacher's kid, one of my closer friends at Tennessee Temple, who had married a girl I knew named Judy — asked me before I left whether I had a prayer card. A prayer card is what missionaries hand out — a small card with their photo, their field, and information for people who want to pray or give. I did not have one.

Rod said his church in Festus, Missouri had a printing machine and regularly helped missionaries on the field. If I gave him the information, they would print me a stack at no cost.

Several months before I boarded the plane, a stack of prayer cards arrived from Festus, Missouri.  [view photo](#)

There was one small problem. The map of South Korea on the card was printed as a mirror image — reversed, backwards, the whole peninsula flipped. Almost nobody noticed. Almost nobody in my circle knew enough about the shape of South Korea to recognize that anything was wrong. The cards went out anyway, to everyone I knew and everyone I met in the months before I left.

I went to Korea with a backwards map of Korea on my prayer card. It did not seem to slow God down.

Rod and Judy later stopped in Seoul on a layover while traveling to the Philippines — deliberately, so they could visit. We saw a little of the city together. They came to the orphanage where I was staying and met the children. Rod Casey has been and is still a dear friend. Some friendships begin in college and simply never end.

I am going to be a missionary. In Korea.

I graduated in three years. I was ordained at my home church on a Wednesday evening, hands laid on my head by men who had known me since I was running through church yards playing tag. My church committed to send twenty-five dollars a month in missionary support. A fellow student was leaving Chattanooga to study in Germany and needed her car delivered to her parents in California. I needed to get to Los Angeles — a one-way ticket to Seoul from LAX was cheaper than from Oklahoma City. It was a practical arrangement that worked for both of us. I drove her sports car across the desert to Los Angeles. The radiator overheated in Arizona, and I waited by

the side of the road for a tow truck and thought about what I was doing and could not find a reason to stop.

On May 31, 1982, I boarded a plane at Los Angeles International Airport. I had a valid passport, a tourist visa good for ninety days, a one-way ticket, one suitcase, and nine hundred dollars.

My mother was forty-two years old. She was standing somewhere in Oklahoma with her hands open.

She had been listening to me for eight years. She had heard me say the same thing to every adult who asked. She had attended my graduation — Steve had driven her all the way from Bethany to Chattanooga, days off work, across four states, because it mattered and he was that kind of friend. A woman from our church circle had opened her home so my mother had a place to stay. That is how she got there. That is who got her there. The church, again, showing up in the form of ordinary people doing generous things without being asked twice.

When the moment came, I walked to where my mother was sitting and I offered her my arm. I guided her to the stairs at the side of the platform — steep stairs, the kind that require attention — and I took her up them carefully, one step at a time, and then I stopped. She crossed the platform alone, walking to the podium where Dr. Lee Roberson, the chancellor of the university and senior pastor of Highland Park Baptist Church, waited to hand her a book on behalf of her son. I stood at the edge of the platform and watched her go. When it was done, I was there again, waiting, and I guided her back down those stairs and walked her to her seat.

I had been escorted my whole life — by her hands, her singing, her welfare-check tithing, her Saturday morning candy routes, her voice in a gymnasium cheering louder than anyone. On those stairs, for a few minutes, I got to be the one doing

the escorting. It was not enough to repay what I owed. It was what I had. Inside the cover of that book, a sticker. At the bottom of the sticker, a verse.

The eternal God is your refuge, and underneath are the everlasting arms.

She gave me to the arms that were already underneath.

And I flew west to be in the east, and the Pacific Ocean was very wide, and I was twenty-one years old, and Jesus was leading.

* * *

Chapter Four continues...

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Chapter Four

Now What?

Tense. Scary. Real.

Those are the three words I would use to describe the moment the wheels of that Northwest Airlines flight touched down at Gimpo International Airport on the evening of June 1, 1982. Not the twelve hours of flight before it. Not the Pacific spread out below the clouds like something too large to be believed. Not the moment of takeoff from Los Angeles, when I had sat in my seat and felt something that might have been courage or might have been the inability to imagine turning back.

The landing. The wheels on Korean ground. That is where it became real.

For eight years I had been saying I was going to be a missionary. I had said it to Sunday school teachers and church deacons and college professors and anyone else who asked. I had meant it every time. But meaning something and arriving somewhere are two different things, and somewhere over the Pacific the distance between them had quietly collapsed, and now there was nothing left between the calling and the country except an immigration line I had never stood in before and a

lobby full of people I did not know and a question I had successfully avoided asking for eight years.

Now what?

* * *

I did not know how immigration worked. I did not know what customs wanted from me or what I was supposed to declare or where the luggage carousel was or which way to walk once, I had my bags. I followed the people around me because following was the only option available. I watched what they did, and I did the same thing a few seconds behind them, hoping nobody noticed that I was navigating entirely by imitation.

I got through. Somehow, I got through. And then I walked out of the secured area and into the arrival lobby and stopped.

The lobby was full of people. Hundreds of faces, all of them Korean, all of them moving with the certainty of people who know exactly where they are going. They had people to meet and buses to catch and lives in motion. The crowd flowed around me like a river around a rock that had no business being in the middle of it.

I found an empty spot, and I sat down on my suitcase.

There was a man who was supposed to meet me. I did not know his name. I did not have a phone number. I did not know what he looked like. The arrangement was that he would find me — which had seemed reasonable when the arrangement was made in Oklahoma and seemed considerably less reasonable now that I was sitting on a suitcase in a Korean airport lobby with no way to find anyone or be found by anyone or do anything except wait and hope.

I had a cowboy hat. I was wearing it, or carrying it — I cannot remember which, only that it was with me, that I had brought it from Oklahoma as though Oklahoma needed to be

represented on this occasion. In a lobby full of Korean faces it was spectacularly unnecessary. There was not a horse within a thousand miles. There was not another cowboy hat on the Asian continent as far as I could tell. But it was from home, and home was very far away, and I held onto it.

Nobody spoke to me. Several people looked at me — a white boy in a black suit with cowboy boots and a cowboy hat, sitting on his suitcase in the middle of a Korean airport lobby — and then looked away again, because whatever I was I was clearly not their problem. I tried speaking to a few people nearby. Simple English. Slow and clear, the way you speak to someone in a language they might not know. Nobody understood. Nobody could help.

I had assumed, somewhere in the back of my mind, that English would be available. Not universal — I was not that naive — but available. A few people. A fallback. Some way to communicate when the situation required it. What I discovered in that lobby, and what I would spend the next several months learning to accept, was that my assumption had been wrong in the most comprehensive possible way. I was in a country of fifty million people, and I did not speak the language any of them spoke, and not one of them was obligated to speak mine.

I was lost in a crowd. Not dramatically. Not spiritually. Just — lost. The ordinary, practical, completely helpless kind of lost that happens when you are twenty-one years old and sitting on a suitcase in a foreign country and there is genuinely nothing you can do except wait.

I waited.

I did not pray, or if I did, I do not remember it. I had faith — I had always had faith; it was the furniture of my interior life — but faith in that lobby felt less like a light and more like a coat. Something I was wearing. Something that kept me from

freezing without making the room any warmer. God did not feel far away exactly. He felt quiet. The way He is sometimes quiet when He is not performing a miracle but simply waiting alongside a person who needs to learn to sit still.

I had not yet learned the language for what was living inside me. I had not been taught about the Holy Spirit in the way that makes His presence recognizable in ordinary moments — in lobbies, on suitcases, in the specific loneliness of being the only person in a room who does not know what to do next. That understanding would come later. At twenty-one, sitting in that airport, all I knew was that I had said yes to something and the something had brought me here and here was not what I had imagined.

Here was tense and scary and real.

An hour passed. Maybe more. And then a Korean man came through the doors moving quickly, scanning the lobby, and his eyes landed on me with the expression of someone who has found exactly what he was looking for and is relieved and slightly embarrassed about the delay. He walked over and extended his hand and said something that I understood to be an apology. It sounded like * So Ree. * He did not speak English. I did not speak Korean. We shook hands and looked at each other and understood that we were going to have to figure out the rest as we went.

His nickname was Hama — hippopotamus in Korean, given based on the shape of his nose, which was unusual among Korean noses. He was the Youth for Christ representative who had been sent to collect me. He was an hour late because Korean time operates on a different philosophy than Oklahoma time — events are advertised to begin earlier than they begin, and arrival times are understood to be approximate, and the concept of keeping someone waiting does not carry the

same weight it carries in America. I would learn all of this. I would spend years learning all of this. In the lobby I just knew he was late and I was glad he had come.

He got a taxi. He put my luggage in the trunk. We got in. And Korea began.

* * *

The first thing I saw outside the airport was soldiers.

Not policemen. Soldiers. Standing at the intersection with M16 rifles, armed and ready, watching the traffic with the alertness of men who are not performing a ceremony but doing a job. I had grown up in Oklahoma. I had never seen anything like this on an ordinary street in an ordinary city on an ordinary evening. My stomach tightened.

Korea was still technically at war. The conflict that had begun in 1950 had ended with an armistice in 1953 — a pause, not a peace. The border between north and south was one of the most heavily militarized places on earth. Soldiers at intersections were not a sign that something was wrong. They were a sign that the country had been living with the possibility of something going wrong for thirty years and had made its arrangements accordingly.

I did not know any of that yet. I just saw the rifles and felt the reality of where I was settling into my body in a new way.

The taxi ride to the city took an hour. Seoul spread out around us in the dark — enormous, dense, loud in a way that cities in Oklahoma were not loud. The driver drove the way Korean drivers drove, which is to say with a confidence in outcomes that I had not yet learned to share. Hama sat in the front and occasionally turned to look at me with the expression of a man who is trying to be hospitable across a complete absence of shared language.

He took me to a yeokwan (여관) a Korean inn, something between a hotel and a boarding house, priced for ordinary people rather than foreign visitors. My room was on the third floor. The bathroom was tiled from floor to ceiling and the shower had no stall — you stood in the middle of the room and the water went everywhere, which meant everything below the waist got wet and the single towel, roughly the size of a hand towel, was inadequate by any standard I had previously applied to towels. The street noise came through the window all night. The lights from outside made the room bright even in the small hours of the morning.

I lay on the bed and could not sleep.

Then came the explosion.

Enormous. Close. The kind of sound that bypasses thought and goes directly to the body, the kind that makes you run before you have decided to run. I was at the window in seconds, heart pounding, scanning the street below for the evidence of whatever had just happened.

There was nothing. The street was as it had been. Nobody was running. Nobody was looking up. The other guests in the yeokwan were not stirring. Whatever I had heard had not alarmed anyone else in the building, which meant either that it had not happened or that it was the kind of thing that happened here regularly enough that people had stopped treating it as news.

I went back to bed. I lay there with my heart still moving too fast and thought about North Korea and artillery and the soldiers at the intersection. I thought about the fact that I had come here alone, that nobody in this city knew me, that the man who had been an hour late to collect me was the closest thing I had to a point of contact in a country of fifty million people.

I did not sleep.

The sun came up eventually. Hama arrived and took me to breakfast. The menu was the same as dinner. I had not yet understood that Korean meals are not organized the way American meals are organized — that breakfast is not a different category of food from lunch or dinner, that rice and soup and banchan are appropriate at any hour. I ate what was in front of me and I did not complain, because I had not yet developed the Korean vocabulary for complaining and because complaining seemed wrong given the circumstances of my arrival.

Then he put me on a bus to Gwangju.

* * *

The bus ride took four hours. A stewardess worked the aisle — serving water, collecting trash, helping the driver reverse at stops, doing her job with the thoroughness that I would come to understand was characteristic of Korean service in general. Halfway through the journey the bus stopped at a rest area and the passengers got off to use the facilities and buy noodles from the vendors.

The men's bathroom was a revelation. Squat pots instead of toilet seats. A trough urinal along one wall where men lined up without ceremony. I had grown up in an outhouse on an Oklahoma farm. I could manage this. What I could not manage was the food, because I had no Korean money and no Korean words and no way to order the noodles that everyone around me was eating with great satisfaction.

I stood and watched. Trucks were parked nearby selling cassette tapes, car accessories, watermelons, strawberries. The Beach Boys were playing through a loudspeaker on one of the trucks. I had traveled more than six thousand miles and the first music I heard in Korea was the Beach Boys.

When it was time to reboard, I discovered that I did not know which bus was mine. They were all the same color, the same size, lined up in a row. The stewardess had announced the bus number in Korean and I had not understood. I stood in the parking lot knowing with complete certainty that I was about to be left behind in a Korean rest stop with no money and no language and no idea where I was.

The driver saw me. He understood the situation immediately — there was only one explanation for a white man in a black suit with a cowboy hat standing in a Korean rest stop parking lot looking at a row of identical buses with that expression. He sent the stewardess. She guided me to the right bus. I thanked her in English, which she did not understand, and I sat down and did not get up again until Gwangju.

* * *

At the Gwangju bus terminal two young men were waiting for me. They had been sent by Elder John Song — the director of Gwangju Youth For Christ and a professor of English at the local university — to collect the American who was coming to do an internship. They were warm and enthusiastic and glad to see me in a way that made me feel, for the first time since the wheels had touched down in Seoul the previous evening, like someone who was expected and wanted.

One of those two young men became a lifetime friend. His name was Kim Bong Joong (김봉중). His nickname among his friends was Bong Bong Ee — warm, outgoing, the kind of person who was easy to be around because he made everyone around him feel comfortable. He had finished his military service and was back at university, one year older than me, studying history. American history was his passion — his English was already quite good and impressive for a Korean college student at that time, and he knew American history well

enough to surprise me with details I had missed in my own education.

That mattered enormously in those first months. I did not yet speak Korean. Kim Bong-joong spoke English. He became the bridge I needed to begin understanding the Korean culture and the life of Gwangju — what things meant, how people thought, what was safe to say and what was not. He answered my naive questions with patience. He helped me navigate a city and a culture that were completely foreign to me.

He went on to the University of Toledo in Ohio to earn his PhD in American history, then returned to Korea to teach. A Korean man who spent his academic life studying America. We have remained in contact ever since.

But I want to say something about Chonnam National University — the university Kim Bong-joong attended — and about the city of Gwangju itself. Because I arrived in June 1982, and two years before I arrived, something had happened in this city that the people had not recovered from and would not recover from for a very long time.

In May 1980, the citizens of Gwangju — students and ordinary people alike — had revolted against the military government of Chun Doo-hwan, who had seized power in a coup. The uprising had begun at Chonnam National University, where students demonstrating against martial law were beaten, shot at, and killed by government paratroopers. What started as a student protest became a city-wide resistance. Citizens took to the streets — workers, shopkeepers, parents. The military suppressed it with force. Hundreds were injured. People were killed. The city that I arrived in two years later still carried the wounds visibly — bullet holes in the walls of buildings that had not yet been repaired, people walking with the gait of those

whose bodies have been through something, families who had lost someone and could not speak about it openly.

The Korean government controlled the press. The story of Gwangju had been suppressed nationally. Most Koreans outside the city did not know the full truth of what had happened there. But the people of Gwangju and South Cholla Province — Chonnam — knew. They carried the grief and the anger and the injustice of it like something worn under the skin, invisible to the casual observer but immediately felt by anyone who spent enough time in conversation with them.

I was a new face. An American. Someone who had come from outside, who carried no loyalty to the government that had done this, who had no reason to be hostile and every reason to listen. The college students and the citizens of Gwangju told me their side of the story. They told me things that were not safe to say in many other contexts. I was moved. I was overwhelmed. And I understood, in a way that would take years to fully articulate, why the faith of the people in Gwangju had the intensity it had. When earthly authority fails you so completely, the only authority left is the one that cannot be corrupted.

I had arrived at the first place that was waiting for me, and that mattered more than I could have explained at the time.

Elder Song was a serious man with a generous spirit. He was an elder at the First Presbyterian Church of Gwangju. He was a professor of English language and literature. He was the kind of person who occupied multiple worlds at once — the academic world, the church world, the civic world — and moved between them with an ease that I would spend years trying to understand. He introduced me to his university students. He took me to meet the university president. He brought me to the Youth For Christ gatherings on Saturdays,

where I was astonished by the intelligence and energy of the Korean high school students who came.

It took time to understand the world I had entered. One thing I did not grasp immediately was this — Elder John Song, who had invited me to Korea, who had a career and a church and deep roots in this country, could barely leave it. When Korean citizens wanted to travel abroad in 1982, the government issued a passport that specified exactly which country they could visit and for exactly how long. They then had to take that limited passport to the embassy of the destination country and apply for a visa — also limited. A single person had almost no chance of getting permission to leave at all, because there was no guarantee they would come back. A married man with a family, a job, property — those were the qualifications that made the government confident a person had enough roots to return. I was a single American with no property and no job in Korea. I could come and go on a tourist visa almost freely. The man who had arranged my entire arrival could barely get permission to attend a conference abroad. I did not know that when I arrived. It took time to see.

These were not children who needed someone to come from America and teach them about Jesus. They knew about Jesus. They had been raised in churches, many of them, in a country where Christianity had exploded in the decades since the Korean War. They came to YFC because they loved it, because the community fed something in them, because their faith was genuinely their own.

I was given the responsibility of sharing an English Bible class with the students after the Saturday program finished. Most would stay. I would prepare a story or narrative from the Bible — something personal, something I could connect to

their lives as students. That was my one hour of formal responsibility.

The rest of the time I spent with the YFC college staff — young people who had come up through the high school program, graduated, and stayed connected while attending different universities. We were similar in age. We did things together. It kept the loneliness at a manageable distance and gave me a place to ask the questions I could not ask anywhere else — about the culture, the language, the hundred small things that a foreigner does not know he does not know until he does them wrong.

One Saturday, during a staff meeting conducted entirely in Korean, something happened that I did not know was happening.

They planned a surprise birthday party for me.

In front of me. In Korean. Using slang I had not yet learned, talking at the speed that native speakers talk when they are not slowing down for a foreigner. My birthday is November 8th, and the Saturday closest to it that year they had decided to honor it — and they had made all the arrangements with me sitting right there in the room, completely unaware.

I was genuinely surprised. Overwhelmed. Happy in a way I had not expected to be happy — far from Oklahoma, far from my college friends, in a country whose language I was still stumbling through, and this new family had remembered my birthday and arranged something and brought gifts that did not cost much but meant more than I could say in either language.

Elder John Song congratulated me in front of the full YFC student body. A photograph was taken. I stood there receiving something I had not known that I needed it until I received it.

And then afterward, when the celebration had settled, they started laughing among themselves. I wanted to know what was funny. They told me.

They had planned the whole thing in front of me. Every detail, every arrangement, every decision — all of it discussed openly in that staff meeting while I sat there not understanding a word. They found this enormously funny. The slang they had used, the speed at which they had spoken, the fact that it was entirely about me and I had not caught a single thread of it.

They laughed again.

I did not laugh.

I felt hurt. I felt angry at myself. I felt incompetent in a way that a college diploma does not prepare you for — because the diploma had nothing to do with what I was failing at in that moment. I could write essays. I could pass exams. I could not sit in a room with Korean people speaking Korean at their natural speed and understand what was being said about me.

It took time to process. To stop being angry at myself and start being honest about where I was — six months into a language, not six years. A person does not become fluent in six months. The gap between six months and the ability to follow a fast conversation full of slang is a gap that only time closes.

Eventually I laughed about it too. It is still a good story.

But the first feeling deserves to be on the page as well as the eventual laughter. Because it was real. And anyone who has ever tried to learn a language in the country that speaks it will recognize it immediately — the humiliation of intelligence rendered helpless. The loneliness of being in a room where people are talking about you and you are the only one who does not know it.

The birthday party was wonderful. The moment after was one of the harder moments of those early months. Both things

happened on the same afternoon. That is what it felt like to be a foreigner in Korea in 1982.

The young man who presented the gift on behalf of the students was Joseph Cho (조병영) — the student body president of the YFC Gwangju.  [view photo](#) He now lives in New Jersey with his wife and two daughters. We have met in Seoul from time to time over the years. We still communicate by SMS. Some friendships begin with a wrapped gift and a room full of people laughing, and they simply never end.

And everyone I met — Elder Song, his students, the church members, the young people at YFC — everyone eventually asked me the same question.

Why did you come to Korea?

In Korean, that question does not ask about the method of travel. It asks about the motivation. What brought you here. What made you choose this. I had an answer ready and I gave it every time: I came to be a missionary. God called me to Korea.

And every time, with some variation in the wording but none in the substance, the response came back:

Korea is a missionary-sending country now. We don't need missionaries anymore.

I heard this so often in those first months that it became a kind of refrain — the answer to an answer, the closed door that appeared every time I tried to explain why I had come. Korean Christianity had grown so rapidly, so completely, that the country had moved within a generation from mission field to missionary sender. Korea was, by some measures, the second largest sender of Christian missionaries in the world. American missionaries were finishing their final terms and going home. Nobody was coming to replace them.

I had come more than six thousand miles to be told I was not needed.

I did not know what to do with that. The calling had been clear — Korea was never in question. From the night at Lake Texoma to the ordination service in Bethany to the plane lifting off from Los Angeles, I had been certain that God had sent me here. That certainty had not moved.

What confused me was the question underneath the certainty. Not whether I was supposed to be in Korea. But what exactly I was supposed to be doing here. An American missionary arriving in a country that had outgrown its need for American missionaries — what did that look like? What did it mean? Korea did not need me to introduce Jesus. Korea was introducing Jesus to the rest of the world. So, what was my role?

I did not have an answer. The confirmation had come through Joey and Elder Song's letter and the stranger in the restaurant who had come back to leave a twenty-five dollar check on the table. All of that had pointed here. God had said Korea. He had not yet said what Korea would require of me. And here was telling me, through every Korean Christian I met, that the role I had imagined for myself did not exist anymore.

I stayed anyway. Not because I had figured it out. Because Korea was where I had been sent, and the question of what to do there was God's problem to answer in His own time. My job was to be present and available and to pay attention.

And sometimes, in the middle of that waiting, God sent a signal.

Elder John Song had allowed me to use the Youth for Christ Gwangju post office box for my mail. PO Box 58, at the main post office in downtown Gwangju. I shared the combination and often I was the one who went to collect the mail — bringing Elder Song his correspondence as chairman of YFC Gwangju and keeping my own personal mail separate.

One day I went to the box and found a large white envelope, thickly sealed with tape. I could feel through the paper that there were coins inside — shifting around, pressing against the edges. I took it on the bus back to Elder Song's house and opened it on the way.

Twelve dollars in coins. Maybe two one-dollar bills. And a note.

A Sunday school teacher — someone I had known at college — had told her class about a missionary in Korea who had gone by faith. Over several weeks those children had brought their offering. A coin here, a coin there, the kind of giving that children do when they are genuinely moved by something and have only what is in their pockets to give. The teacher had collected it all, sealed it into that white envelope — some coins shifting loose on the way, the envelope taped shut again to keep them in — and mailed it across the Pacific to PO Box 58 in Gwangju.

I sat on that bus with twelve dollars in coins in my lap and felt something I did not have a word for at the time. Not gratitude exactly — though it was that too. Something more like confirmation. Children in a Sunday school classroom in America who had never met me and would likely never meet me had given what they had because someone told them a story about a missionary going by faith. And it had arrived. Into exactly the uncertainty I was sitting in, on exactly the bus I was riding, at exactly the moment I most needed to hear it.

You are on the right path. Keep going.

That is how God often speaks to me — not in thunder, not in dramatic signs, but in a white envelope full of children's coins on a Korean city bus. The everlasting arms do not always announce themselves. Sometimes they just make sure the mail arrives.

I sat with it. I learned the bus routes. I bought a ten-speed bicycle and discovered that cycling in a Korean summer is an act of optimism that the weather does not support. I bought a used 125cc Honda — the same size engine I had ridden in Oklahoma, which felt like a small mercy — and the transportation problem was largely solved.

Korean roads in 1982 had a lane hierarchy that reflected the society itself. Black sedans with personal drivers occupied the fast inner lanes. Taxis followed. Buses and cargo vehicles were confined to the outer lanes. Motorcycles belonged with the buses — in the slow lanes, on the edges. That was the law.

I rode in the first lane anyway. Not out of defiance — simply because nobody stopped me. Foreigners on motorcycles seemed to fall into an unwritten exception. The police had neither the manpower nor the interest to enforce every lane violation on every motorcycle weaving through Seoul traffic. So, I rode fast, in the wrong lane, and after enough years I assumed the law must have changed.

In 2010 a driver pulled alongside me, furious, and told me I had no right to be in that lane. I was indignant. I had been doing this for years. I went to a police station to check. The officer looked up the law and told me the man was right. The law had never changed. Only the enforcement had.

I had been breaking Korean law, happily, for nearly three decades. That taught me something about the difference between what is written and what is practiced — a gap I would observe in many areas of Korean life over the years. I started the English Bible study at the Saturday YFC gatherings. I moved into the home of Elder Song's family and slept in a room with his two younger sons and practiced my Korean with his daughters and ate at his table and watched how a Korean Christian family lived from the inside.

The Song family had four children. Hannah was the oldest — one year younger than me, a piano student at college, traveling back and forth for her classes but sleeping at home each night. She was the oldest daughter, and I was an American one year her senior who had appeared informally in her family's life, and she did not seem especially pleased about the arrangement. I understood that. The second daughter was Mina — in her first year of college, a voice major, curious about the world in the way that first-year college students are curious. She was curious about me. There was something that passed between us — a flirtation, an awareness, the kind of unspoken current that two young people feel when they are in the same house and neither entirely knows what to do with what they are feeling. We were both too young to name it accurately or act on it wisely, so it remained what it was — a current, unresolved, eventually fading.

The two younger boys — Samuel and Jacob — were high school age and accepting of a big brother who had moved into their room. The room became smaller. There was more talking at night before sleep. I did not mind. I was twenty-one and far from home and the sound of other people in the dark was not unwelcome.  [view photo](#)

One day Elder Song and I were on a bus together, going somewhere I no longer remember. I had been thinking about Mina — about whether there was something there worth pursuing, whether it was even possible. I asked him a question that I framed as carefully as I knew how. Something like — how do you feel about interracial marriage? And then, more specifically, how would you feel if Mina were to marry a foreigner?

The conversation ended quickly.

No. He was not open to interracial marriage. And he was sure she would never consider it.

That was the end of the pursuit and the end of the conversation.

I was startled by how fast the answer came. Not by its content — I had suspected this was the general position — but by its speed and its certainty. There was no hesitation, no nuance, no * well it would depend on the person. * Just no.

I filed that away. It was probably the answer most Korean fathers of that generation would give to a foreign man asking that question about their daughter. They might even encourage a foreigner to think about marrying a Korean girl — just not their Korean girl. That was my analysis of the general cultural position, gathered from that one quick answer on a bus in Gwangju.

I did not know then that the answer would eventually be different. That a different father, in a different city, years later, would say yes — on one condition. That the condition would be fair. And that I would mean it when I agreed.

The Song family has remained in my life ever since — and mine in theirs. Elder John Song's wife passed away in later years, as did Hannah, the oldest daughter. When each of them passed, I was there. Not as a guest paying respects from a distance — as one of the family. I stood with them during the wake, in the line that receives condolences, as people came to mourn. Nobody needed to explain my presence or assign me a role. The family knew where I belonged. I stood there. Mina — the second daughter, the voice major — still lives in Gwangju. When I visit the city, I see her. And I see Elder John Song himself, who is ninety-two years old and still there. The man who invited me to Korea, who gave me a room in his house

and a place at his table and a combination to a post office box — ninety-two years old, and I still visit him in Gwangju.

Samuel Song — the older of the two boys whose room I shared — went through dental school, as his father had hoped. In Korean Confucian tradition the oldest son carries the responsibility of providing for the parents, and Elder Song had modeled this himself, caring for both his own parents and his wife's parents until they passed. Samuel understood the expectation. But Samuel had always wanted to be a medical missionary. He became a dentist in Korea first — practicing for ten years, contributing to his parents' care — and then, after his mother passed and after what I imagine were conversations that involved both stubbornness and grace on both sides, he left for Africa as a dental missionary with his wife and two young children. He had waited ten years for the mission field. He went anyway.

Jacob Song — the younger boy, the junior high student who had been perfectly happy to have an older brother in the room — finished his required military service and immediately set his sights abroad. He applied to a university in Tulsa, Oklahoma. He was accepted. He went. In Tulsa he met a Korean missionary girl whose family was based in Spain. He graduated. He married her — the wedding was in Korea — and then they went back to Tulsa and stayed. Jacob now teaches at that same university and runs his own recording studio where he produces music.

All four of the Song children inherited something musical from their parents — it ran through that family the way certain gifts run through families, showing up in different forms in each child. But the best singer of all four, in my opinion, is Jacob. The youngest. The one who ended up in Oklahoma, of all the places in the world.

Some of the people who shape your life in the early chapters stay in it through all the chapters that follow. The Song family is one of those.

There is one more turn in that story worth telling. Shortly after I left Gwangju for Seoul and the Yonsei language program, Elder John Song applied for a temporary passport. He received a limited American visa and traveled to Oklahoma City to study at a university there for one summer. He needed a place to stay.

I asked my mother and Raymond if he could stay with them in Bethany.

He stayed in our house. The pastor at Western Oaks Baptist Church helped him find a used car. He got an American driver's license. He drove himself back and forth between Bethany and the university in Oklahoma City for the rest of the summer, living in the house where I had grown up, worshipping at the church where I had been ordained, being looked after by the mother who had given me to Jesus at the airport.

I had gone to Korea and lived in his house. He had gone to Oklahoma and lived in mine. The world is not as large as it looks from the airport lobby.

And I learned Korean. Badly at first, and then less badly, and then well enough to get into trouble in ways I had not anticipated. The students who were willing to speak Korean with me were mostly the young women, who were more curious and more patient. The young men wanted to practice their English. I insisted on Korean and the young men grew bored and drifted away and I learned my Korean from the young women, which meant I learned it with expressions and intonations that belonged to young women, which I would discover later when I used those expressions in front of Korean men and they looked at me with a kind of benevolent confusion.

There is a particular Korean word for this kind of mistake, and I made it often.

* * *

Three months in, the tourist visa expired. The simplest solution was to leave the country briefly and come back — a routine procedure for foreigners in Korea at the time. I took the car ferry from Busan harbor to Shimonoseki, Japan, turned around, and came back. Another ninety days. It was inconvenient and cost money I did not have to spare, but it worked.

What did not work was what came next.

A friend who was a missionary helped me apply for a proper missionary visa, which would allow me to stay in Korea long-term without the ninety-day border runs. I filled out the application honestly, explaining what I was doing in Korea and why I was qualified to do it. I did not realize that honesty was the mistake. The honest description of my activities was also the evidence of a violation — I had been doing missionary work on a tourist visa, which was illegal, and I had just put that in writing and submitted it to the government.

A letter came by registered mail. It was from the immigration office of the Korean Government Justice Department.

I had three days to leave the country.

I was being deported.

I read the letter several times. I was twenty-one years old and I had been in Korea for three months and I was being deported. The people who had helped me apply apologized. They told me that if I went to the Korean consulate in Osaka, Japan and applied there, the missionary visa would likely be approved within a week.

When I shared the news with Dr. Dick Nieusma — a dental missionary working at the Christian Hospital of Gwangju — he did something I had not asked him to do. He contacted a missionary couple in his denomination who lived in Osaka, Mr. and Mrs. Moore. They were empty nesters. They had a spare room. They agreed to take me in for the week it was supposed to take.

I packed my things. I went to Busan harbor. I boarded a ferry — this time to Osaka.

* * *

Japan was clean in a way that Korea was not yet clean. The streets of Osaka were wide and orderly and there were American fast-food restaurants with familiar logos that I could read. I walked past a McDonald's and stopped. The smell came through the door — the specific, smell of a Big Mac, a smell I had not encountered in three months, a smell that arrived in my body as something close to physical longing. I checked my money. I could not afford it.

I turned around and kept walking.

That is a small thing. I know it is a small thing. But I want to put it here because it is true, and because the accumulation of small things — the Big Mac I couldn't buy, the towel the size of a hand towel, the bus I couldn't identify, the immigration letter I hadn't expected — that accumulation is what the mission field actually feels like from the inside. It is not dramatic. It is not a crisis of faith. It is just Tuesday, and you are twenty-one years old, and you cannot afford a Big Mac, and the person who was supposed to meet you was an hour late, and nobody needs you here anyway.

That is where faith lives. Not in the camp meetings and the ordination services and the verse on the award sticker. In the

Tuesday. In the Big Mac you walk away from. In the ferry ride to Japan and the week of waiting that turned into five weeks.

Five weeks.

The consulate received my application and my passport and told me they would call when it was ready. I was without a passport — which meant I was without options, without the ability to change my mind, without any way to go anywhere except the Moore's home where I was staying and the consulate office a short walk from the harbor. I went to the consulate every day. Every day the answer was the same. Not ready. Not ready. And then: we've sent it to Korea. We'll call you.

Do not come back. We will call you.

The Moore family had expected a guest for one week. They got five. They tried to engage me — suggested I work in the yard, helped me find things to do, tried to draw me out of the fog I was living in. I did not cooperate. I was in a spiral — doubt, fear, depression — and I did not have the energy or the willingness to pretend otherwise. I sat in their spare room, and I waited and I was not good company.

They were patient anyway. That was grace, plain and unremarkable and given freely to someone who had done nothing to earn it.

Five weeks. The new semester had started at TTU. My college friends were beginning their senior year — the year I had skipped by graduating early, the year that was happening without me while I sat in a spare room in Japan waiting for a phone call.

Where was my faith? I have asked myself that question many times since. The honest answer is that faith does not always feel like faith from the inside. Sometimes it feels like stubbornness. Sometimes it feels like having no good alternative. I stayed in Japan and I waited because I had

nowhere else to go and no money to get there and no plan beyond the original plan, which was Korea.

I am sure the Moore family was glad to see me go. I cannot blame them.

Jesus was leading. I could not always see where he was leading me. Yet, I had not yet arrived at the place where I stopped believing He was leading, even when I could not see His hand.

The phone rang. The missionary visa had been approved.

I went back to Korea.

* * *

Elder Song and I talked about the future. He was honest with me. The question of whether a foreign missionary was needed in Korea was not going to be resolved by my insisting I was needed. The Koreans were going to answer that question themselves, and they were answering it by training their own leaders and sending their own missionaries and building their own churches at a rate that made the contributions of foreign workers look increasingly supplementary.

But there was another question underneath that one. Not whether Korea needed missionaries. Whether Korea needed Bill Majors.

I did not know the answer yet. But I was beginning to understand that the answer would not come from an argument or a plan. It would come the way most important things had come in my life — through a person I had not been looking for, in a moment I had not arranged, by a route I could not have mapped in advance.

Jesus was leading. I had agreed to follow. That agreement did not come with a detailed itinerary.

It came with a cowboy hat and nine hundred dollars and a question I could not yet answer.

Now what?

I was about to find out.

* * *

One day Joe Hale asked if I would help him carry some heavy boxes to a children's home nearby.

Joe Hale was not a stranger. I had met him at Tennessee Temple while I was still a student — he had come to campus looking for Christian school teachers who might be willing to come to Korea. Joey had introduced us. Joe had been in Korea for six years by then, working in Uijeongbu — the city north of Seoul where my daughters would later be born — running a ministry to US military families and founding a small foreign school. He had learned his Korean informally, on the street, the same way I was learning mine. And so we had both ended up in the same level at Yonsei University's Korean Language Institute at the same time, sitting in the same classroom, two men who had first met on a college campus in Tennessee and were now doing their best to keep up with a Korean teacher in Seoul.

It was through that classroom reunion — from Tennessee Temple to Yonsei to the same level two class — that Joe asked me one day if I would come with him to deliver boxes to an orphanage. He needed an extra pair of hands, and I had nothing more important to do. I said yes without knowing what I was walking into.

Hwarang Children's Home. It had been started by a single woman just after the Korean War — a grandmother who saw children with nowhere to go and made a place for them. When she passed away her son and his wife — her daughter-in-law — continued what she had begun. By the time Joe Hale and I arrived with our boxes, the home held about eighty-five children — from three years old through high school — along

with six or so staff members, several of whom had grown up there themselves and simply never left.  [view photo](#)

I do not have adequate words for what I felt that day. Beautiful children everywhere. Small ones running. Older ones watching with careful eyes, assessing this foreigner who had arrived with boxes and an uncertain Korean vocabulary. The place was alive with the energy of a large family that has learned to function as one organism — everyone knowing their role, the older ones watching the younger ones, the rhythms of the home running on their own momentum.

I went back. And went back again. And kept going back.

What I told myself was that I was being generous — giving my time, being a big brother to children who needed one. What was happening, though I did not see it until later, was that those children were giving me far more than I was giving them. My Korean was developing faster than it ever had in a classroom, because children do not slow down for your limitations. They talk at full speed and expect you to keep up, and somehow you do. The language was coming in ways that textbooks and language school could not produce.

I started driving the orphanage van. I helped with whatever needed helping. I was spending more time at Hwarang than I was spending at the residence where I was supposed to be living. Eventually the staff looked at the situation practically — there was a room, small as a closet, that could be cleared out. Would I like to move in?

I moved in.

And sometimes, when I wanted to be closer to the rhythm of the place, I would sleep in the large room with the older boys. The room had two platforms built from wall to wall — like bunk beds that filled the entire room, with just a narrow hallway

in front of the sleeping area. Every boy had his space on those platforms. I had mine.

The problem was the blankets. Or rather, the single blanket that was yours for the night — which was only yours until you fell deeply enough asleep for someone colder than you to reach over and pull it away. Nobody was being cruel. Everyone was just cold. In the dark, half asleep, the instinct is simple — pull toward warmth. The fact that the blanket now belongs to the person next to you is a problem that person will deal with when they wake up cold.

I woke up cold more than once.

There were two experiences during those orphanage years that I could not have had anywhere else — and that I have never forgotten.

The first was at Hwarang. The orphanage had leased a rice field. When planting season came, we all went — staff and whoever else was available. I took off my shoes and stepped into the irrigated paddy. The mud came up to mid-calf, cold and deep and soft, squeezing up between my toes with every step in a way that was simultaneously strange and completely satisfying. We bent over and planted seedlings — small rice plants that had already started growing, pressed into the mud at specific distances, in straight lines, row by row across the flooded field.  [view photo](#)

I had grown up in Oklahoma. I had planted nothing in my life that required standing barefoot in a flooded field. But I bent alongside the staff, and I planted and I learned what Korean farming felt like from the inside — which is to say, it felt like hard work punctuated by extraordinary amounts of food. Every two hours we stopped. We ate. We drank. We rested. Then we went back. By the end of the day, we had eaten five times. I

liked eating. The rice field was one of the better days of those years.

The second was at Sungshin. The orphanage had leased a cabbage field — planted it, watched it grow, and when harvest time came the Korean military provided a truck and two soldiers to help bring the cabbage in. The older boys did most of the heavy work — pulling the heads from the ground, carrying them to the truck, unloading at the orphanage. The girls took over from there, washing and cutting and preparing kimchi that would feed the orphanage through the fall and winter.

We worked in assembly lines — field to truck, truck to wash area, wash area to the girls who would turn it into kimchi. It was hard work. We were sore for days afterward.

But somewhere in the middle of it, someone started naming the cabbage heads after teachers and politicians. And someone else discovered that a large cabbage head, hiked backward through the legs the way an American football center snaps to a quarterback, could be thrown a reasonable distance to a receiver running a route through the field. We played our version of football with cabbage heads between loads.

Mostly we worked. But we laughed while we worked. And the kimchi lasted all winter. And the sore muscles were proof that something real had happened.

* * *

The adoption work found me rather than the other way around.

The Eastern Adoption Agency in Seoul facilitated international adoptions for children from various orphanages. When all the paperwork was completed — the health checks, the legal documents, the international clearances, the American passport with the child's new name — what remained was a

practical problem. Someone had to get the child from Seoul to the airport city where the new family was waiting. The agency needed escorts. I was available.

The first children I escorted were not from Hwarang but from another home — identical twin girls, four years old. Their new names, written in their American passports, were Robin and Rachel. They were going to a family in Minneapolis, Minnesota.

I was twenty-three years old and I had never been a father. But from the moment those two girls were placed in my care at Kimpo Airport, I became one — temporarily, practically, with everything I had. In my imagination I was going to be the best father possible for those twenty hours. I was going to be calm and competent and the kind of steady presence that two four-year-old girls crossing the Pacific for the first time needed beside them.

Robin threw up on the airplane.

Milk and food, everywhere — on her, on the seat, on me, on the general vicinity. The dream of calm competent fatherhood met the reality of a sick child at thirty thousand feet, and I was busy cleaning up when the flight attendant arrived, assessed the situation with professional efficiency, asked us to step aside, and handled the airplane while I handled Robin. I was proud as a peacock being seen by the other passengers as the father of these two beautiful girls, even with the circumstances being what they were.

What I did not know, cleaning up Robin at thirty thousand feet over the Pacific, was that those girls would become part of my life for decades. Their adoptive mother brought them back to Korea in 1998 when they graduated from high school — to see their motherland, to understand where they had come from. I spent time with them. I was their tour guide. They sat in

Youngnak Church and watched their Uncle Bill translate simultaneously from Korean to English. They call me Uncle Bill still. The relationship that began with vomit and a flight attendant has outlasted more carefully arranged things.

Over several years I escorted twenty-three children in total — to Minneapolis, New York, Chicago, and other cities. Each time the same essential experience: small hands in mine at the departure gate, new hands taking over at the arrival gate, and the walk back through the terminal alone. I learned something from those trips that I could not have learned any other way. Love is not diminished by its brevity. Those children were fully mine for the hours we traveled together, and then fully someone else's, and both things were completely true.

* * *

About a five-minute drive from Hwarang was another children's home — poorer, older, more precarious. Where Hwarang was cement block construction, this place was housed in what could only be described as a fifty-year-old barn. The floors were heated the traditional Korean way, with coal — yeontan, the cylindrical coal briquette with holes, top to bottom, eight inches across — but the building itself was tired. Termites had found it. It was not going to stand indefinitely.

A Korean American pastor from Los Angeles had heard about this orphanage and felt called to take it over, to raise money, to build something better for these children. He came to Korea and stayed temporarily, trying to develop relationships and support. He needed help. I heard about him. We met.

My heart was shaken. I knew I needed to move.

So, I did. I left Hwarang and moved into Sungshin Children's Home as their resident missionary. I drove the van. I helped with worship. I lived in a room with the oldest high school boys — a room roughly eight feet by eight feet, five of

us in it each night, sleeping next to and on top of and tangled up with each other's legs. Sleeping was hard work. The coal-heated floor kept us warm from below while the thin walls offered whatever the night outside decided to give us from above. You learned to sleep deeply or not at all.

The goal was to raise enough money to tear down the old facility and build something new. American army engineers volunteered their equipment — bulldozers and excavation machinery that cleared the site and dug the basement at no cost, which saved a significant amount of money. Korean contractors then built the new three-story facility. It rose on the same land where the barn had stood.

And then we learned something that hindsight made obvious and foresight had not.

People give generously when they see children living in a barn. The visual moves them. The need is visible, the poverty undeniable, the contrast between what is and what should be is impossible to ignore. Donations came. The building fund grew. We started construction before we had the full amount — thinking that the same rate of giving would continue, that momentum would carry us to completion.

It did not.

When donors came back to visit and saw children living in a new three-story building, their hearts were not moved in the same way. The urgency was gone. The barn was gone. The need that had been visible was now housed behind new walls and the giving slowed. We finished the building, but with difficulty, and I carried the lesson forward into everything I would do later about fundraising and building projects.

Raise one hundred and twenty percent before you start. Not eighty percent. Not one hundred. One hundred and twenty. Because the donors who gave when the need was urgent will

not all give again when the need looks solved. New donors must be found, and they are harder to find once the visible need has been addressed. That is not a critique of donors. It is simply how human generosity works and knowing it saves grief.

* * *

I lived at Sungshin until the night before my wedding.

It was a Friday morning. The older children had already left for school. The younger ones were being organized for their daily program — the staff moving them through the morning routine, voices calling, small feet on the floor. I walked from my room to the office. I said what needed to be said. And then I picked up my bag — one bag, holding everything I owned, all the personal clothes and belongings that had been in that eight-by-eight room with five boys — and I walked through the gates.

The morning continued behind me. Children being organized. Staff doing their work. Nobody made a scene. I had not wanted a scene. A big goodbye would have been for me, not for them, and what they needed on an ordinary Friday morning was an ordinary Friday morning.

But as I passed through the gates something struck me that I was not prepared for.

I am taking more out of this place than I was able to leave here for these children.

I had come to give. I had given what I could — time, presence, driving, translating, sleeping on a platform in a room with five boys and losing blankets in the dark. But what those years had given me was larger than what I had brought through the gates. The language. The understanding of Korean family life from the inside. The twenty-three children I had escorted across the Pacific. The understanding of what it means to be family with people who are not your blood. The capacity to love

without permanence — to give fully and then release fully and trust that the love does not disappear when the proximity ends.

There was no room at the orphanage for a married couple. That was simply true. And high school students did not need newlyweds living beside them — that was also simply true. I intended to stay connected after the wedding. I planned to keep helping as much as I could, even while finding work to provide for my wife. I was not planning to disappear.

But the children felt it as abandonment. I have thought about that many times since. They were children who had already been left — by parents, by circumstances, by a world that had not made room for them. They understood abandonment before they understood marriage. And when Missionary Bill walked out the gate with one bag on a Friday morning, the conclusion was available to them immediately.

He loves someone more than he loves us. That must be true. Otherwise, he would not have left.

I wanted to deny it. I could not. Not entirely. It was not that I loved them less — I did not love them less. But someone had come into my life who changed where I lived and how I lived and what the center of my daily world looked like. The children were not wrong to feel what they felt. They were just feeling the truth from a child's angle.

I walked to my wedding carrying that too.

I walked to my wedding carrying all of that.

The children of Sungshin are adults now. Many of them. We have a group chat — SMS, the way Koreans stay connected — and I am included. When traditional holidays come and Koreans gather with their families, sometimes a message goes out and some of us meet. This is family. Not the family I was born into, not the family I married into, but the family that formed around a coal-heated floor and a barn that became a

building and a bag I carried out of a gate one Friday morning in October 1987.

Jesus had been arranging that family since the day Joe Hale needed help carrying boxes.

* * *

Chapter Five continues...

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Chapter Five

Jakyung

There are moments in a life that you do not recognize as moments until long after they have passed. You are in the middle of them eating galbi and trying to remember the Korean word for delicious and making ten girls laugh with your street-learned mispronunciations, and you have no idea that God is doing something in the room that will take years to fully understand.

That is how I met my wife.

* * *

Joey called from Suwon. His mother had made galbi, and he was hosting a farewell lunch at the Kim family home. His father — Dr. Billy Kim, 김장환 목사 — had just returned from a North American tour with a Korean high school girls' ensemble, ten young women who had spent two months traveling through churches across America and Canada, singing with style and grace, raising funds and building bridges between the Korean church and the Korean diaspora abroad. The tour had been a success. Dr. Kim was a man who knew how to make things succeed.

I should say something about Dr. Kim, because to leave him out would be dishonest and to reduce him to a footnote would

be equally wrong. He was Joey's father, which is how I knew him — but he was also one of the most significant Christian voices in Korea in the twentieth century. He had left Korea as a boy, finished his education in America including seminary at Bob Jones University, and returned to Korea as a missionary in 1959. He became senior pastor of Central Baptist Church in Suwon. He led Korea Youth For Christ. He headed Far East Broadcasting Company in Korea. In 1973, when Billy Graham held a city crusade in Seoul, it was Dr. Billy Kim who stood beside him at every session and translated — a young Korean pastor interpreting for the most famous evangelist in the world, in front of crowds that numbered in the hundreds of thousands. His own story could fill several books and deserves to.

What matters here is what his story did for mine. He was Joey's father. Joey was my roommate. And Joey's father had invited me to a farewell lunch for the ensemble.

I went.

* * *

The room was full of young women. Ten of them, all roughly my age, all recently graduated from Korean high school, all carrying two months of American and Canadian homes and churches and English in their bodies alongside the Korean they had grown up speaking. They were curious and warm, and they moved as a group the way Korean girls of that age and background move — no single one stepping forward to claim attention, the group itself the unit, the group itself the social organism.

I was the comedian.

Not because I was trying to be funny — or not only because of that. It happened naturally, inevitably, in the gap between what they knew and what I knew. Their English came from textbooks. My Korean came from the streets of Gwangju,

which meant it came from young women who had taught me expressions and inflections that belonged to young women, which meant that when I opened my mouth in Korean I was both impressive — a foreigner speaking their language — and hilarious, because what I said and how I said it did not match the person saying it. They wanted to practice their textbook English. I wanted to practice my street Korean. We were each other's slightly broken mirror, and the laughter was real and warm and the lunch lasted longer than lunches usually last.

I was not looking for a wife. I want to be clear about that. I was twenty-one years old and I had been in Korea for a few months, and I was still not entirely certain I was supposed to be there at all. I had been told more than once that Korea did not need foreign missionaries. I had been deported and reinstated and was living on a missionary visa that felt provisional, like a door that had been opened partway and might close again. I had not arrived at the place in my mind — or my heart — where marrying a Korean woman seemed like something that was available to me. Not spiritually. Just — practically, culturally. I was still figuring out whether Korea wanted me here at all. Finding a soulmate had not made the list.

What I wanted, more than anything, was to be liked. To be accepted. To be on the inside of something rather than on the outside looking in. I had been outside so many things for so long — the boy without a father, the boy with the food stamps, the foreigner in the lobby who could not find his bus. I wanted to sit at a table and belong to it.

At that table in Suwon, with galbi and ten curious faces and laughter filling the room, I belonged to it. For one afternoon I was not a foreign missionary who had arrived too late to be needed. I was just a young man who made people laugh, and that was enough.

I did not know which face I was looking at. I did not know that one of them would become Jakyung Lyu (류자경) Niki, as she would come to be known by her English name — and that Jakyung would become my wife and the mother of my daughters and the person standing beside me for everything that came after. I was just eating galbi and getting the tones wrong in my Korean and enjoying the afternoon.

God knew. He had arranged the whole thing — Joey's phone call, Dr. Kim's tour, the timing of my missionary visa, the farewell lunch on that day. He had been arranging it for longer than I understood. I just had not been told yet.

* * *

The ensemble gradually became a quartet.  [view photo](#)

Over the months that followed, some of the girls moved on to other things — jobs, marriage, the ordinary next steps of life after high school. Some simply drifted away from the group. By the time the dust settled, four remained, still singing together, still traveling to churches and events, a tight unit of young women with voices that harmonized and faith that held.

One of them was Jakyung Lyu.

I did not fall in love with her immediately. I want to tell this honestly because the honest version is better than the romantic version. What happened was slower and stranger and more like something being revealed than something being chosen. We were in the same circles — Joey's world, the world of young Korean Christians connected to Dr. Kim's ministry, the world that I was slowly finding my way into. We saw each other at events. We talked, in the mixture of Korean and English that was our shared language — her textbook English meeting my street Korean somewhere in the middle, both of us working harder than the conversation required, both of us finding the work worthwhile.

She was not what I expected. I am not certain I had expectations — but if I had, she would not have fit them. She was quiet in a way that was not shyness. It was more like stillness. The room could be loud and she was still. She listened before she spoke, and when she spoke it was worth waiting for.

She had come to faith on her own. Not in a Christian home — she was the only believer in her family. She had begun attending church as a young girl in elementary school, and then she attended a high school founded by a Christian man, and somewhere in those years the faith she had encountered became genuinely her own. She had made that decision alone and carried it alone inside a home that did not share it. That is a particular kind of faith — not inherited, not performed, not supported by the people sitting across from you at the dinner table. It is faith that must decide, every day, to keep being faith.

I had grown up watching my mother's faith work the same way. Quiet. Steady. Expressed in hands and presence rather than words. Something in me recognized it in Jakyung before I had words for what I was recognizing.

But I am still getting ahead of myself. Before Jakyung was my wife. Before any of that, there was a great deal of ordinary life that had to be lived, and I had to live it first, and not all of it was easy, and not all of it was wise.

* * *

I was learning Korea the slow way — the only real way. Not from textbooks, not from cultural orientation programs, not from the careful explanations of people who wanted to help me avoid mistakes. From mistakes. From the education that comes from getting things wrong in a foreign language and a foreign culture and having to figure out, afterward, what you did and why it landed the way it did.

Korean culture is built on a foundation of Confucian values that are invisible until you bump into them. Priority of age. Hierarchy. The feelings of the other person arriving before your own. Intuition and wit as the primary tools of social navigation. What is said is often less important than what is not said — the meaning lives in the eyes, the silences, the small adjustments of posture and expression that carry entire conversations.

I was terrible at all of it. I was an Oklahoma boy who said what he meant and meant what he said, and I had landed in a culture where both of those habits required modification. I bumped into things. I misread things. I offended people without knowing it and was forgiven more often than I deserved.

But I was learning. Korean was coming — slowly, then faster, the way languages come when you are living inside them rather than studying them from a distance. I moved back to Seoul and enrolled in the language program at Yonsei University, the only institution in Korea at the time that taught Korean as a foreign language. I lived with a Korean family — a retired one-star army general and his wife. They had four children. The two oldest, a daughter and a son, were living in the United States. Their second daughter, Young-hee (이영희 누나), was living at home.  [view photo](#) Their youngest son was fulfilling his required military service on Jeju Island, which meant his bedroom was empty, and that empty room became mine. Their house was quiet and orderly and an education in itself — in how a Korean family moved, how meals worked, how the rhythms of a home built on Confucian values felt from the inside. I ate Korean food at every meal. I watched Korean television. I dreamed, eventually, in Korean.

What I did not anticipate was that I would become part of the family.

They welcomed me not as a tenant or a language student passing through but as a son — a foster son, in every way that mattered. Holidays were spent together. The relationship deepened year by year. At one point I needed money and my Korean mother was my only resource. She told me what Korean wisdom teaches — that you should not loan money to friends because the relationship can be damaged by the disappointment of borrowing and repaying. And then she loaned me the money anyway. I paid it back as quickly as I could. The relationship only grew deeper for it.

When my Korean mother passed away years later, I was asked to preach and pray at her graveside. And then a few years after that, when my Korean father passed away, I was asked again. We were family. Not by blood. Not by paperwork. By the accumulation of meals and holidays and trust and the grace of people who opened a room in their home and ended up opening everything else as well.

And through all of it, the question that had followed me since the first weeks in Gwangju continued to follow me.

Why are you here? Korea doesn't need you.

I had not stopped believing God had sent me. But I had stopped being certain what He had sent me to do. The answer I had carried since I was thirteen years old — I am going to be a missionary — was still true. I just did not yet know what it meant in this specific place, at this specific time, in a country that was sending its own missionaries and building its own churches and did not particularly need a young man from Oklahoma to come explain Jesus to them.

The answer, when it came, did not come through a plan or a program. It came through people. It always came through people.

It came through an orphanage in Uijeongbu. Through eighty-five children who needed a big brother and a van driver and someone who would sleep in their room and play soccer in their yard and not leave when it got hard. Through twenty-three children I escorted on international adoption flights to Minneapolis and New York and Chicago — little ones whose futures were on the other side of an ocean, whose hands I held until the new family's hands could take over.

It came through a friendship golf tournament between Korean businessmen and American military officers who needed a translator for their dinner speeches, and who asked the missionary every time to pray before the meal, and who built relationships across the table that eventually found their way back to the orphanage in the form of help.

It came through a church — small, new, just beginning — where I served as youth pastor and watched Korean teenagers find faith of their own.

And it came, slowly, undeniably, through a quiet woman with a voice that harmonized and a faith that was genuinely her own.

* * *

I will not pretend that the path to marrying Jakyung was simple or straight. My heart had been in other places before hers. There had been a girl in Oklahoma — a first love, the kind that feels final when you are nineteen and feels like a chapter when you are older. That chapter had closed by the time I came to Korea, though not cleanly and not without pain. There had been the foolishness of an ultimatum sent by letter across the Pacific — either trust me or send back the ring — and the ring had come back, and I had deserved that.

In the years that followed I had other friendships, other conversations, other people who passed through the story. And

through all of it, Jakyung was there — not as a romantic interest, not as someone I had identified as a potential wife, but as a friend. My closest friend in Korea. I told her everything. My struggles, my mistakes, the complications of my heart, the challenges of being a foreigner trying to find his place. She listened and gave her opinion with the directness of someone who cares enough to be honest and the gentleness of someone who knows how to deliver honesty without damage. She never made our friendship about herself. She never demanded anything. She was simply present, and her presence was the most uncomplicated thing in my life.

I was waiting to fall head over heels in love. That was my picture of how it was supposed to happen — overwhelming, unmistakable, the kind that arrives like weather and leaves no doubt. I was holding out for that feeling.

Dr. Dick Nieusma — the dentist missionary from Gwangju, the man who had let me use his American washing machine and fed me American lunches and loved me like family in my first months in Korea — looked at me one day and asked a question that cut straight through everything I thought I knew.

Why don't you marry your friend?

Not a friend. Your friend. He had seen what I could not see from the inside — that the woman I had been telling everything to, the woman whose advice I trusted above anyone else's, the woman who was young and kind and non-demanding and genuinely herself in every conversation we had ever had — that woman was not just a friend. She was the person.

I had been so busy waiting for the feeling to arrive that I had not noticed it was already there, wearing the clothes of friendship.

I spent the next two weeks in evening prayer. Not rushed prayer — careful, deliberate prayer, the kind where you bring a

question and sit with it and wait for an answer rather than manufacturing one. The question was simple: is Jakyung the person? After two weeks God gave me peace. The answer was clear.

I went to Jakyung. I proposed.

That was the first moment either of us knew. The friendship had never signaled where it was going — not to her, not to me. The proposal was the shift, for both of us, from one thing into something neither of us had seen coming. She had been my counselor. Now I was asking her to be my wife.

She said yes — but not simply. She had conditions.

The first I already knew. She would not marry a pastor. I had addressed that — I was a missionary, a parachurch worker, not a Sunday morning preacher. She accepted that distinction.

The second stopped me.

She said we could choose an interracial marriage as adults — that was our right. But she did not want natural-born children. It would not be fair to them. Growing up Amerasian — American and Asian in one body — would be hard. The world was not always kind to children who belonged to two places at once and fit perfectly in neither. We could adopt, she said. But not our own.

I sat with that. It was not a small thing. Did I want to marry someone who would not have our own children? But I had spent weeks before the proposal in evening prayer, asking God whether Jakyung was the person. The answer that came back was clear. She was. And if she was the person, then the rest would find its way.

I told her I needed to speak to her brother.

She arranged it. We had dinner with her brother and his wife one evening. I asked him formally — would he give me

permission to marry his sister? He said he could not answer that. I would have to ask his father.

He arranged the meeting.

Jakyung's father received me alone. I sat on the floor in the Korean way — formally, on my knees, not cross-legged, the posture of a man presenting himself with respect. I asked him for permission to marry his daughter.

He was quiet for a moment. Then he told me — she is my only daughter, and the youngest in the family. I will give you permission to marry her on one condition. You must promise to live in Korea as a missionary for the rest of your life.

I understood why he asked. He was not being unreasonable. He was asking for his daughter not to disappear to the other side of the world.

I told him the truth. As a follower of Jesus, I must be obedient to God above all else. If it is God's will for me to live in Korea as a missionary for the rest of my life — and I believe it is — then yes. I make that promise.

He said yes.

I want to add a footnote to that promise — one that came about twenty-five years later.

Jakyung's parents passed away within three months of each other. We had built a good relationship with them over the years. After the second funeral, when both were gone, I turned to Jakyung in what I believed was a moment of gentle liberation.

I said — now I'm a free man.

She looked at me. What do you mean?

I said — well, now that your parents aren't alive, we're free to move wherever we want in the world.

She said — no. You promised. The promise had nothing to do with their death. You made that promise to God and to my father. It stands as long as you are alive.

I had thought the condition came with an expiration date. She informed me it did not.

And she was right. The promise was never really about her parents. It was about Korea — her name, her culture, her language, the things her father had wanted to protect by asking that question in the first place. Those things did not die with him. They were still here. And so was I.

* * *

The question of children resolved itself in the most unexpected way — in a rental car at Los Angeles International Airport.

I had been in Buenos Aires for five weeks of CBMC training. Jakyung flew to Los Angeles. I flew to Los Angeles. We were going to drive together to Colorado Springs for a conference. I got the rental car, parked it, went in to meet her at arrivals. We loaded her bags. We got in the car, ready to get on the highway.

She said — quietly, in the ordinary moment before a long drive — I stopped taking my birth control pill.

Five weeks apart had told her something that no conversation could have told her. Home was not home without a family. She had changed her mind. She was willing for us to have our own children. Two, she said. Two years apart. That was her plan.

I listened carefully. I considered the situation. And then I made a practical observation.

We had both just gotten off long international flights. We were tired. The drive to Colorado Springs was several hours. It would not be responsible to drive in that condition. The sensible thing — really the only reasonable thing — was to find a hotel nearby and rest before attempting the highway.

Jakyung agreed that this was very sensible.

It is entirely possible that our oldest daughter Sarah was conceived in Los Angeles that evening. I cannot prove it. But the timing, as they say, was not coincidental.

Sarah was born in 1990. Anna was born in 1992. Twenty-five months apart.

We named our first daughter Sarah after my grandmother, Sarah Majors.  [view photo](#) She had been such an example of grace, mercy, and love in my life. She helped my mother — financially and with moral support — raise us during the years we lived in Wichita. She always welcomed us to come see her for holidays and summers, whenever my mother could drive us up from Stillwater.

Two beautiful daughters. Raised between two countries, two languages, two cultures — exactly what Jakyung had once feared would be unfair to a child. What she found instead was that children raised between worlds do not fall between them. They stand on both.

God had known that. He let Jakyung discover it herself, in a rental car, before a long drive to Colorado.

* * *

We were married on October 31, 1987.  [view photo](#)

Elder John Song presided over the ceremony. His four children — Hannah, Mina, Samuel, and Jacob — sang as a quartet. Special music at a wedding, offered by the family that had housed me in Gwangju five years earlier, the family whose room I had slept in and whose table I had eaten at and whose post office box combination I had memorized. They were there. They were singing.

My mother came from Oklahoma. No other member of my American family could make the journey. But the people who had become my family in Korea were there — the Song family, children from Sunghsin Children's Home, friends from the US

Army connections we had built through the orphanage. A wedding assembled from the life Bill Majors had lived, not the life he had come from.

Among the guests were Colonel Ray Shaw and his wife Doris. Ray had been part of the military assistance when we tore down the old orphanage facilities — his unit had provided equipment and manpower that saved us significant money on the construction. He and Doris had become friends through the orphanage work.

Before the wedding, they asked us quietly what we planned to do about wedding rings.

I had lived in orphanages for years. I did not have money for rings.

They said they hoped it would not offend us — they did not want to insult us — but they had something they wanted to offer. Doris had been married before, and she had her previous wedding band. She wanted Jakyung to have it if she was willing. And Doris, years earlier, had also found a man's ring in a park somewhere and kept it without knowing why. She wanted to offer it to me, as a temporary ring until we could afford our own.

They offered these things with such gentleness and such care that there was nothing to be offended by. We had the rings refitted. We wore them at the ceremony.

We wore them for thirty-five years.

On our thirty-fifth wedding anniversary, Jakyung and I bought our own rings. But for thirty-five years we had worn a ring found in a park and a ring from a previous marriage — offered by a colonel and his wife who did not want to insult us, who had no idea they were giving us something we would carry for more than three decades.

That is how God provided for a man who went by faith. Not always through dramatic miracles. Sometimes through a colonel who found a ring in a park and did not know why he kept it.

I will not try to compress what the marriage itself means into a paragraph — the years of knowing each other, the conversations in broken languages that found their way to whole understanding, the faith she brought and the faith I brought and what they became together. Those years deserve their own telling, and they will get it in the chapters that follow.

What I want to say here is simpler.

I had come to Korea as a boy who did not know whether Korea wanted him. I had sat on a suitcase in an airport lobby and felt lost in a crowd. I had been deported and reinstated and told more times than I could count that my calling did not make sense in this context. I had bumped into walls I could not see and offended people I was trying to love and gotten the tones wrong and the expressions wrong and the silences wrong.

And God had given me, in the middle of all of that, a woman who was from this country. Who carried it in her bones and her language and her faith. Who could reach the places I could not reach and understand the things I could not understand and stand in rooms where I would always be a foreigner and make those rooms feel like home.

He had arranged it at a farewell lunch in Suwon. He had been arranging it before that — through Joey, through Dr. Kim, through Elder Song's letter of invitation, through every step of the road that had led a boy from Oklahoma to a table full of galbi and laughter and ten curious faces.

I had not been looking for a soulmate. I had been looking for a place to belong.

He gave me both.

She is still here. After everything — the ladder accident that nearly killed me, the churches, the ministries, the years and the miles and the losses and the mercies — she is still here.

That is not nothing. That is everything.

* * *

Chapter Six continues...

* * *

Chapter Six

Youngnak

On October 31, 1987, Jakyung Lyu and Bill Majors were married.

In Korea, a wife keeps her own family name after marriage — the name her parents gave her is hers to keep. Jakyung remained Jakyung Lyu. That is as it should be.

I had been living in an eight-by-eight room with five high school boys until the morning before the wedding. I walked out of Sungshin Children's Home with one bag, got married, and began the next chapter of my life.

We needed a place to live. In Korea, that meant key money.

Key money (전세) was the Korean system of leasing a home without paying rent. You gave the owner approximately two-thirds of the home's value as a lump sum. You lived in the home for two years. At the end of the lease, assuming no damage, the owner returned your full amount with no interest. No monthly payments. No rent. The reason the system existed was that Korean banks required eighty percent equity for a mortgage — meaning most people were saving toward the full purchase price while letting tenants' key money serve as their working capital.

My mother lent us eight thousand dollars.

My maternal grandmother had raised us on a single principle about money — spend less than you make, never carry debt, and never let debt become a spiral. My mother Mary had lived by that same principle, managing government welfare checks with the discipline of a banker, making ends meet on almost nothing. That voice was in my head from childhood, and it spoke loudly the moment I signed the key money agreement. These eight thousand dollars needed to be repaid. Fast. Before debt became comfortable.

I repaid it within the first year.

What that meant practically was that Jakyung washed our clothes by hand.

We could not afford a washing machine until the debt was cleared. Small Korean apartments of that era did not have dryers anyway — clothes were hung on indoor racks or on the balcony clothesline. But the washing machine itself, the basic appliance that would have made the laundry manageable, was not purchased until the eight thousand was gone. Jakyung had grown up with her mother doing the laundry by hand, so the method was not foreign to her. What was foreign was the reason — her husband's stubborn philosophical commitment to a grandmother's principle about debt.

She endured it. She did not endure it entirely in silence. There were arguments. There was a burden she carried that I was perhaps too rigid to fully acknowledge at the time. I knew what I believed about debt and I held to it with the kind of unemotional determination that made me effective in some areas and difficult to live with in others. The ladder accident, seven years later, would forcibly develop the side of my brain that understood what that kind of stubbornness cost the people around me. But that was seven years away. In 1987 I was certain

I was right, and the washing machine waited until the debt was paid.

When it arrived, it was welcomed.

* * *

The 1988 Seoul Summer Olympics were coming.

Korea was preparing to show itself to the world — the nation that had risen from the ashes of the Korean War, that had transformed itself within a generation from one of the poorest countries on earth to an economic force with something to say. The Olympics were not just a sporting event. They were a statement. And they required something Korea had not yet fully done — opening its doors.

When I arrived in 1982, Korea was still a largely closed society. Ordinary citizens could not easily leave. Foreigners could not easily stay. The country that had survived occupation and war and poverty had turned inward to protect itself. But the Olympics demanded the opposite. If Korea wanted a relationship with the world, it had to lower its walls and let the world in. New subway lines were built — numbers two, three, and four, connecting a city that previously had only one. New apartment complexes went up to house the athletes. Laws and limitations that had governed movement for decades began quietly to shift. The 1988 Olympics was the moment Korea decided it was ready to be seen. Seoul did not have enough hotels and motels to house the thousands of visitors who would descend on the city that summer. New subway lines — numbers two, three, and four — were being built. New apartment complexes were going up, built on the condition that they would house Olympic athletes first and then transfer to the original buyers. The city was in motion.

The Korean church went into motion too.

Christian Business Men's Committees — CBMC — had a membership of chairmen, CEOs, and presidents of companies. White-collar professionals, men of means, men with homes large enough to have a spare room. CBMC decided to run a homestay program. Match foreign tourists who needed accommodation with Christian Korean families who had space to offer. The visitors would stay in Korean homes, eat Korean food, attend Korean churches, experience Korean Christian life from the inside — and the families would use the opportunity to share their faith.

They needed someone to run the program. Someone who could communicate with foreign tourists in English and with Korean families in Korean. Someone who understood both worlds.

They found me.  [view photo](#)

I helped match tourists with homes. I gave directions from the airport. I coordinated the logistics of dozens of families opening their doors to strangers from around the world. It was not glamorous work. It was exactly the kind of work that needs doing and rarely gets done well because it requires someone who can operate fluently in two languages and two cultures simultaneously.

That summer I could do that. Korea had given me that.

It is worth noting — CBMC International headquarters and CBMC USA were located two blocks from Tennessee Temple University in Chattanooga. I had walked past them for three years without ever making a connection. God had been saving that connection for Seoul, for 1988, for exactly this.

When the Olympics homestay program ended, CBMC International invited me to serve as their Asian Director for one year — 1989. It was a remarkable thing to be asked. I was young, inexperienced in Asian business culture, and had never held a

regional directorship of anything. But the invitation came and I accepted it.

The training began in Buenos Aires, Argentina, under the South American Director. Five weeks was the plan. Then Eastern Airlines announced bankruptcy.

The announcement came suddenly — the last airplane leaving the airport would be first come, first served. That was not a sentence designed to produce calm. What should I do? Did I have the authority to decide on my own, or did this require agreement from CBMC International in Chattanooga? Did the South American Director have the authority to decide together with me? The questions moved fast and the clock moved faster.

A message went to Chattanooga. The answer came back — there was a field director in the Miami area who could take me in and complete my training there. Go to the airport. Go now.

I went. I stood by at the gate. The boarding process was finishing. Fifteen minutes before it closed, I got on the plane.

From Miami I completed my training. After that I flew to Los Angeles to meet Jakyung, and the two of us drove to Colorado Springs for a CBMC staff conference. It was in the rental car at LAX, before we got on the highway, that Jakyung told me she had stopped taking her birth control pill. After the conference I returned to Seoul. The year that followed took me to Japan, Taiwan, and the Philippines — countries where CBMC already had a presence — and to Vietnam and Thailand, where the goal was to plant seeds, to share the vision of gospel in the marketplace, to meet Christian businessmen who might catch the vision and carry it forward. There were plans to go further, but budget and contacts were still works in progress.

It was a wonderful year in many ways. A young man from Oklahoma, traveling across Asia, meeting men who were trying

to live their faith inside their businesses, encouraging what was already there and introducing what was not yet. The seeds went into the ground. Whether they found good soil in every place, only time and God would show.

At the end of the year, the Director of CBMC Korea absorbed my role into his own responsibilities. It cost less. One position instead of two.

I felt fired.

I wanted to blame others — the structure, the budget, the lack of direct communication, the cultural gap between what I expected to be told and the Korean way of communicating decisions through reorganization rather than conversation. In Korea, Confucian values place the feelings of the listener above the directness of the message. You do not say — Bill, this isn't working. You restructure in a way that makes the conversation unnecessary. I had grown up in a culture where the hard thing was said to your face, where *Bill, stop being the victim* was considered an act of love. That directness was not available to me here. The message arrived through an org chart instead of a conversation, and I had to learn to receive it.

But I want to be honest — and this book has required honesty throughout — when I look at what happened clearly, the decision was also wise. I was young. I was inexperienced in the nuances of Asian business culture. I lacked the self-motivation and internal passion that a role like that requires when nobody is looking over your shoulder. More direct development and communication from CBMC International could have helped. But the core issue was mine to own.

I take the responsibility.

That is a sentence I have had to say more than once in my life. It never gets easier. But it is always the right thing.

* * *

When the CBMC Asian Director position ended in 1989, Jakyung was pregnant with our first child. I needed a salary. A real one, weekday work, something that would provide for a family that was growing.

I was already translating on Sunday mornings at Younknak Church. But Sundays were not enough.

I applied to Goldstar — the electronics company now known as LG Electronics — and was hired. Their offices were in the West Tower on Yoido, in what was called the Twin Towers. I was placed in the overseas administration team — seven people in total, including me. My responsibilities were twofold: proofreading anything the company produced in English, and assisting with cross-cultural training for employees being sent abroad for five-year postings.

The training program was serious work. Employees would spend a year in morning English conversation classes — one hour before work every day. Then came one month of intensive cross-cultural training at a center about an hour from Seoul, and this time the employee's wife and children came too. The whole family needed to be prepared for life in a foreign country. I knew something about that.

I signed a two-year contract. Among the seven people on the team was a man named Hee-joong Kim (김희중). His family and mine have maintained a friendship of thirty-five years and counting.

When the two-year contract ended, our second daughter was on the way, and I was ready to extend. But a different opportunity appeared first.

A friend from my US Army contract connections — John Green — had been hired by Grumman, the American aerospace and defense company, which had secured a sixteen-million-dollar contract with the Korean National Police. John

wanted me as the translator between the police and the Grumman engineers, and as the manager of administration for Grumman and its subcontractors, which included Motorola.

I accepted.

The first four months were productive — good work, clear purpose. We set up a new office, bought furniture and equipment, hired a driver and a secretary. I translated in meeting after meeting between Korean police officials and American engineers. The work felt solid.

Then the HR manager from the main office arrived. He sat me down and explained quickly and without warmth that they were not satisfied with my work. He offered two months' pay to help me find another job. If I collected my personal belongings immediately, he would walk me out.

I was struck as if someone had hit me across the side of the head.

I went home dragging my heart behind me.

Months later I understood what had happened — the contract between Grumman and the Korean National Police had collapsed entirely. When a sixteen-million-dollar contract falls apart, the company moves quickly to minimize losses, which means letting go of local contracted employees as cheaply as possible. It was not personal. It was financial. I was collateral damage in a business failure that had nothing to do with my performance.

But I did not know that when I walked out the door. I only knew I had been dismissed.

Jakyung got half the story — not because I was hiding the rest, but because I did not fully understand it myself yet. In our marriage, as in most Korean families of that generation, there was an unspoken division of responsibility. I was the minister of foreign affairs. She was the minister of internal affairs. The

outside world was mine to navigate and solve. The inside world — the home, the children, the daily rhythms of family life — was hers. When the outside collapsed, I came home and absorbed it quietly, and she kept managing the inside without the full picture of what had happened outside.

I was silent for a time. I spent time at home with Anna, who was a new baby, and Sarah, who was a toddler. The Sunday translations at Younknak continued. But the weekdays were hollow and I struggled to find my footing.

It was approximately four months after the Grumman dismissal that Rev. Lim sat me down and told me he hoped I would return to America to continue my seminary education. The door that Grumman had closed was not the last word. It rarely is.

* * *

The CBMC Seoul Committee held a weekly prayer breakfast. They invited me to share my testimony in Korean. The breakfast had a designated pastor from a major Korean church who came each week to lead the Bible study — and on this morning, the pastor assigned to the Seoul Committee was the senior pastor of Younknak Church.

His name was Rev. Lim, Youngsoo (임영수 목사님).

We were seated at the same table. I gave my testimony. He led the Bible study. Breakfast was served. And Rev. Lim asked me a question.

Had I ever visited Younknak Church?

I had not.

He invited me to come. He would give me a tour personally.

I accepted, not fully understanding what I was accepting.

* * *

I was not prepared for Younknak Church.

I knew it was a significant church — people had mentioned it. What I did not know was the weight of what significant meant in this case. When I arrived downtown and saw the campus, I stopped.

Four buildings. A large piece of land in the heart of Seoul. The main sanctuary built of stone — the architecture not merely functional but deliberately beautiful, the kind of building that says something is happening here that deserves a permanent home. I walked through it overwhelmed. Not intimidated exactly, but aware that I was standing inside something whose history I did not yet know and whose scale I had not anticipated.

I began to learn the history.

Younghak Church had been founded in December 1945 by Rev. Han Kyung-chik (한경직 목사님) a man who had come south as a refugee during the chaos of the Korean War period, leading a congregation of fellow refugees who had fled the north. They had set up a tent city on the land where the church now stood. Rev. Han had led Sunday worship and prayer meetings in those tents. When the war ended and life became possible again, the tent city became a church — and that church became one of the most significant congregations in the history of Korean Christianity.

Rev. Han Kyung-chik was not simply a pastor. He was a historical figure. A man whose faith had been tested by displacement and loss and the suffering of a nation divided, and who had emerged from that testing with a clarity of purpose that shaped everything he touched. Learning his story in pieces, hearing it from the people who had been formed by his ministry, I began to understand that I had walked into something that carried weight far beyond its address.

Rev. Lim invited me to join the pastoral staff for their Tuesday morning devotional. He asked if I would share an English devotion with them. I did.

And then he asked if I would serve as the simultaneous English translator for the Sunday morning worship services — two services, nine o'clock and eleven o'clock, every Sunday in the main auditorium. Foreigners attending the services would use headphones to hear the translation in real time as Rev. Lim preached in Korean.  [view photo](#)

I said yes.

* * *

Through my work with CBMC there was another annual event that I came to be part of — one I could not have anticipated and one I never took for granted.

The Korea National Prayer Breakfast.

Modeled after the National Prayer Breakfast in Washington DC, this annual event took place each spring when the President of Korea could fit it into his schedule — a gathering where Korean Christians could pray for their president and for the nation. Ambassadors, business leaders, and military officers from multiple countries were invited. It was a room full of significant people doing something quietly extraordinary — praying together across lines of nationality and rank and power.

CBMC carried a large share of the organizational responsibility for this event. And I was asked to be the simultaneous English translator — the only one — for the entire program.

There were two other translators present, handling Chinese and Japanese. But each of us carried the whole event alone in our language. Approximately ten people would speak from the podium across two hours of program. The translation had to

be continuous, accurate, and delivered in real time — no pausing to think, no asking for a repeat.

I should say something about where we were in the room. Simultaneous translators are heard but not seen. We worked from a temporary booth set up in the back — our voices traveling through headphones to the people who needed to hear the event in their language. We were not standing at a podium. We were not on stage. Nobody in the room was looking at us. We were useful and invisible, which is exactly the right combination for that kind of work.

By the end of those two hours each of us was exhausted in a particular way that only simultaneous translators know. Brain dead is the accurate description. Every word of every speech had passed through our minds twice.

The evening before each event, a manuscript would arrive from the President's office — official government stationery with gold lettering across the top, the text written in the formal technical language of a professional speechwriter. My job was to prepare overnight. To read it, understand it, find the English equivalents for its official Korean, and have it ready to render live the next morning.

For approximately fifteen years I was invited back — apart from the years I spent in Dallas for seminary and in Ansan during my first semester back in Korea. Five presidents, each serving a five-year term — Roh Tae-woo, Kim Young-sam, Kim Dae-jung, Roh Moo-hyun, and Lee Myung-bak. Each administration, each spring, the gold-lettered manuscript arrived, and I prepared and I stood in that room and translated for the President of Korea and his guests.

I am a boy from Oklahoma who came to Korea with nine hundred dollars and a cowboy hat. I translated the Korea National Prayer Breakfast for approximately fifteen years. I do

not have adequate words for what that means — only the recognition that it was never my doing. I was simply the person available who could do the job, placed there by a chain of connections that began with a dinner in Chattanooga and a letter in a post office box.

There was one other translation moment from that period that I want to place on the page.

Around 1989, at the Chamshil Outdoor Stadium in Seoul, I was asked to translate for a large revival service. The warm-up speakers included my home church pastor — Rev. Charles Hand, the senior pastor of Western Oaks Baptist Church in Bethany, Oklahoma. The key speaker for the evening was Robert Schuller from the Crystal Cathedral in California, one of the most prominent preachers in America at that time.

Before the revival began, the speakers and translators gathered for prayer. We stood in a circle. On one side of me was Robert Schuller. On the other side was Charles Hand.

Charles Hand was the pastor who had ordained me. He had stood at the front of Western Oaks Baptist Church on a Wednesday evening and laid his hands on my head and sent me out. Now I was standing beside him in a prayer circle in a Korean outdoor stadium, about to translate his words to a Korean crowd.

I do not know if he fully understood what that moment meant to the young man standing next to him. The calling that had begun in his church in Bethany had led to this — to standing between the pastor who ordained him and one of the most famous preachers in the world, in a country on the other side of the earth, useful and present and exactly where God had always been leading.

For five years, every Sunday morning, I sat in the translation booth at Younknak Church and put Rev. Lim's Korean into English as he spoke it. Simultaneously — not after the sentence was finished but inside it, word finding word, meaning chasing meaning, the Korean and the English running in parallel tracks in my brain. It was the most demanding language work I had ever done. It was also the finest school I had ever attended. Five years of sitting inside the preaching of a great pastor, hearing every word twice — once in Korean and once in my own English rendering of it — formed me in ways I am still understanding.

And occasionally — approximately once each quarter — the Pastor Emeritus himself preached. Rev. Han Kyung-chik. The founder of Younknak, the man who had led a congregation of North Korean refugees in a tent city and built one of the most significant churches in the history of Korean Christianity. He was elderly by then, but he still preached. He lived until April 2000, when he was ninety-seven years old — just months short of ninety-eight.

When Rev. Han preached, I translated.

I want to be careful not to claim more than I deserve in saying that. But I also want to be honest about what it was. I had the privilege of standing — invisibly, in a booth in the back — inside the preaching of two men who became guides and examples of what godliness looks like in a human life. Rev. Lim, Youngsoo. Rev. Han, Kyung-chik. One the active pastor, one the pastor emeritus. Both formed by the same faith, both shaped by the same history, both pointing in the same direction.

That was the finest school I ever attended. Five years of Sundays. And sometimes, four times a year, the voice of the man who had started it all.

Robin and Rachel sat in those pews in 1998, watching their Uncle Bill translate. They had been four years old when I wiped milk off an airplane seat. They were eighteen when they came back to see where they had come from, and they sat in a stone church in downtown Seoul and watched the man who had escorted them across the Pacific now escorting Korean words across the language barrier every Sunday morning.

* * *

After five years of Sunday mornings at Younknak, Rev. Lim called me into his office.

He told me it was time to go back to America for further education. Korea places an enormous value on academic credentials — not as a formality but as a genuine marker of the seriousness with which a person has pursued their field. If I was going to have the influence in Korea that he believed I could have, I needed the academic foundation to match.

His instruction was specific. Go to one seminary for a master's degree. Go to a different school for a doctorate. Do not stay in Korea to study — go to America, come back with what only America can give you, and your ministry here will be more effective than it would have been if you had stayed.

I went home and told Jakyung.

She was not excited. The question she asked was the right question — where is the money coming from? How do we move a family of four across the Pacific? The girls were three and one years old. She had built a life in Seoul. She had a home, relationships, a community, a routine. Her husband was asking her to dismantle all of it on the advice of a senior pastor and the leading of a God she trusted, and the finances were not clear.

I could not resolve her hesitation. I had tried. The arguments I had made at home had not moved her, partly because I was her husband and she knew my stubbornness and

partly because no argument I could make was stronger than her practical concern about money and children and displacement.

That Christmas, Rev. Lim and his wife invited Jakyung and me to dinner.

We assumed all the pastoral staff had been invited. When we arrived at the Hilton Millennium Hotel on Namsan — one of the finest hotels in Seoul, the city spread below it — we discovered it was just the four of us. Rev. Lim and his wife. Jakyung and me. A private dinner at a five-star hotel.

We sat down. We looked at our menus. And Rev. Lim looked across the table at Jakyung and said simply that he believed Bill should go to seminary in America.

Jakyung is Korean. She was raised in the Korean church. When a senior pastor of a great congregation speaks directly to you across a dinner table — not in a sermon, not in a general announcement, but to you personally, looking at you, saying your husband's name — it lands differently than a husband making the same argument at home. For a Korean Christian of Jakyung's generation, the senior pastor's word carries the weight that the Old Testament people felt when Moses came down from the mountain. You do not argue. You receive.

She looked down from her menu. She lifted her eyes. She said yes.

What I had been unable to accomplish alone, Rev. Lim accomplished with one sentence.

We applied to Dallas Theological Seminary. It was the closest seminary to my family in Oklahoma. We packed our lives again. The girls were three and one. Jakyung had said yes to a dinner she had not known was coming, in a hotel she had not known she was going to, for a future she had not fully chosen.

She went anyway.

That is who she is.

* * *

Applying to Dallas Theological Seminary turned out to be its own story.

It was the summer of 1993. I applied for the fall semester without any real concern about being accepted. The thought of not being accepted had not seriously occurred to me. I was going to seminary because the senior pastor of Younknak Church had told me to go, and God had confirmed it through Jakyung's yes at the Hilton dinner, and that was sufficient.

What I had not considered was my transcript.

I had graduated from Tennessee Temple University in 1982 — one year early, in a hurry to get to the mission field before Jesus came back. Grades had not been my priority. My first semester I had done well, but five newspaper routes before sunrise and the philosophy of passing rather than excelling had shaped the three years that followed. I had never imagined going beyond an undergraduate degree. Nobody in my immediate family had gone to college at all. Graduate school had not been part of any picture I had painted for myself.

That was eleven years before the DTS application. Eleven years in Korea, far from American academic conversations, unaware of things that had shifted while I was not watching.

One thing that had shifted was TTU's accreditation status.

Tennessee Temple had transitioned from college to university during those years. The library had been expanded to meet accreditation requirements. I had assumed that process was complete before I graduated in 1982. It was not. My diploma came from a school that had not yet been accredited at the time I received it. I did not know that. I was in Korea. I was not watching.

We left Korea and came to Oklahoma two weeks before the semester was to begin — giving the family time to reconnect with my family and friends before the move to Dallas. Each day in Oklahoma carried the anticipation of what was coming. The bags were packed. Dallas was next.

One week before the semester started, the phone rang.

It was for me. A professor named Robert Pyne — one of the members of the advisory board that decided admissions. He explained that the council had two struggles with my application.

The first was the accreditation issue. TTU was not accredited at the time of my graduation. DTS had standards about the institutions from which they accepted graduate students, and my diploma did not meet them.

The second was my GPA. It was 2.79 which was below what DTS required.

I was shaken to the bones. My voice cracked. I started stuttering. I could not hold the words together properly. What came out was not an argument — it was a plea. I told him that my family had come from Korea. That we had spent two weeks with my family in Oklahoma. That our bags were packed. That we were ready to come to Dallas. That I had said yes to this because the senior pastor of one of the most significant churches in Korea had told me to go, and my wife had agreed, and we had given up what we had in Seoul to come.

He listened.

He said he would discuss it with the council and call me back the next day.

I hung up the phone.

The next twenty-four hours were among the hardest of my life. Jakyung had two small children and a house full of in-laws and she took the immediate — the children, the meals, the

ordinary demands of a family living in someone else's home — and she let that be what her hands held. Whatever she felt underneath it, I was not told. Maybe she prayed silently in the dark. Maybe she was angry at the journey she had said yes to at a dinner she had not known was coming. Maybe she could not sleep. None of that came to me. She held it herself, the way she held so many things, so that I could hold the one thing I was already barely holding.

I waited.

The call came the next day.

Prof. Pyne told me the council had decided to accept me — on probation. If my grades fell below a C in any course, I would not be permitted to enroll for the second semester.

I said yes. Of course, I said yes.

When I walked into my first class at Dallas Theological Seminary, I felt like a man who had been abandoned in the desert — alone, thirsty, starving for something he had not known he needed until that moment. What I found in that classroom, and in every classroom that followed, and in every chapel service, was manna. High heaven manna, every day. The Word of God opened by men who had devoted their lives to understanding it, offered to a student who was finally, genuinely, completely hungry for it.

I never heard back from the council about my probationary status. Not because they forgot. Because my grades were A average. There was nothing to discuss. I was not proving anything to anybody. I was simply a man who had arrived at the right place at the right time, after eleven years of doing what he could with what he had and was being restored.

Restored. That is the word. Not just educated. Restored.

* * *

Seminary life had its own rhythms and its own demands.

I had put myself through college in Chattanooga delivering the Chattanooga Times before sunrise every morning for three years. In Dallas I found the same solution — the Dallas Morning News. Same principle, different city, considerably larger newspaper. The Dallas Morning News was the biggest paper I had ever tried to throw from a car window while driving through a neighborhood in the dark. The logistics of getting that many papers airborne from a moving vehicle at three in the morning is a skill that sounds simple and is not. I managed it. I had done it before. But it was hard — up at three, deliver, come home, classes during the day, study at night, sleep, repeat.

It was during my first semester that a different door opened.

The English pastor at Korean Presbyterian Church of Dallas — KPCD — had to return to Princeton to complete his seminary studies. He had come to Dallas as an intern, serving the junior high and high school students in the English Ministry, and now he had to go back. The Korean pastor for the young adults — college-age and career singles — was himself a DTS student, juggling full-time ministry at KPCD with full-time seminary studies while supporting a family of five. He told me it could be done. He was doing it. And there was a position open.

I needed to talk to Jakyung before I could consider an interview.

This required care. When I had proposed to Jakyung in Korea, she had told me something clearly — she would not marry a pastor. Not the lifestyle. Not the title that came with it in Korean church culture. The pastor's wife — Samonim — carried specific expectations that Jakyung had no interest in fulfilling. She was expected to have attended seminary herself, to lead women's Bible studies, to play piano, to cook for large numbers of guests, to be a particular kind of public person.

Jakyung had agreed to marry a missionary. A parachurch worker. Someone who worked with Youth for Christ and orphanages and the margins of things. Not a pastor who preached on Sundays in a church.

I had been safe. I was a missionary.

Now I needed to ask her to consider an interview for a pastoral position.

I had my pitch ready. It was just during seminary. Just this one time. And practically — if I got the position, we could move out of the one-bedroom student housing unit where four of us were living and into a two-bedroom apartment near the church. She knew what the 3 AM newspaper route looked like. She was living with it.

She bought into it.

The interview was also a kind of performance — not dishonest, but deliberate. My Korean ability, my eleven years living in Korea, my interracial marriage, my understanding of the culture from the inside — these were what I brought to the room that no other candidate could bring. Any pastor could help Korean American teenagers spiritually. What these parents were also hoping for was someone who might help their children hold onto what their families had carried across the ocean. The Korean language. The Korean identity. The sense that being Korean was not something to be embarrassed about or set aside in America.

When I opened my mouth and spoke to those Korean parents in Korean — fluent, natural, street-learned Korean that had been living in me for eleven years — I watched their faces change.

It felt like I had walked in dressed as Clark Kent and they had just seen the S on my chest.

I was not Superman. But in that room, in that moment, I understood what I represented to them. Not just a pastor. A bridge. Someone their children could not dismiss as simply American, simply foreign, simply unable to understand what it meant to move between two worlds.

In January 1994 I began as the English Ministry pastor at Korean Presbyterian Church of Dallas.

I was working full-time at KPCD, studying full-time at DTS, raising two small children with Jakyung, and sleeping as much as the schedule allowed. The newspaper routes were behind me. The manna continued every day in every class and every chapel.

It was the fullest season of my life. And it was about to become the most interrupted.

But before the ladder — one more story from those years that belongs on the page.

* * *

Two weeks before the 1988 Seoul Summer Olympics, an organization called World Sports Evangelism sent professional athletes to Korea — men and women who would use their sport as a platform to share their faith. They needed local volunteers to drive and translate. I signed up.

They assigned me to Steve Jones and his wife Bonnie.

Steve had been a professional golfer on the PGA Tour for several years. He was everything you would imagine a PGA professional to be — tall, precise, the kind of athlete whose natural motion looks effortless from a distance and is only revealed as work up close. But what mattered more was that he was strong in his faith and genuinely wanted to share it.

For six or seven days we went to Korean golf ranges together. Steve would step up and hit a few balls — which was enough to stop everyone within watching distance, because when a PGA professional strikes a golf ball it looks like

something from a different sport than what ordinary golfers are playing. Then he would stop and share his testimony — how he came to faith, what it meant to him to follow Jesus — and I translated. Then he would help a few of the Korean golfers with their swings. We did that every day.

Jakyung washed their clothes. The four of us ate Korean meals together. We became friends in the way that people become friends when they are doing meaningful work in close quarters for a week — quickly, and durably.

That friendship has lasted ever since. Steve has invited me to join him for practice rounds before tournaments, gotten me tickets to walk the course during competition. One of those invitations was to Pebble Beach — the course where Steve had won the AT&T National Pro-Am in 1988, the same year we met in Seoul. And in 1996 Steve Jones won the United States Open Championship, completing one of the remarkable comeback stories in professional golf — he had suffered severe ligament damage in a dirt-bike accident in 1991 and spent nearly three years away from the Tour before returning.

But the part of this story that belongs in this book happened in 1989.

After Korea, Steve had his best year on the PGA Tour — winning three tournaments. From those earnings he sent me a missionary support check. No announcement. No phone call. Just an envelope in the mail with a personal check made out to Bill Majors.

I looked at the amount and felt the breath go out of me. Three thousand dollars. That was going to go a long way toward building a house.

I went to the bank to deposit it.

The teller looked at the check. She looked at me. She processed the transaction.

I had miscounted the zeros.

It was not three thousand dollars. It was thirty thousand dollars. Steve and Bonnie Jones had sent thirty thousand dollars.

I could not hold onto myself. I had been shaken at three thousand. Thirty thousand left me speechless — standing at a bank window in Seoul trying to process what had just happened.

* * *

I need to back up slightly to explain why a house mattered so much.

In the summer of 1990, a Baptist missionary family going home for one year of furlough needed someone to watch their house in the north part of Seoul. They asked if we would come and live there. We said yes. The house was three stories with a small basement — a mansion compared to the seven hundred square feet we had been living in. Calvin and Debi Meeds, Baptist missionaries, lived in the house next door with their two children. It was something like a small missionary compound, two families living side by side, which was its own kind of grace.

Debi Meeds was our sunshine every day during that year. She is a lovely person — warm and present and the kind of neighbor who makes everything more manageable simply by being there.

We were new parents. Sarah was only a few months old. One day she became severely constipated and Jakyung and I had no idea what to do. We were first-time parents with a baby in distress and no practical knowledge of how to solve the problem.

We went to Debi.

She had nurse's training. She told us to bring Sarah over. She spread layers of newspaper across her bed — multiple layers — and laid Sarah down on top of them. She took off the

diaper, took a small bar of soap, and used it to gently work around the opening.

What followed was immediate, dramatic, and extremely well-prepared for, given the newspaper situation.

Sarah was fine. The bed was fine. Debi was completely unfazed. Two new parents stood there learning something they would not forget.

That is what good neighbors do. They spread newspapers on the bed and solve the problem and do not make you feel foolish for not knowing. Debi Meeds has been and is still a dear friend.

The Meeds family gave us one more gift before that season was over.

The missionary family whose house we had been watching was coming home from furlough. We needed to move out. The country house was not yet finished — all our money had gone into building it, and it was close but not done. We had nowhere to go.

Calvin and Debi had a converted single-car garage on their property — remodeled into a separate building used as an office, with a small bathroom inside. They said it would be far too small for the three of us — Jakyung, Sarah, and me. But if we wanted to use it while we waited for the house to finish, we were welcome to it.

We took it.

For almost six months in 1991 that converted garage was our home. It was small. It was also enjoyable in a way that surprised us — because our neighbors were right there, close enough to walk to, and whenever we needed to do laundry or needed help of any kind, Calvin and Debi were willing. We were almost finished with the house. The finish line was visible. And we had good people beside us while we waited for it.

From a three-story missionary mansion to a single-car garage. With a baby. That is the shape of a missionary life — not a straight line upward, but whatever space is available, gratefully received.

One more memory from the three-story missionary house — one that belongs to the era as much as to the address.

In the 1980s and 1990s, theft was a significant problem in Korea. Thieves would break into homes and take televisions, money, gold, silver. Sometimes they came while you were sleeping — silent, careful, gone before you woke. The operating theory seemed to be taken what you can carry and sell, do not confront the family, do not make noise. Violence was not the goal. Invisibility was.

One night while we were sleeping in that three-story house, someone climbed up to the second floor — three stories signal wealth, and wealth signals something worth taking — came through the bathroom window, found my wallet, took the cash, and left without awaking any of us up from our sleep. Several hundred dollars gone. But when we searched the perimeter the next morning, the wallet was on the ground near the wall where he had climbed over — the money removed, the ID and driver's license still inside. He had taken what he could spend and left the rest.

There was one more member of our household during those years who deserves mention.

When Jakyung was pregnant with Sarah, we got a dog. A cocker spaniel. We named him Poncho. He lived in the house with us through the pregnancy — a warm, present, cheerful addition to a household that was about to become considerably more complicated.

When Sarah was born, Jakyung made her position clear. The dog was not going to be in the same house as the baby. She was not going to argue about it. Poncho was going to the roof.

You cannot argue with your spouse on these matters. Nor should you try.

We built a doghouse and set it up on the flat-top roof — walls around it to keep him safe, a long leash to keep him from reaching any open doors. Poncho adapted. He seemed content enough on his rooftop. We went up to see him. Life continued.

When we moved to the missionary compound with Calvin and Debi, Poncho came with us. The compound had a yard — better than a roof, we thought. Room to move, fresh air, green space.

The iron gate at the entrance of the compound opened and closed to let cars in and out. Between the bottom bar of the gate and the ground there was a gap. Not large. Just enough.

Poncho found it.

We never saw him again.

That is the small grief that a family carries quietly — the dog who adapted to the rooftop but not to the yard, who found the gap and went through it and did not come back. Sarah was too young to understand. Jakyung and I understood. Poncho had been part of the household through a pregnancy and a birth and a move, and then he was gone through a space in an iron gate on an ordinary day.

Korea today is almost unrecognizable from that version of itself. You can leave your smartphone on a coffee shop table while you use the restroom and return to find it exactly where you left it. Something forgotten in a taxi is frequently returned. Items left on a bus or subway turn up in lost and found. The country that once required someone to remain on the property

during daylight hours to deter thieves has become one of the safest places in Asia to leave your belongings unattended.

Some of that is CCTV — cameras everywhere, and the near certainty of being identified if you steal. Some of it is prosperity — when everyone has a television, there is no market for a stolen one. Some of it is a cultural shift that happened gradually and is now simply the way things are.

I arrived in a Korea where a thief climbed through a bathroom window in the night and took my cash. I am writing in a Korea where the cash would probably be handed to the nearest police officer. Forty years. One country. Almost unrecognizable.

It was also during this period that I made a contract on a small piece of land outside Seoul in the country — one sixth of an acre, with a fifty-year-old farmhouse on it that was not livable but could be torn down. The goal was to own land. The house would come later.

Jakyung was pregnant with Sarah when I signed the contract. The day after — or perhaps the same day, I cannot be certain anymore — she went into labor. I drove her to the hospital. Sarah was born. We had a piece of land and a first daughter on the same day, or nearly the same day.

Let me tell you what that house and land looked like.

The property was triangular — an unusual shape, but we were the last house in the upper village, and the triangle became our yard. Below us was a lower village of perhaps thirty homes, governed by something like a homeowner's association with strict rules about building in the traditional Korean architectural style — wood construction, tiled roofs. But we were higher up, just past that zone, and had the freedom to build what we wanted. We built in concrete with a flat roof — designed from the beginning so that if we ever had the money, we could add a

second floor. Steel bars ran through the concrete roof, and we knew exactly where to break through to put in a stairway. We never built the second floor. We never had enough time or money. But the possibility was there.

On one side of the property was mountain. On the other was a rice field, with a stream running beside it past our property. We put a gate at the entrance — not a fence, just a gate to stop cars from driving into the yard. The house sat in the largest corner of the triangle. The rest became our life.

We put down concrete blocks for a driveway and a patio. We tried a small garden — and this is where the Oklahoma boy in me came fully alive. I got hold of okra seeds. We planted okra and corn and vegetables. We got a few chickens and they started laying eggs. We had a large yard dog who lived outside. Standing there in the dirt with okra growing beside me and a stream nearby and mountains behind the property — something from childhood came back that I had not known I was missing.

Sarah was old enough to walk in the dirt and play in the yard. Through Army friends I got an American swing set from the PX — a slide, swings, the whole arrangement — and watching our daughters out there in the yard with the mountain behind them and the stream nearby was something I will not forget. The yard dog was enormous and would regularly knock Sarah off her feet when he came running to greet her. She got back up every time. She was tougher than she looked.

One day we noticed Sarah had food on her face — and on her clothes — that had not come from our kitchen. We followed her to the neighbors' house. They had been feeding her. What they were eating that day was dog soup — not unusual in the Korean countryside, especially in summer, where

the tradition held that the protein in dog meat-built stamina and health. We did not make a scene. But we noted it.

For me, that life felt like something close to home. For Jakyung it was something else entirely.

She had grown up in Seoul. She knew city streets, public transportation, the rhythms of urban life. Out here in the country the neighbors were not warm to newcomers — and Jakyung, with her sensitivity to unspoken signals, felt it clearly. How they spoke to her. How they looked at her. What they thought when Sarah cried or wandered into someone else's space. She felt unwelcome in a way I did not feel — partly because I was a foreigner and they were too courteous to show me their coldness directly, and partly because I lacked the intuition she had developed over a lifetime of reading Korean rooms.

She was not accepted. She was not welcome. She knew it. And that knowledge sat with her through the time we lived there and followed her to Dallas and came back with her when we returned. When we left for seminary in 1993, she did not want to go back to that house — not even if we had the money to repay the key money. The village had told her, in the way that Korean villages tell people things, that she did not belong there. She had heard it.

Her friend and her friend's husband — the couple who had helped us build the house — were glad to stay on as tenants. They were more than welcome. They lived there through the Dallas years and through the Hanyang campus years, until the IMF crisis came and we sold.

In 1993 we left for Dallas and seminary. To fund the move we arranged key money on the house — Korean key money, roughly two thirds of the property's value, paid by a tenant who would live there while we were gone. That money carried us

through three years of seminary. When we returned, we needed to pay it back.

We returned to Hanyang campus housing. The country house sat empty in terms of our use — too far from Seoul for the girls to attend school, too distant from the life we were living. And then in 1997 the IMF crisis arrived. Korea as a nation faced potential bankruptcy and required emergency loans from the International Monetary Fund. Property values fell. The economy contracted sharply. It became clear we needed to sell.

We sold the house and land for approximately what we had put into it. No great profit. No loss. The money was set aside — for a house in Seoul someday, we thought.

We never bought that house in Seoul.

But Sarah and Anna went to university in the United States. Financial aid helped. The money from the country house helped more.

Steve Jones hit golf balls at a driving range in Seoul two weeks before the 1988 Olympics and shared his testimony and sent a check with one more zero than I expected. That money became a house. The house became seminary tuition. The tuition became a return to Korea. And the land, sold during a national financial crisis, became university education for two daughters who carry both worlds in their blood.

God held that money for fifteen years and sent it exactly where it needed to go.

* * *

The ladder was waiting.

* * *

Chapter Seven

The Gap

There is a moment I cannot tell you about.

Not because I am unwilling. Because I was not there for it. One moment I was on a ladder in a church gymnasium the night after Thanksgiving, stretching to staple black construction paper to a wall, hurrying the way I was always hurrying, my mind already on tomorrow and the drama and the students and everything that still needed to be done — and then there is nothing. A gap. A silence in the record of my life that has no contents because I was not conscious to fill it.

I do not know how I fell. I do not know what I hit on the way down or what position I landed in or who found me or what their face looked like when they did. Nobody saw it happen. The students were nearby, helping, handing up paper — and then at some point I was on the floor, and they were around me and none of us can fully account for the transition between those two states.

The next thing I remember is a hospital room. My wife's face. My daughters.

That gap — between the ladder and the hospital room — is not empty. I know that now. I know that God was present in it, that the everlasting arms were underneath even when I was

not conscious to feel them. But I cannot tell you what it was like because I was not there to experience it. I can only tell you what was on either side of it.

* * *

The days before the fall had been full in the way that ministry days are full — not one thing but many things, none of them quite finished, all of them pulling in different directions.

We had driven to Bethany, Oklahoma for Thanksgiving — my family returning to the extended family I had grown up with, my wife and daughters meeting the people who had shaped the boy I had been before Korea made me someone else. It was good. It was warm. It was the warmth of a table full of people who know your history and hold it without judgment.

On Friday I drove back. I dropped Jakyung and the girls at our apartment. And then I went directly to the church, because the drama was the next night and the gymnasium stage was not ready and I was the one responsible for making it ready.

The concept was ambitious. The stage was to look like a large television screen — a frame of black construction paper around the performance area, with a husband and wife seated in front as if watching television in their own living room, the drama itself playing out as the channels changed with a remote control. It was the kind of idea that sounds straightforward and reveals its complications only when you are standing in the gymnasium in the early evening with a single ladder and a stack of construction paper and a group of students who are tired and willing and looking to you to tell them what to do next.

I was the tallest. It was my ladder. I went up.

The students handed paper up to me. I stretched and stapled. My mind was on the work and on tomorrow and on everything that still needed attention. It was early evening — six o'clock, perhaps, though I cannot be certain. I was not thinking about

the height or the balance or the fatigue of a man who had driven from Oklahoma and back and was now at the top of a ladder after a full day of travel.

And then there is nothing.

* * *

While I was in surgery, a group of Korean parents and adult members of our church came to the hospital. They gathered in the waiting room and prayed. A dozen or so Korean and Asian faces, waiting together, holding the situation before God in the language they knew best.

The nurse came out of the recovery room to find the closest of kin. She walked into the waiting area and looked around. She was looking for someone connected to her Caucasian patient — and all she saw were Korean and Asian faces. It did not occur to her that they were exactly the right people. She asked anyway, out of procedure, whether the closest of kin for Bill Majors was present.

My wife stood up.

The nurse must have been surprised. She followed Jakyung back into the recovery room. And there, at the bedside, husband and wife began to speak to each other — in Korean. Which is when the nurses finally understood why nothing had made sense.

I had woken up from surgery before Jakyung arrived. Two or three people were around the bed asking simple orientation questions — What day is today? What time is it? What is your name? They were trying to assess my condition, to see how much of me had come back. They asked in English.

I answered in Korean.

They had nothing to write on their paperwork. They did not understand a word. It did not occur to them that their Caucasian patient might be fluent in an Asian language — why

would it? They simply noted that the answers were not comprehensible and waited for more information.

The information arrived when Jakyung walked in and the two of us began talking to each other in the language we had shared for years — the language of our marriage, our ministry, our daughters, our daily life. Korean. Not English. Not the language of my Oklahoma childhood. The language I had learned on the streets of Gwangju and at the dinner tables of Korean families and through eleven years of living inside a culture that had eventually become more mine than the one I was born into.

My brain, in its most unguarded moment — fresh from surgery, before conscious control had returned, before I had the capacity to choose — went to Korea. That is where I lived. That is where the deepest part of me had taken up residence.

Jakyung told me about it many days later, when my short-term memory had returned enough to receive new information. I had no memory of those early hours. There were visits from Jakyung in those first days that I do not remember at all — she came, she sat with me, she spoke to me, and I was conscious, but the memory did not record. The brain was still deciding what to keep.

What I do remember is the visit when she brought the girls.

Sarah was four years old. Anna was two. I knew them completely and immediately — there was no confusion about who they were. What I could not do was say their names.

The words were there. I could feel them the way you feel a word on the tip of your tongue when it will not come. I reached for my wife's name and what came out was not her name. I called her my girlfriend. She understood. She did not correct me. She sat beside the bed and held whatever she was feeling inside herself and let me call her whatever I could manage.

I looked at Sarah's face, and I knew her completely and I could not say Sarah. What came out instead was my princess. The proper noun was locked behind the wall and the tender thing — the feeling of her, the specific love I had for that four-year-old girl — that came through when the name could not.

And then there was Anna.

I had half my head shaved. There were metal staples in my skull where they had worked. I was in a hospital gown, and my hands and feet were tied to the bed rails — standard procedure for a patient in my condition, a precaution against the involuntary movements of a brain working to reorient itself. Nobody had shown me a mirror. Nobody had explained to me what I looked like or fully where I was or why. I had no capacity to evaluate my own condition. I only knew what I felt — the joy of seeing my wife and daughters, and then the grief of what happened next. In that room, I was as unable to comprehend my situation as my two-year-old daughter was unable to comprehend hers. We were both that undeveloped. We were both responding only with what we could feel.

Sarah looked at her father — the shaved head, the staples, the gown, the restraints — and she came toward the bed. She tried to climb up beside me. Something in her needed to be close regardless of what she saw, the instinct of a child who loves her father more than she fears what has happened to him. Four years old and she wanted to sit beside me on that bed.

My hands were tied. I could not reach for her.

Anna was two years old. Two-year-olds do not have the framework to process what they see — they only feel it. And what Anna felt when Jakyung tried to bring her close to the man in the bed was wrong. Everything about it was wrong. The shaved head was wrong. The staples were wrong. The restraints were wrong. This person did not look or feel like her father.

She cried like she was dying.

That sound — a two-year-old crying with everything she had because she could not find her father in the person lying in that bed — that was the most devastating thing I experienced in that hospital. Not the surgery. Not the restraints. Not the shaved head or the staples or the beeper that would go off near the stairs. The cry of my youngest daughter who could not recognize me.

My hands were tied to the bed rails. I could not reach for her.

She is thirty-four years old now. Sarah is thirty-six. They have both carried that day in different ways, from different angles, with different wounds that I cannot fully see from where I stand. What I know is that it happened, and it mattered, and the man in that bed would have given anything to untie his hands and reach for both.

Sarah has grown up with a father who loves her without question and who sometimes, in an unguarded moment, reaches for her name and comes back with Cheryl — his sister's name, the name that lives just ahead of Sarah in some rewired corridor of his brain. He catches it. He corrects it. Cheryl — Sarah. But it is too late. The wrong name has already landed, and she has already felt it and she must choose, in that fraction of a second, not to be hurt by something she knows is not intentional.

She makes that choice. She has been making it for thirty-two years. I am aware of what it costs her, and I cannot fix it and I carry that.

* * *

They operated on my brain.

Blood had collected there from the fall, pressure building against tissue that had no room to expand. The surgeons did

what surgeons do in such cases — relieving the pressure, managing the swelling, working with instruments I have no knowledge of on the part of me that holds everything I am. I was not present for any of it. I was somewhere else, or nowhere at all, while they worked.

The students gathered that night at the church. The drama was the next evening. They had a decision to make.

One student asked a question.

What would Pastor Bill want us to do?

There was no more discussion after that. They went back to work. They had preparation in front of them and a performance the next night and a pastor who had told them, through years of showing up and finishing things, exactly what he would want them to do in his absence. They finished what we had started together. By the time they performed the drama the next evening — the gymnasium stage looking like a television, the husband and wife in their living room, the channels changing — they already knew the surgery had been successful. They knew their pastor was alive and recovering. They also knew it would be a long road back. They performed anyway, honoring the work we had done together, completing what had been started.

I was not there to see it. I will never know exactly how it went. I gave everything to prepare it and I missed it completely. But those students answered my absence with their presence, and they completed the work, and I have thought about that many times in the years since. About what it means to invest in people deeply enough that they can answer for you when you cannot answer for yourself.

That is not a small thing. That is the whole point of ministry.

* * *

The first week I was strapped to the bed — hands and feet — while I was unconscious and the medical staff managed what needed to be managed. When I became aware of my surroundings, I was already in the hospital room, already looking at faces I knew and could not name. A beeper was attached to me that went off whenever I approached the stairs or the elevator. When I was taken to shower, I was escorted by a male nurse. Every movement was supervised. Every edge was watched.

I hated it.

I am a man who has ridden motorcycles across Oklahoma, who drove a Volkswagen Beetle alone across hundreds of miles to start college with seventy-five dollars in his pocket, who drove a fellow student's sports car across a desert to California to catch a plane to Korea. I am a man who has navigated foreign countries by instinct and learned foreign languages on the street and figured things out as he went. I do not like being watched near stairs. I do not like being escorted to the shower. I do not like the beeper, and I did not like what it implied about what had happened to me.

After two weeks the doctors allowed me to go home on the condition that Jakyung agreed to always have two adults in the house with me. She agreed. We went home.

For six months I was driven to four hours of rehabilitation every weekday. Someone else drove. That was hard — not the exercises themselves, not the work of rebuilding what the fall had damaged, but the passenger seat. I hated being unable to do the exercises. I felt helpless. I complained about the worksheets being xerox copies with faded ink that was hard to read. I wanted someone else to be responsible. I was a victim, and I behaved like one.

I want to be honest about that period because honesty is the whole point of this book. For the first year or so after the accident, nearly every conversation I had eventually circled back to the accident. It did not matter how the conversation started — it ended with me and my ladder and my injury and my suffering. I was in a spiral that had only one subject. I was not loving the people around me. I was wanting their pity.

My pastoral replacement during recovery was a man named Rev. James Kim. He loved me. He was my friend. And because he loved me and was my friend, he did something that required more courage than most people muster — he looked me in the face, directly, and said what needed to be said.

Bill, stop being the victim. You must go on in life.

I heard him. Not immediately — there was a moment of resistance, the instinct to defend the spiral I had built around myself. But the words landed because they came from love and not from frustration, from a friend and not an adversary. And somewhere underneath the self-pity, the real Bill Majors heard the truth and recognized it.

He was right. I was not loving anybody. I was just wanting pity.

That is not easy to write. But it is true, and this book has no room for the version of me that only shows the noble parts.

* * *

I want to say something about Jakyung during those months, because she deserves more than a passing mention.

She was the one who agreed to the conditions. She was the one who arranged the two adults. She was the one who drove and waited and drove again. She was the one who sat beside the hospital bed in the first days when her husband called her his girlfriend because her name would not come, and who did not flinch, and who stayed.

She had married a man she had not expected to marry — the friendship that became something else on the day he proposed. She had followed him into a life of ministry in a country that was not her own comfort zone either, a Korean woman married to an American missionary, navigating the same Confucian social structures from the inside that he was navigating from the outside. She had built something with him. She had given him daughters.

And then he fell off a ladder, and she drove him to rehabilitation every day for six months, until he was cleared to drive himself again.

I asked her to carry a great deal. She carried it without complaint and without drama, the way she carried everything — quietly, steadily, with a faith that did not require an audience. The same faith that had caught my attention at a farewell lunch in Suwon, the faith that a girl had found on her own in an elementary school church and carried alone inside her own family home — that faith held her up through all of it.  [view photo](#)

She stayed. Through all of it — the unconscious days, the surgery, the six months of driving me to rehabilitation, the doubt spiral, the victim spiral, the slow return to something resembling the man she had married. She did not leave. I have said elsewhere in this book that she is still here. In this chapter, that fact has a weight that the earlier mention could not carry.

* * *

I came back.

Not all the way back — not in every sense. The brain does not fully return from what mine went through. The names still slip sometimes. Sarah becomes Cheryl before it becomes Sarah. There are other small losses that are permanent, small rewiring that I have learned to live with because there is no alternative.

But I came back. I came back to the pulpit. I came back to ministry. I came back to loving people instead of wanting their pity. I came back to the students who had performed the drama without me and who welcomed me back without making a production of it.

The gap between the ladder and the hospital room is still there. I cannot fill it. What I know is what happened inside it — told to me afterward by the people who were present.

A college student named Phil Kim was there that night. He had come home from college to celebrate Thanksgiving with his family and with the high school students at the church. He was helping some of the students run through their parts in the drama. And when it happened — when I fell — Phil Kim was the one who saw it. He saw the ladder on the floor. He saw me. He saw the blood. And he did not hesitate. He went immediately and called 911.

The fire station was across the street from the church. But the fire department's ambulance could not take me to the nearest hospital. I needed a neurologist, and not every hospital had one available on a Thanksgiving weekend. The ambulance drove thirty minutes to find the right place.

That place was Parkland Hospital in Dallas on November 25, 1994.

The same Parkland Hospital that received President John F. Kennedy on November 22, 1963, after his assassination. A hospital that has seen the worst that can happen to a human body and has kept doing its work anyway — holiday weekend after holiday weekend, President and pastor alike.

Phil Kim saved my life that night. I want to say that plainly, without drama, because it is simply true. A college student home for Thanksgiving, with the presence of mind to see what

needed to be done and do it immediately — that is what kept me alive long enough to reach a neurologist.

In the years that followed, Phil Kim and I kept crossing paths. He came to Korea and lived in Seoul for a few months before going back to the US for dental school. He went to dental school, joined the army as a dentist, and was assigned to the 8th Army Hospital at Yongsan in Seoul — and during that time he attended the international worship service where I was pastoring. I watched him fall in love. I got to know the woman he was seeing. He came back to Seoul to marry her, and I had the privilege of officiating that wedding. Thirty-five years of crossing paths, each one deeper than the last.

In 2019, when I started CrossCulture Community Foundation in Texas, Phil Kim became one of my board members. The college student who called 911 the night I fell is now one of the men who helps lead what I have spent my life building.

God assembles people around us long before we understand what they are being assembled for.

Underneath it all — underneath the fall and the surgery and the beeper and the six months of rehabilitation and the names that still slip and the year of self-pity that a friend loved me enough to interrupt — underneath all of it, the same arms that had been underneath everything else.

The eternal God is your refuge.

And underneath are the everlasting arms.

* * *

Chapter Eight continues...

* * *

Chapter Eight

New Wiring

The insurance company decided I was normal.

Not restored. Not returned to who I had been before the fall. Normal — meaning that on the scale they used to measure such things, I was no longer at the bottom. Some people were above me and some were below me and that position in the middle was sufficient, legally, to stop paying for rehabilitation.

My heart broke at that decision. Not because I was ungrateful for what the rehabilitation had done — it had done real work, rebuilt real things, given me back capacities I had lost. But the goal I had assumed we were working toward — returning me to the person I had been before I went up that ladder — was not the goal the insurance company had ever agreed to pursue. Their goal was normal. They had reached it. We were finished.

The doctor offered what comfort he could. The brain, he explained, does not stop healing when the formal rehabilitation ends. It continues without help— building new pathways, finding alternative routes around the damaged ones, rewiring itself through the ordinary work of daily life. Time was still doing something. I would continue to improve, just without the structured help.

I held onto that. It was what I had.

* * *

What I did not expect was to discover that the accident had given me something.

Before the fall, I was an analytical man. Logical. Strategic. I lived in my head — in plans and assessments and the careful management of information. I was not a man who paid much attention to his own emotions or anyone else's. Feelings were not the primary currency of my interior life.

The accident changed that completely.

The analytical, logical part of my brain — the left brain, the part that processes language and sequential reasoning and careful thought — took the damage. And what was left, in the aftermath, was the part of my brain I had spent my whole life underusing. The emotional, intuitive, feeling side. The right brain, which had been sitting largely dormant while the left brain ran the operation.

Suddenly the left brain was offline, and the right brain was all I had.

I cried at everything. Not occasionally — constantly. Advertisements made me cry. Songs made me cry. Watching children play made me cry. Emotions moved through me like weather moves through a place with no walls — arriving without warning, leaving without permission, beyond my ability to manage or predict. I had never been a man who cried easily. Now I was a man who could not stop.

It was disorienting. It was embarrassing. It was also, I came to understand slowly, a kind of gift.

I had spent decades as a missionary — loving people, serving people, building communities of faith — and doing most of it from my head. The emotional life of the people I was serving had always been somewhat at arm's length from my

own interior experience. I understood their feelings. I did not always feel them with them.

The accident took away the arm's length. It left me in a room with nothing but feeling, and I had to learn to live there. That learning took time. But when it was done — when the emotional and the analytical began to work together in a way they had never worked before — I was a different kind of minister than I had been. More present. More human. More capable of sitting with someone in their pain without reaching too quickly for the solution.

I would not have chosen the ladder accident. But I would not give back what it made possible.

* * *

The second gift was harder to name and took longer to receive.

I had known about the Holy Spirit my whole life. I had a theological understanding of His presence and His work. What I did not have was the experiential knowledge of Him. The daily, practical, moment-by-moment awareness of a presence inside me that was not my own strength.

Before the accident, I had been strong enough not to notice my need.

After the accident, my abilities were too weak to carry me. The analytical mind that had managed everything was damaged. The emotional side was raw and uncontrolled. I had no reserve of personal competence to draw from. And ministry was still happening — people still needed to be loved and led and served — and I was the person responsible for doing it.

I could not do it on my own. That was simply and completely true. And into that incapacity, the Holy Spirit became real to me in a way He had never been before. Not dramatic. Not sudden. A process — the same kind of gradual

development the doctor had described for the brain itself. New connections being built. New pathways being discovered. Learning to recognize a presence I had always had but never learned to lean on because I had always been strong enough to manage without leaning.

My mother had carried that presence her whole life without knowing its name. I had known its name my whole life without knowing how to carry it. The accident was the doorway through which I finally learned what she had always practiced.

* * *

In the hospital bed during those two weeks before I was discharged, something else happened.

God called me to be a pastor.

Not a missionary in the sense I had always understood the word — the traveling, the language learning, the crossing of cultures. A pastor. A shepherd of a congregation. Someone who stays with specific people over time and walks with them through ordinary life and extraordinary loss.

It was a new thing. A different thing. And I did not immediately know what to do with it.

My first thought was that it meant staying with the high school students at Korean Presbyterian Church of Dallas — the KPCD congregation I had been serving when I fell. But that did not hold together when I examined it. James Kim had been hired as my replacement. A congregation does not need two pastors. And those high school students were about to scatter — to colleges, to careers, to marriages in other cities. The congregation I was imagining was already in the process of dissolving.

So, I looked elsewhere. I traveled and spoke at churches in America as a pastoral candidate. I presented myself and was presented to congregations who were looking for a pastor, and

I listened to see whether the mutual yes would come. It did not. Either the church said no, or I said no, or the conversation simply reached its natural end without resolution. No church in America and I ever arrived at the place where both parties felt certain this was the right fit.

But something was forming underneath those failed candidacies. I had been the English pastor at a Korean immigrant church in Dallas — KPCD. I understood what it meant to serve a congregation caught between two languages, two cultures, two generations. And a different idea was beginning to take shape. What if the answer was not a church in America at all? What if the answer was returning to Korea — not to a Korean church that added English as an afterthought, but to build something where two languages could worship together as equals? A church where a foreigner could choose simultaneous translation in a large Korean service with a great choir and a full congregation, or step into a smaller English worship — two hundred seats, tight and personal — where the language was entirely their own. Two doors into the same house.

That idea felt right. It felt like the calling the hospital bed had given me, finally finding its address.

It did not feel right to Jakyung.

She had been through the ladder accident. She had packed two small daughters — three years old and one — and moved to a country that was not her own. She had arrived knowing no one, built a life from nothing, found a church, made friends, learned the roads and the streets, watched her daughters settle into school. Dallas had become home. The girls were in kindergarten and preschool. Life was moving forward. Why go back?

I could not entirely answer that question to her satisfaction. I believed it was where God was leading. She could not stop me and could not change my mind. I could not change hers. We both recognized, with some wry acknowledgment, that we were looking at the same stubbornness in each other — the same quality that had made her wash clothes by hand and made me ride in the wrong motorcycle lane for thirty years.

What helped was Dr. Billy Kim.

We sat with him and Jakyung told her side of the story honestly — her hesitation, her fear, her exhaustion at starting over again. He listened. He spoke. And something in the way he framed the vision — the English ministry, the international congregation, the two doors into the same house — reached her in a way my arguments had not. She did not come away excited. But she came away willing.

We went back to Korea.

* * *

The first six months were hard.

The campus housing at Hanyang was on the fourth floor of a building with no elevator. Jakyung carried groceries up four flights of stairs because there was no marketplace on campus — only a student snack shop and a cafeteria that was not for us. She missed her car. She missed Dallas roads she knew by memory. She missed her church. She missed the life she had built and then been asked to leave for the second time.

The apartment was small. The girls had no bedroom. I bought bunkbeds — the bottom bunk folded into a couch so the living room could breathe during the day, the top bunk always there above your head as a reminder of what the room was really doing at night. It was not the kind of home you invited people to easily. It was not the kind of home Jakyung had imagined for her daughters.

She said so. Not once — throughout those six years, from time to time, she said so. She dealt with her own depression quietly, the way she dealt with most hard things, without making a production of it. She adapted. She always adapted. But the cost of the adapting was real, and it did not disappear simply because I had a logical response ready.

My logical response was this — we were paying nothing in subsidized housing. If we moved off campus, rent would cost at least a thousand dollars a month. Eight hundred dollars a month saved over six years was money toward a home of our own someday. The math was sound. I believed in the math.

She was climbing four flights of stairs with groceries. The math did not carry the groceries.

We stayed six years. And there were genuine graces in it — the campus as a front yard where the girls rode their bikes in the parking lot on weekends when the students were gone and the spaces were empty and safe. Birthday parties where friends came and the campus became a kind of playground that ordinary neighborhoods could not offer. The girls had very little problem with any of it. Children adapt faster than adults and complain less about what they have never known to miss.

The six years were not unbroken. After three and a half years the university announced plans to remodel the dormitory. The teachers housing on the fourth floor would close. Most teachers were moved to one-bedroom suites in another dormitory on campus — adequate for a single person, impossible for a family of four. Nobody discussed with us directly what would happen to us. That is the Korean way. Things are arranged through channels, through middle management, through the quiet work of people who are watching without announcing that they are watching.

We were surprised to discover that a courtesy apartment had been arranged for us — a real apartment, off campus, in a regular neighborhood apartment complex. It came not from the founding president and chairman of Hanyang University, Dr. Kim Lyun-joon, through any direct conversation with us, but through someone in middle management who had simply made it happen. Six months. A nice apartment we could never have afforded ourselves. Far above anything the university was required to provide.

We did not have much furniture — just what we had moved from the teachers housing, enough to fill the rooms without filling them. But there was floor space. Real floor space, the kind children run across and families spread out on. Jakyung had shopping nearby. She had a place she could invite people to without apology. She had, for six months, the life she had been describing for three and a half years.

Then the remodel finished and we moved back to campus. The new housing was nicer — first floor, its own entrance, more separation from student life. But it was slightly smaller. And it was still campus. The six months off had given Jakyung a clear picture of what she wanted and then asked her to set it down again.

But she did not say — and I believe in this — that she was right about everything else.

* * *

Meanwhile the girls were finding their way between two worlds — which was exactly what their father had intended, and their mother had worried about.

When we returned to Korea, Sarah was five and Anna was three. Sarah had completed one semester of kindergarten in a Dallas public school. In Korea the school year begins in March, so we enrolled her in a Korean kindergarten for one semester,

and then she started first grade at Hanyang Elementary — the school whose lottery had nearly stopped my heart. Anna went into a Korean preschool, then a year of international school for kindergarten, then one semester of first grade at the international school — until her number was drawn from the jar and we pulled her out and put her in Hanyang Elementary alongside her sister.

This was not accidental. I wanted our daughters double-dipped in languages and cultures. Korean immersion alongside English — two complete worlds, not one world with the other as a guest. I also wanted to avoid the expensive tuition of a full international school education on the salary I was earning. Whether that decision was driven more by conviction or frugality, I cannot say with complete honesty. Probably both. Possibly a lot of both.

Only God knows the exact ratio. And He has not told me.

* * *

The doctor had told me to exercise. Not all exercise — the skull that had been opened and put back together was still tender, and certain sports carried risks I could not afford. Swimming was approved. Bowling was approved. Some things were not.

In Dallas I had bowled occasionally — a substitute in the US Army bowling league in Seoul years earlier, a 150 average, nothing serious. A young man from the Korean American church at KPCD had his own equipment and his own car and enjoyed bowling, and the two of us started going once a week. Sometimes others came. It was exercise and it was relationship and it served its purpose.

When we returned to Korea, bowling disappeared. There was nothing close to campus. But there were tennis courts.

The university had courts reserved for professors — clay courts, well maintained, with a fraternity of regulars who had been playing together for years. I had hit tennis balls over nets at city parks growing up in Oklahoma. I knew how to keep score. That was approximately the full extent of my preparation when I showed up with equipment and tennis shoes and asked to play.

They let me play one game. They needed no further evaluation.

They told me there was one hope. I needed to take lessons. Six months minimum. Down at the Hanyang junior high girls' school there were two courts — one available for instruction. They gave me the details and sent me away.

I took the lessons. Six months. I came back.

I was still not good enough — but considerably better than I had been. The tennis club had its hierarchy, as Korean clubs do. Those who played best and had been members longest held the authority. Those who were new — especially those whose game was poor — needed to be subservient, patient, humble, willing to wait. My job was to draw the lines on the clay court. Every thirty or forty-five minutes, someone needed to walk the court with the line marker and restore the boundaries. That someone was me.

I drew lines. I waited. Two hours, sometimes three, to play the last game when the good players had gone home and whoever remained needed a fourth. The game I got was still good enough to come back for.

There was one professor who was critical of me from the beginning. He was negative, pointed, and had most people on his side — because my game was genuinely bad and his judgment was not entirely wrong. I did not know why he had taken against me so specifically. I kept showing up anyway. I

drew lines. I improved. I sometimes brought food. The majority shifted gradually from his side toward mine, until even his supporters would not stand with him when he was absent.

Eventually he became my friend.

There is a Korean proverb — if you are persistent, even your enemy will become your friend. That is what happened in the Hanyang professors' tennis club, over two or three or four years, one clay court at a time.

My game kept improving. The passion was driving me now, not logic — I could feel that clearly. Tennis was five minutes from my apartment. I could play between classes during a two-hour break, and again in the evenings after work. The friendships I built in that club were with older professors who had long tenure at the university — men who understood Korean academic culture in ways that took years to learn, who accepted me into their circle not because of anything I said or taught but because I had shown up consistently and drawn lines and waited and improved. That was worth more than I understood at the time.

In 2001 I entered the national professor's tennis tournament — held that year in Busan, hosted by Busan National University. I went not as part of the team tournament but paired with one strong player in my age group who took me as his partner. We started at nine in the morning. Single elimination. Nine matches across the day, driving an hour between venues as we advanced through the rounds.

We made it to the finals.

For the semifinal we played at the main courts. For the finals we waited while other age groups finished, and then we faced Ulsan University. They beat us 6-2. We both played as though we had forgotten what we knew — frozen by fatigue or by the

weight of being in the finals or by the small crowd of spectators cheering for the other side.

Afterward we understood what had happened. All day we had been saying to each other — let's make it to the finals, let's make it to the finals. We made it to the finals. We had not been saying let's win the finals. The goal we had spoken produced exactly the result it promised and nothing more.

We learned to say it differently after that.

My name was printed in the tennis magazine published annually for participants in that national tournament. Bill Majors. Hanyang University. 2001. A foreigner's name in the history of the Korean national professor's tennis tournament. It remains there still.

Jakyung had one car between us — I had a motorcycle, so the car was largely available to her unless we went as a family. She was not without transportation. But she was raising two daughters in a small campus apartment while her husband played tennis between classes and in the evenings with considerable passion. She could see the recovery happening. She could see him belonging to something, strengthening, coming alive. She was glad for parts of it.

She also needed him home more than tennis allowed.

Both things were true. Both things stayed true. And years later — that story belongs to Book Two — Jakyung would find her own passion for tennis. Whether it came from watching mine or whether it was always in her waiting to emerge, I cannot say. What I know is that she found it. And when she did, I understood something about those campus years that I had not understood while living them.

Some things we plant without knowing we are planting them.

* * *

One more thing about those campus years that deserves its own telling — the motorcycle.

I had a motorcycle on campus and Jakyung had the car. She was not without transportation. But the motorcycle was mine and it changed everything about how I moved through those years.

Ten minutes before class starts — jump on the motorcycle, park in front of the building, walk up the stairs, walk into the classroom on time. Between classes — down to the tennis courts on the motorcycle, play a match, shower, back on the motorcycle, into the classroom on time. After the last class — off campus on the motorcycle, dinner with someone, meeting, back on campus, home. If Jakyung needed an errand run — motorcycle. If the girls needed to be somewhere — motorcycle.

Sometimes both girls came with me. Sarah behind me, arms around my waist. Anna on the gas tank in front, held between my arms. They loved it. The wind and the speed and the pleasure of being driven somewhere by their father on a machine that was loud and fast and entirely unlike the subway.

On campus it was safe. The roads were quiet, the traffic was university traffic, and I was a good driver. I knew every path.

There was a shortcut from the dormitory to the campus gate — across a hill with loose stones and dirt, up and then down, and then a steel gate with an iron bar along the bottom that held it shut when closed. To use the shortcut, you had to either park the motorcycle on the hill and open the gate yourself or find it already open. Then you had to get the front wheel and the back wheel over that iron bar without dropping the bike, navigate five or six meters of loose gravel, and reach the pavement on the other side. You were off campus in about a hundred meters from the student housing.

I used that shortcut sometimes. Wisdom was not always the motivator. Sometimes it was simply risk and convenience and the confidence of a man who had been riding motorcycles since he was fourteen years old in Oklahoma.

Sometimes I took that shortcut with the girls on board.

I am not saying that was wise. I am saying it happened. And we always made it. And the girls thought it was an adventure.

The motorcycle gave me a freedom on that campus that no one else in the family had in the same way. I could be everywhere and nowhere, between obligations, moving fast, available and unavailable at the same time. It was wonderful. It was also, in ways I did not always acknowledge, one more thing that was mine and not ours.

But the girls loved riding it. And that part I do not regret at all.

* * *

Meanwhile, there was the matter of finishing what had been interrupted.

Dallas Theological Seminary. I had been two weeks from the end of the semester when I fell off the ladder. Two weeks — close enough that most of the work was already done, but not close enough to graduate on schedule.

Word spread across the DTS campus. The professors were informed that their student had undergone brain surgery and would be hospitalized through the end of the semester. And then those professors did something I have not forgotten and will not forget.

They showed grace. Each in their own way, each according to what was reasonable given what remained undone. Some graded me for the semester based on work I had completed before the accident — deciding that what I had already done was sufficient evidence of what I knew. Others delayed my

grade, holding the semester open until I was able to complete specific tasks at whatever pace my recovery allowed.

One professor — Dr. John Hannah, who taught church history — told me that I would be required to complete the assigned reading. But that was all. He would wait however long it took. If it took ten years, he would wait ten years. I signed an agreement and he gave me an early grade based on my promise. Several years later I notified Dr. Hannah that the reading had been completed.

I graduated in December 1995. One semester late. Still graduated.  [view photo](#)

* * *

The doctoral program was the next question and the next disappointment.

I applied to Trinity Evangelical Divinity School in Deerfield, Illinois. I was declined. I visited Fuller Theological Seminary in California. It did not feel like my school — something in my spirit did not settle there. I did not have a clear sense of where I was supposed to go, only a growing sense that wherever it was, the timing was not yet right.

I had to delay the doctoral program. I filed that away and turned my attention to the more immediate question — which was how to get my family back to Korea.

* * *

We did not have the money to return on our own. That was the plain truth. The accident had interrupted everything — income, savings, plans. I needed a position that came with housing, something that would allow us to return without requiring us to have resources we did not have.

That December, Dallas Theological Seminary held a winter revival. The special speaker, invited by the seminary president Dr. Charles Swindoll, was Dr. Billy Kim.

Dr. Billy Kim. Joey's father. The man who had hosted the farewell lunch in Suwon where I had first met the ten girls in the ensemble. The man who had been the Korean translator when Billy Graham preached to hundreds of thousands in Seoul. The man whose name had been the thread connecting me to Korea since I was a college student in Chattanooga.

Jakyung and I asked if we could have supper with him one evening. He agreed. We sat down together and told him everything — the ladder accident, the surgery, the rehabilitation, the months of recovery, the calling to pastoral ministry that had come in the hospital bed, and the practical reality that we needed to be hired in Korea to return.

Dr. Billy Kim listened. Then he asked a question.

If he could arrange an interview in Seoul, could we buy a plane ticket to get there?

I said yes. He said he would be in touch.

* * *

The trip to Korea was arranged. Dr. Billy Kim set up a meeting with Dr. Lyun-joon Kim — the founder of Hanyang University. I had history with this man. In 1983, when I was a young missionary attending graduate classes at Hanyang and barely understanding a word of the lectures, Dr. Lyun-joon Kim had offered me a scholarship in exchange for English conversation lessons several times a week. We had sat together in his Peugeot on Sunday mornings, his driver taking us from Seoul to Suwon for church. I had eaten at his table. He had been generous to me when I had very little to offer in return.

Thirteen years later I sat across from him again.

His office at the university had a table set for three. Steaks, catered from the President Hotel. The kind of meeting that happens when a man of considerable means wants to make a guest feel welcomed and considered. I gave him my resume. He

looked at it. Then he picked up the phone and called his daughter, who was a professor in the College of Education at Hanyang.

He asked her if she had a position for me to come and teach English. She said she would investigate it. He told her to call me if something opened for the March semester in 1996.

I flew back to Dallas. I waited.

Two and a half months passed. The March semester drew closer. I tried not to count the days, but I counted the days. Each one that passed without a call was another day of the window closing. A semester does not wait. If the call did not come in time there would be no position — not until September at the earliest, and even that was not certain.

One week before the semester was to begin, the phone rang.

It was Hanyang University's College of Education. There was a position. Not on the main Seoul campus — at their branch school in Ansan. I could work there one semester and try to transfer to Seoul later. Could I come?

I said yes.

I did not think about the logistics until after I had said yes. There were considerable logistics. One week. No housing for a family. No time to arrange schools for the girls or find an apartment large enough for four people. The position was real, but the situation could not absorb a family's arrival on one week's notice.

I went alone.

* * *

My room for that first semester was a single dormitory room — one teacher, one bed, one desk, four walls. I was assigned twenty-three hours of teaching per week, but many of the classes covered the same material, which meant I did not need to prepare new lessons constantly. The textbooks were shared

across instructors. The midterm and final examinations were prepared collectively by the teaching staff. The load was manageable in a way that a more demanding position would not have been.

God had arranged even that.

Because what my brain needed — what it had needed since November 25, 1994, and had not yet fully received — was rest. Extended, uninterrupted rest. No family responsibilities in the evenings. No pastoral demands outside of teaching hours. Just the work and then the silence and then sleep.

I slept twelve hours a night.

Not ten. Not eleven. Twelve. Every night, for that entire first semester, my brain claimed the hours it needed to keep building the new pathways the doctor had described. I did not choose twelve hours — my body chose it. I simply stopped fighting it and let the healing happen.

The students in my classes were impressed that their foreign instructor spoke Korean. Their own English was limited enough that most of them did not realize their professor had been through brain surgery less than eighteen months earlier and was still in the process of recovery. I stood in front of those classrooms and God helped me through each session. I was not fully recovered. But I was present, and I was functioning, and the semester passed.

* * *

When the semester at Ansan ended I began looking for housing large enough to bring my family — this time on the main Hanyang campus in Seoul, where I hoped to transfer. The university had rules — children were not permitted in the faculty housing units. Most of the available rooms were small, single-occupancy spaces that would have been impossible for a family of four. There were only three apartments on the

property large enough to accommodate a family, and those were occupied.

I waited. I asked. I made it known that I needed something different.

In March 1996 — the start of the new Korean academic year — one of the three larger apartments became available. The university gave us permission — children and all — to move in. The apartment was one bedroom. It was enough. The school — Hanyang Elementary — was less than two hundred yards from our front door.

Jakyung and I disagreed about that school.

I wanted our daughters in the Korean school. Korean language, Korean culture, Korean peers — immersion in the country where we were going to live and serve. Jakyung wanted them in an international school. English instruction, international community, a curriculum that would not disadvantage them if we ever moved again.

We were both firm. We had our reasons and we held them.

Then we learned about the admission process. Hanyang Elementary accepted seventy-two girls and seventy-two boys for four first-grade classes each year. The applicant ratio was four to one. Each applicant was assigned a number. The numbers were drawn from a jar, one by one, in front of the parents. At least one parent had to be in the room when the drawing took place. Seventy-five percent of the children who applied would be turned away.

1996. Sarah's number was in the jar. I was in that room.

I want to tell you what it felt like because the summary does not do it justice. The numbers were called one at a time. Number one. Number two. Number three. Each number a child confirmed, a family's relief visible on their faces. The

room was tense in the way that rooms are tense when something irreversible is happening slowly.

Sarah attending this school was my dream. My desire. The Korean immersion, the proximity to our housing, the education I believed was right for her — I wanted this for her with a specific and focused wanting that I had not often felt about something I could not control.

After number sixty I was sweating. Twelve numbers remained. More than two hundred children would go home without a place in this school. Each number drawn was one fewer remaining. Sixty-one. Still not Sarah.

Number sixty-two.

Sarah Majors.

Relief and overwhelming joy filled my heart simultaneously — the combination that happens when something you wanted badly and feared losing is suddenly and completely yours. I was bursting at the seams. My daughter was going to Hanyang Elementary School less than two hundred yards from our front door.

* * *

Two years later Anna's number was in the jar.

By then Jakyung had drawn her line. She had accepted Sarah's placement because the lottery had decided it. But Anna was different. Jakyung had made her position clear — if Anna's number was not drawn, both girls would transfer to an international school. She would not accept one daughter in a Korean school and one in an international school. It had to be the same for both.

That was not fair. But who was going to be on my side? I needed Anna's number to be drawn. There was no alternative outcome I was willing to accept.

I was in that room again. The numbers were called. One by one. The same slow accumulation, the same tense faces, the same irreversibility of each number announced.

Ten numbers drawn. Twenty. Thirty. Anna's number had not been called.

Forty. Fifty. Sixty. Still not Anna.

Seventy. Seventy-one numbers drawn. One number remained. Every parent in that room whose child's number had not been called was sitting with the full weight of it — the speech they would have to give at home, the school they would have to explain, the child who would ask why.

The principal paused before drawing the last number. He looked out at the room — at the parents sweating like horses in the desert, as I would later describe it — and he said something I have not forgotten.

He said: if your child's number is not drawn today, please do not go home and tell them their number wasn't drawn. That is like telling them they are a loser. Go home excited and tell them the name of the school they will be attending. Because even if it is not this school, your children are not losers.

Then he reached into the jar.

Anna Majors.

I could not stay in my seat. I was on my feet and moving — jogging around the room, trying to keep the YES that was inside me from coming out as a sound that would embarrass everyone present including myself. Seventy-two numbers. Anna was the last one drawn.

The last one.

Jakyung had said if Anna's number is not drawn, both girls go to international school. God had drawn Anna's number last — as if He wanted to make certain everyone in that room understood that nothing about this was inevitable, nothing

about it was guaranteed, and nothing about it was anyone's plan except His.

* * *

I must tell you something about those years that is not comfortable to tell.

I was not easy to live with.

The brain injury had left me emotionally raw in ways I could not always control, and one of the emotions that came through most powerfully and most destructively was doubt. I began to doubt Jakyung. Not because she had given me reason — she had given me none. But the damaged, unregulated emotional brain does not require evidence. It generates feeling without logic, suspicion without cause, a case built from nothing against the person closest to you.

I became a detective with no evidence and no case, investigating a crime that had not been committed. I doubted her love. I doubted her faithfulness. I was angry. The anger came fast and stayed long and found its way into the house, into the rooms where the girls were, into the ordinary moments of family life that should have been ordinary.

Jakyung bore it.

Not silently — she was human, and sometimes she blew up, because she had limits and she had been carrying something very heavy for a long time and she was not made of stone. But most of the time she held herself together, knowing that someone in the house had to.

She stayed.

Into that spiral came a friend named Bob Myers.

I had known Bob since my single days at the orphanage in Uijeongbu — an American, a US Army officer who had moved in and out of Korea over the years as his assignments changed.

Not long after we returned to Seoul, he came back too. We talked from time to time. He was paying attention.

One day he told me what he saw.

He said I was spiraling out of control with my doubt and my detective attitude. He said what I was doing had a destination and the destination was the destruction of my marriage. And then he gave me something simple.

If you don't have evidence, don't allow doubt to exist in you.

That was it. One sentence from a friend who had been watching and who loved me enough to say the plain thing plainly. The doubt had no evidence. I had been constructing it from nothing, feeding it with my damaged emotional brain, letting it grow in the dark where logic could not reach it. Bob turned the light on. The doubt could not survive the light.

Things got better. The natural healing of the brain was continuing — new pathways, new connections, the slow return of the capacity to think as well as feel. Time was doing its work. Bob's sentence was doing its work. The Holy Spirit was doing His work. All of it together, at the same time, in the same life.

That is usually how healing happens. Not one thing. Everything at once.

* * *

Rev. James Kim was my pastoral replacement during the recovery period. He was younger than me, gifted, and he was also my friend — genuinely, not just professionally. He loved me the way friends love each other when they are willing to say the hard thing face to face.

He said it.

Bill, stop being the victim. You have to go on in life.

I had needed to hear that. The spiral of self-pity — turning every conversation back to the accident, wanting pity more than I was giving love — had needed someone to interrupt it from

the outside. James Kim interrupted it. Bob Myers interrupted the next one. Jakyung absorbed both spirals and kept the house running and stayed.

I am aware of what all that cost the people around me. I cannot go back and be a better husband or a better father or a better friend during that time. What I can do is name it honestly and be grateful that the people who loved me were patient enough to wait for me to come back.

I came back.

* * *

The brain that came back was not identical to the brain that had gone up the ladder. Some things were permanently different. The names still slipped. There were new pathways that became permanent features of the landscape rather than temporary detours.

But there were also the gifts. The emotional life that had been forced open by the accident — brought slowly under the management of a renewed mind. More present than before. More capable of feeling the room I was in rather than just analyzing it.

And the Holy Spirit — real now in the daily, practical way that only need can make something real. I had needed Him too badly to keep Him at arm's length. The accident had taken away my ability to manage without Him, and I had learned, in the managing, that He was there. Had always been there. Underneath every chapter of this story.

Underneath all of it. Every time.

* * *

Chapter Eight continues...

* * *

I want to say something before this book closes. Something I have been circling around for every chapter without quite saying directly.

I was never chosen by a mission agency.

Every year at Tennessee Temple University, during mission's week, the agencies would come. Representatives would set up tables in the hallways and interview students — assessing them, weighing them, deciding whether they were the right material to be sent out under their organization's name. I sat across those tables more than once. And every time, the answer came back with conditions I could not meet.

Get married first, then come back. Accumulate two years of ministry experience, then we'll talk. Raise your full support package — health insurance, living expenses, social security contributions, furlough funds, continuing education — raise all of it before you go. Raise it by going from church to church on deputation, presenting yourself to congregations who do not know you, asking them to believe in a calling they cannot verify.

I could not do any of that. I was not married. I had no accumulated experience. I had a newspaper route that ran 352 days a year. It had been good to me — it paid for two cars that were tax deductible, covered my tuition, and got me through three years of college. When I left college, I carried a \$2,500 bank loan — the remaining debt from three years of tuition and living expenses. Raymond had promised all four of Mary's children that when one of them went to college he would sell his portable workshop and use that money for tuition. The workshop did not sell. But when I left for Korea, Raymond and my mother quietly paid off that \$2,500 loan for me. The man I had kept at arm's length. The man I never called Dad. He found a way to keep his promise anyway, in the only way available to

him, without ceremony or expectation of thanks. I did not fully understand what that meant until much later.

There was one invitation — to come for a summer internship. But the newspaper route ran 352 days a year. You could not deliver papers 352 days a year and take a summer off. So even that door required a choice I was not yet positioned to make.

I graduated. I was ordained. I drove a fellow student's car across a desert to California. I bought the one-way ticket. I got on the plane.

No agency sent me. No organization vouched for me. No support structure was in place. I went the way Hudson Taylor went to China — by getting on the boat and believing that God would provide for what God had called.

Not long ago I was watching something on YouTube and came across a philosopher and theologian named Dallas Willard. He said something that stopped me. I wrote it down.

Do the best that you can while using all the resources that you have available but abandon the outcome.

I had not heard those words when I was twenty-one years old boarding a plane to Korea. I had not heard them during the five weeks in Japan or the night of the ladder or the two and a half months of waiting for a phone call that came one week before the semester started. I heard them recently — and when I heard them, something clicked into place. Not because the words taught me something new. Because they named something I had already been living.

I had been abandoning the outcome my whole life. Not because I was wise enough to choose it as a strategy. Because the outcome was never mine to control. It never had been. From the moment a thirteen-year-old boy raised his hand in the dark at Lake Texoma, the outcome belonged to God. The only

question was whether I would pretend otherwise or accept it and go anyway.

I accepted it. I went anyway.

* * *

And this is what followed.

A Korean airport lobby where nobody spoke my language and the man who was supposed to meet me was an hour late. A farmhouse in Gwangju where I learned Korean from the women who would talk to me because the men only wanted to practice their English. A deportation notice. Five weeks in Japan without a passport. An orphanage in Uijeongbu where I slept in the room with the boys because they needed a big brother more than I needed a private room. Twenty-three children I escorted to new families in Minneapolis and New York and Chicago, handing small hands to larger ones and walking away.

A farewell lunch in Suwon where ten Korean girls practiced their textbook English against my street Korean, and I was the comedian and I did not know which face I was looking at. A dentist missionary who asked me why I didn't marry my friend. A proposal that was the first moment either of us knew. A wedding. Two daughters. A one-bedroom apartment with a bunk bed in the living room.

A ladder. A Friday evening in November. Black construction paper and a gymnasium stage that needed to look like a television. A gap in my memory that has never been filled. Metal staples in a shaved head. A two-year-old who cried like she was dying because she could not find her father in the person on the bed. Hands tied to bed rails that could not reach for her.

A friend who said stop being the victim. Another friend who said if you don't have evidence don't allow doubt to exist

in you. A wife who drove and stayed and did not leave. A brain that kept rewiring itself in the dark while I slept twelve hours a night in a single dormitory room in Ansan.

A phone call one week before the semester started. A jar full of numbers. Two daughters' names drawn from that jar.

None of it was my plan. I did not have a plan. I had a direction — Korea — and a willingness — yes — and a God who was already in every room before I arrived, arranging things I had no capacity to arrange, holding threads I did not know existed, connecting 1983 to 1996 through a steak dinner in a hotel office and a man who had once let a young missionary ride in his Peugeot on Sunday mornings.

My analytical mind — even before the ladder accident took part of it away — could never have designed what God arranged. The mission agencies were right that I did not meet their requirements. What they could not have known was that the God who called me did not operate by their requirements. He operates by His own — and His requirements, as near as I can tell, are simpler than anyone's paperwork suggests.

Show up. Say yes. Abandon the outcome.

Do the best that you can while using all the resources that you have available. Then let go of what happens next, because what happens next was never yours to control.

* * *

I am writing these words in Seoul, South Korea. I have been here since June 1, 1982. I became an honorary citizen of this city in 2005 — the award presented when Lee Myung-bak was the mayor of Seoul. He would later become the President of Korea, the fifth of the five presidents at whose National Prayer Breakfast I served as simultaneous translator. The man who gave me citizenship in his city eventually sat in the room where I translated for the President of the nation. I became a Korean

citizen in 2012. My legal name spelled in Korean is 매쥬스빌리레이. I have a Korean wife and two daughters and sons-in-law and grandchildren who carry both worlds in their blood.

I did not plan any of that. I could not have planned any of that. I got on a plane with nine hundred dollars and a cowboy hat and a one-way ticket, and Jesus led me all the way.

Through the busy and the complicated. Through the shock and the dark and the days without answers. Through the lobby and the hospital and the dormitory room and the jar full of numbers. Through every closed door and every phone call that came one week too late to be comfortable and one week too early to be impossible.

He led me.

Not around the hard things. I want to be clear about that. Not around them — through them. Every single one. The empty arms and the everlasting arms. The gap between the ladder and the hospital room. The names that still slip. The regrets I carry. The unsaid words.

Through all of it.

My mother knew this. She knew it before she had a name for it, before anyone taught her the theology of it. She knew it in her hands and her voice — in the food she cut into equal pieces and the clothes she sewed by lamplight and the song she sang because the joy was real even when the circumstances were not. She gave me to Jesus at forty-two because she had been given to Jesus herself, long before she understood what that meant.

And Jesus led her all the way too.

* * *

Before this book closes, I want to answer a question that followed me from my first week in Gwangju in 1982.

Why did you come to Korea? We don't need missionaries here.

The Koreans who said that were right. For 1982 they were completely right. The Korean church was strong, growing, sending its own missionaries around the world. Korea did not need foreign missionaries coming to introduce Jesus to Koreans. That work was being done — by Koreans, for Koreans, with a depth and effectiveness that no foreigner could match.

But God was not sending me to do that work.

He was sending me early — very early — for a Korea that did not yet exist.

In 1982 Korea was still carrying the legacy of the Joseon Dynasty — centuries of deliberate isolation that had earned it the name the Hermit Kingdom. The country had survived Japanese occupation, survived the Korean War, survived poverty so severe that a generation of children were sent overseas for adoption — partly because there was not enough to feed them, and partly because Confucian culture made it deeply difficult for Korean families to adopt children who were not their own blood. Korea had turned inward to survive. And it had survived. More than survived — it had risen into something remarkable.

Then came 1988.

The Seoul Summer Olympics. The motto said it plainly: The World to Seoul, Seoul to the World. For the first time the world saw Korea on its own terms — not as a war zone, not as a Cold War problem, but as a nation with culture and beauty and capability. And Korea saw the world arriving at its door. Thousands of foreigners walking Korean streets, hearing Korean spoken, tasting Korean food, watching Korean athletes.

Something cracked open in the hermit kingdom's wall that had never cracked before.

That crack became the Korean Wave — Hallyu. K-pop, K-drama, K-beauty, K-food. What the world now knows as a global cultural phenomenon began its first stirring in the soil that the 1988 Olympics turned over. Korea stopped being a hermit and started becoming a host. Then a sender. Then an influencer that the world could not stop watching.

And with the wave came people. Not visitors for two days. People who came and stayed — taking classes, taking jobs, marrying Koreans, building lives. Ethnic Koreans from the diaspora returning to the land their parents or grandparents had left. Non-Koreans falling in love with a culture that was suddenly everywhere. And Koreans themselves — who had never left Korea — who wanted to become more international, to improve their English, to prepare for a world that was now knocking at their door.

The Korea of 1982 did not need what I carried. The Korea that was becoming needed it very much.

* * *

There is one more thing I want to say before this book ends.

About six years after the ladder accident, I met someone new. We talked. I introduced myself. We said goodbye.

Afterward I realized I had not mentioned the accident.

For five or six years after November 25, 1994, the accident introduced itself before I did. Any time I met someone new it found its way into the conversation within minutes. The wound was still defining me before I had the chance to define myself.

And then one ordinary day, in an ordinary conversation, it simply did not come up. I walked away and noticed its absence. I had introduced myself. The accident had not.

That was the recovery. Not the rehabilitation. Not the average at DTS. Not the return to Korea. That quiet ordinary moment — when I forgot to mention it — was when I knew the ladder accident had finished its work on me.

* * *

In 1996 my family returned to Korea. Hanyang University in Ansan opened the door. But Hanyang was never the destination. It was the means of return.

My dream — formed in the hospital bed, sharpened through five years of simultaneous translation at Younknak, clarified through pastoring Korean-American teenagers in Dallas who did not speak Korean fluently or at all — was to serve both the Koreans who were becoming more international and the internationals who were coming to Korea and staying. To find a congregation where two languages could worship together not as guests in each other's spaces but as members of the same family.

In 1997 I began translating at Younknak Church. I shared the dream with the senior pastor — Rev. Lim Youngsoo, my mentor, the man whose single sentence at a hotel dinner had convinced Jakyung to say yes to Dallas. He listened. He set a condition: one year auditing classes full-time at Jeongshin Presbyterian Seminary, while continuing to teach at Hanyang and translate at Younknak every Sunday.

I did all of it.

And then Rev. Lim resigned.

He was gone. An interim pastor came. I continued showing up every Sunday, translating, doing the work, not knowing whether the dream had died with the resignation or was still alive underneath the uncertainty. I did not know who the new senior pastor would be. I did not know whether the door I had

been building toward would open or close when a new man arrived to hold the key.

What I knew was this.

God had sent me to Korea before Korea needed me. He had used every year of the early arrival to prepare me for a Korea that was still arriving. The deportation that felt like rejection had been language school in disguise. The orphanages that felt like detours had been family formation. The ladder accident that felt like an ending had been a rewiring. The years of waiting had not been wasted. They had been preparation.

I had no reason to believe He was finished.

So, I translated every Sunday. I taught at Hanyang. I waited. I did the best I could with the resources I had, and I abandoned the outcome — the way I had been abandoning outcomes since a twenty-one-year-old boy got on a plane with nine hundred dollars and a cowboy hat and no plan beyond the calling.

The dream was real. The Korea that needed it was real. Where and how and when — that belonged to God, the way everything had always belonged to God.

That is where Book One ends.

One last observation, from a man who has watched this country for more than forty years.

When I arrived in 1982, the Korean government was running a campaign. The slogan was simple: * Two is too many. * They were urging families to have fewer children — one, at most two — concerned about population growth and the resources it would require. The campaign worked. Korean families, already moving toward smaller households as the economy grew and the cost of living rose, listened. Birth rates dropped. Then kept dropping. By 2023 Korea's birth rate had fallen to 0.7 — among the lowest on earth. The government

that once said two is too many now desperately needs more people and cannot find them.

I visited a contemporary history museum in Seoul in 2023. They had an exhibit about that campaign. The tone was not pride. It was regret.

I arrived in a Korea that feared too many people. I am writing these words in a Korea that fears too few. The country has changed in ways that no one in 1982 could have predicted — and some of those changes were chosen, and some were consequences of choices, and not all of them led where anyone intended.

That is the Korea I have lived in. That is the Korea that shaped me and that I have, in some small way, helped shape in return.

* * *

I was four years old when my father stopped coming through the door. I did not understand then what I understand now — which is that God was not absent during that loss. He was already arranging the answer to it, the way He arranges answers to things we do not yet know are questions.

I have heard it said this way: do the best you can with the resources available and abandon the outcome. I have been doing that since a twenty-one-year-old boy boarded a plane with nine hundred dollars and a cowboy hat and no plan beyond a calling. Not because I was wise enough to choose it as a philosophy, but because I had no other option. The outcomes were never mine to control. They belonged to the Father who is sovereign — all-knowing, all-powerful, all-loving, and faithful when everything else is not.

Bud could not stay. God could not leave. That is the difference between a human father and a heavenly one. God chose to use an imperfect and incomplete person who could

not do it on his own — and that was never an accident. It was the point. Because a man who cannot do it on his own must rely on the One who can. And the One who can is the same One who arranged a letter in a post office box, a check with one more zero than expected, a phone call one week before a semester began, and a woman who said yes in a rental car at an airport.

He did not give me a father who stayed. He gave me something better — the Father who was already there before I knew to look for Him, who has never once left, and who was sovereign over every outcome I could not control.

The four-year-old boy could not have known that. The man writing these words knows nothing else.

* * *

Book Two — when it is written — will begin with what happened as Bill pursued his calling to be a missionary / pastor.

* * *

Underneath it all — underneath the farm and the camp and the cowboy hat and the ladder and the jar and everything in between — the same arms. Always the same arms.

The eternal God is your refuge.

And underneath are the everlasting arms.

Deuteronomy 33:27.

It was on a sticker inside a book a stranger's organization gave to a missionary student on graduation day in Chattanooga, Tennessee, on May 24, 1982. His mother carried it out of the auditorium without knowing the verse was there. He guided her up the stairs and waited at the edge of the platform and watched her walk across it alone, and then he guided her back down.

Six days later he boarded a plane.

He is still here.

Jesus led him all the way.

* * *

A Note on the Photographs

The photographs behind the links in this book — and a few more — are part of a growing visual archive that spans more than fifty years, from Oklahoma red dirt to Seoul. Each image was chosen because a photograph can hold what words sometimes cannot.

To browse the full album — all photographs from the journey, in the order they appear in the story — visit billmajors.com/book-photos.

* * *

A Note on What Comes Next

The second book is already taking shape.

The story that follows this one picks up where Bill's calling leads him next — into pastoral ministry. The years in Dallas were never just about a degree. Alongside seminary classes, Bill was pastoring an immigrant congregation in two languages, navigating the space where cultures meet and people search for belonging. That experience clarified something. God was not finished with Youngnak Church. Bill was called to return — not only to translate, but to pastor. The international community flowing into Korea — visitors, students, workers, residents — needed a spiritual home. What emerged was International Worship in English, a congregation built for people between worlds.

That story is being written, but it will take time.

www.crossculture-community.com

* * *

The third book is waiting for a miracle to finish.

God gave Bill a dream: a Museum of the Bible in Korea. Not a small dream. A building, a collection, a permanent witness to the Bible as the most influential book in human history — planted in Seoul, one of the great cities of the world. The dream has a name. It has a foundation. And it has a long road ahead. The wise man said you move a mountain one shovel at a time. So the third book will have to wait — until the shovels have done their work and the miracle has a story worth telling.

www.museumofthebiblekorea.org

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Please give me any comments or corrections.

Let's stay in contact with each other too.